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**From Beneventan Script to Digital Interface:
Modeling the Transition from Medieval Manuscript to Early Modern
Print in the *Legenda Sancti Guilielmi***

MASTER CANDIDATE

Michelle De Paola

Student ID 933911

SUPERVISOR

Prof. Franz Fisher

Ca'Foscari University

CO- SUPERVISOR

Dott. Federico Boschetti

CNR-ILC "A. Zampolli"

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Abstract

This thesis examines the application of digital tools to the study and representation of a medieval hagiographical text in Beneventan script, using the *Vita et obitu sancti Guilielmi* as a case study. Rather than producing a traditional critical or fully synoptic edition, the research focuses on the digital workflow that transforms both manuscript and printed images into structured, interoperable, and navigable textual data. The manuscript is transcribed diplomatically using eScriptorium's handwritten text recognition tools, through a model I trained specifically for Beneventan script. The 1581 printed edition is acquired through a separate OCR/HTR workflow. Both texts are encoded in TEI-XML and processed through XSLT transformations to generate an HTML-based research environment. This interface enables multiple modes of scholarly exploration, including synoptic visualizations of selected sections, structured indices, and a geolocated map linking narrative space to historical geography. The sixteenth-century printed edition edited by Felice Renda is approached not as an ecdotic witness, but as a moment of reception and refunctionalization of the medieval text. Digitally aligned passages make visible processes of normalization, institutional rewriting, and devotional restructuring accompanying the transition from manuscript to print. The thesis thus offers both a methodological contribution, by testing digital tools on a non-standard medieval script, and a philological contribution, by demonstrating how digital representation can render visible the material and historical stratification of a hagiographical text. The resulting digital output is conceived as an open and reusable research environment, rather than a definitive textual endpoint.

KEY WORDS

1. Digital Philology
2. TEI-XML
3. Handwritten Text Recognition (HTR)
4. Beneventan Script
5. 1581 Printed Edition

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Introduction

The *Vita et obitu sancti Guilielmi* represents a crucial hagiographical witness for medieval southern Italy, important both for William of Vercelli's cult and for what its textual history reveals about Montevergine's institutional formation. Its role goes beyond storytelling; it acts as both origin tale and historical record, bridging religious lore with factual tracing. A thirteenth-century parchment codex at Montevergine preserves the medieval tradition in two complete copies, written at different times¹. This study focuses exclusively on the Beneventan script redaction, the earliest and least normalized form. The choice follows a clear philological logic: the Beneventan version, with its continuous narrative structure and minimal corrective intervention, stands closest to the primitive phase of transmission and provides the most suitable point of comparison with the first printed witness. A decisive shift occurs with the *editio princeps*, published at Naples in 1581 under Felice Renda's editorship². The sixteenth-century edition does not simply transfer hagiographical narrative into typographic form. It embeds the *Vita* within a substantial volume containing papal and royal privileges, patrimonial inventories, congregational memoranda, liturgical offices. The hagiography becomes part of a coherent editorial project aimed at consolidating Montevergine's spiritual and institutional identity in the post-Tridentine period. The distance separating the medieval Beneventan redaction from the 1581 print, is more than just a matter of years. It represents a material and cultural shift that poses critical questions for textual history: How is a medieval hagiographical narrative received, reorganized, sometimes harmonized during the shift to print? Which transformations belong to typographic mediation and which to the editor's devotional or institutional aims? To what extent does the printed edition alter structure, lexicon, narrative emphasis when set against the earliest manuscript form? Giovanni Mongelli's critical edition made a fundamental contribution by clarifying the

¹ 'Legenda de Vita et Obitu Sancti Guilielmi', Latin parchment manuscript, Montevergine (Mercogliano, AV), 13th century, Codex 1, Abbey of Montevergine, <https://bibliotecastataledimontevergine.cultura.gov.it/collezione-digitale/legenda-de-vita-et-obitu-sancti-guilielmi/>.

² Felice Renda, *Vita et obitu sancti Guilielmi confessoris et heremitaе* (Naples, 1581).

stratification of the manuscript tradition and mapping relationships among medieval redactions³. Yet despite its scholarly authority, Mongelli's edition remains bound by print's limitations and does not offer direct synoptic visualization comparing the medieval manuscript with the first printed text. This thesis occupies a complementary position. It does not propose a new critical edition in the traditional sense, nor does it replace Mongelli's work, rather, it accompanies that work through digital philology's tools. By narrowing the focus to the Beneventan redaction and Renda's 1581 print, this research avoids corpus dispersion and enables a targeted analysis of the cultural and material shifts accompanying the transition to the early modern period. To maintain thematic coherence, the comparison is further restricted to sections directly concerning the figure of Saint William. Consequently, ancillary or documentary materials, though extensive in the sixteenth-century volume, are excluded, as they do not participate in the hagiographical transmission of the *Vita* itself. While the Gothic redaction remains essential for reconstructing the internal history of the medieval tradition, it is utilized here as a philological and historical reference point rather than a subject of direct synoptic alignment. The operational core of this project rests on a sophisticated source-to-interface workflow. A key experimental contribution is the development of a dedicated Handwritten Text Recognition (HTR) model. Given the absence of pre-existing models for Beneventan script, this work constitutes a pioneering attempt to automate transcription within this specific graphic domain. Following transcription, both witnesses are encoded using TEI-XML standards. Through XSLT transformations, this structured data is converted into an interactive HTML environment. The resulting digital ecosystem moves beyond the paradigm of static reading and reconfigures the *Vita* as an interactive and multi-layered research environment. It offers side-by-side alignment of narrative units to expose rhetorical shifts; searchable indices of persons and places and a dynamic map of the sites mentioned, grounding the hagiography in its physical topography. This research offers a double contribution. Philologically, it provides a transparent comparison of the relationship between medieval manuscript tradition and early modern print.

³ Giovanni Mongelli, 'Legenda de vita et obitu s. Guilielmi confessoris et heremite', *Samnium : pubblicazione trimestrale di studi storici regionali*, no. 1960, n. 3/4; 1961, 1/2, 3/4; 1962, 1/2 (1962 1960).

Methodologically, it demonstrates how digital tools, through encoding, modelling, and visualization, render textual complexity structurally visible and analytically interrogable, a shift identified as central to contemporary digital humanities practice⁴.

⁴ On modelling and the epistemological implications of encoding in Digital Humanities, see Fabio Ciotti, “Modellazione e rappresentazione dei dati,” in Fabio Ciotti, *Digital humanities: metodi, strumenti, saperi* (Carocci, 2024).

Chapter I: Saint William of Vercelli and the Hagiographical Tradition

This chapter maps the historical and cultural terrain surrounding William of Vercelli and the hagiographical tradition he inspired. By examining the saint's life, his charisma, and the foundational role of Montevergine, the text reveals the multifaceted function of medieval hagiography: it served not only as a vessel for memory but also as a primary driver for cult-building and an essential institutional anchor. At the center of this context lies the *Legenda de vita et obitu sancti Guilielmi*, traditionally attributed to John of Nusco. This work represents the foundational text for the centuries of textual and spiritual transmission that followed.

1.1 Life, Vocation, and Itinerant Conversion

William of Vercelli emerged during a period of profound religious transformation that swept across Western Europe in the eleventh and twelfth centuries. This era was characterized by a surge in penitential pilgrimages, eremitic revivals, and a renewed longing for a radically evangelical life⁵. William's early vocation was shaped by this climate but also reflected his specific social position. Hagiographical tradition identifies him as a cadet son, a status that, within aristocratic family strategies of the late eleventh century, could limit access to primary inheritance and orient younger sons toward military or ecclesiastical careers⁶. Born probably around 1085 in Vercelli, William embraced renunciation and ascetic discipline young. The sources emphasize his precocious spiritual maturity, his early decision to abandon worldly prospects for *sacra religio*⁷. Rather than leading immediately to a stable monastic profession, his choice inaugurated a period of intense experimentation marked by mobility, bodily mortification, and a progressive

⁵ André Vauchez, *La spiritualità dell'Occidente medievale (secoli VIII-XIII)* (Vita e Pensiero, 1993), 91–105.

⁶ On aristocratic family structures and social imaginaries in feudal society, see Georges Duby et al., *The Three Orders: Feudal Society Imagined* (University of Chicago Press, 1980), 293–305.

⁷ Celestino Mercurio, 'Una leggenda medioevale di San Guglielmo da Vercelli', *Rivista storica benedettina* 1–2, no. A. 1, fasc. 3; A. 2, 5–6 (1906).

detachment from familial and social obligations. Tradition reports that the young William set out for Santiago de Compostela, the symbolic destination of Western Christendom and a privileged site for spiritual renewal. However, he never completed the journey. In the hagiographical record, this interruption is presented not as a failure, but as a moment of decisive vocational discernment⁸. The *Vitae* report that William, tested by fatigue and extreme penance, interpreted this impediment as a divine sign. While some redactions attribute the halt to bodily weakness and exhaustion, others emphasize an inner revelation or spiritual admonition received along the way⁹. Regardless of the specific cause, the episode marks a fundamental turning point: William realized that God was not calling him to a sanctity defined by reaching a distant sacred destination. Instead, his witness was to be rooted in renunciation, obedience, and stability. Within the narrative logic of the text, the unfinished pilgrimage carries paradigmatic weight; the missed destination becomes the sign of a higher vocation. Journey's interruption is reinterpreted as an act of obedience, signaling a shift toward the mission that would eventually take concrete form in southern Italy.

1.2 From Pilgrimage to Eremitism: The Birth of a Foundational Charism

After abandoning his journey to Santiago, William turned definitively toward eremitism. This transition did not reject the penitential logic of pilgrimage but rather transformed it: physical displacement was reoriented into a form of ascetic stability, grounded in *stabilitas*, silence, and daily spiritual discipline¹⁰. The sources insist on corporeal dimension. He undertakes prolonged fasts, nocturnal vigils, voluntary exposure to cold

⁸ Giovanni Mongelli, *La prima biografia di S. Guglielmo da Vercelli fondatore di Montevergine e del Goleto: testo critico latino con la versione italiana a fronte*, Edizioni del Santuario (Montevergine, 1979).

⁹ Giovanni Giacomo Giordano, *Croniche di Monte Vergine nelle quali si tratta delle cose più notabili occorse in detto Monte, prima, e doppo, che in quello fusse edificato il monasterio, & instituita la Congregatione, detta parimente di Monte Vergine, dell'Ordine del Patriarca S. Benedetto. E della Vita, e miracoli del Padre San Guglielmo da Vercelli abbate, e di tutti gl'altri Santi, & Abbati suoi successori fin'a questi nostri tempi*, 1 vol. (1649; Camillo Cavallo, 1649).

¹⁰ On the integration of eremitic movements within the wider framework of ecclesiastical renewal in the eleventh and twelfth centuries, see Raoul Manselli, 'Monachesimo e riforma ecclesiastica (1049–1122). Presentazione della Settimana di Studi', *Rivista di Storia e Letteratura Religiosa* 4, no. 3 (1968), 507–14.

and fatigue. William places himself within an ascetic lineage consciously evoking early Christian eremites from Egypt, Syria, Palestine¹¹. His body became both the site and the instrument of sanctification. Hagiographical tradition underscores that his serenity amidst extreme physical suffering was a sign of divine grace rather than mere natural resilience¹². Yet William's eremitism is never purely individual or antisocial. From earliest stages, his way of life attracts followers who recognize in his conduct not only personal holiness but viable spiritual model. The saint emerges as charismatic hermit, capable of transforming radical asceticism into shared form of life. His authority derives not from written rules or juridical structures but from coherence between teaching and lived example. This dynamic generates the first nuclei of communal life and eventually a network of foundations extending across Irpinia into Apulia. Eremitic withdrawal meets apostolic impulse. William's vocation anticipates eremitism oriented toward community and spiritual guidance rather than absolute solitude.

1.3 Montevergine: Between Eremitic Solitude and Cenobitic Community

The place where William's charism finds fullest expression is Montevergine, a mountainous Irpinian site whose geographical harshness corresponds to the saint's spiritual ideal. Choosing such a location reflects conscious search for separation from the world (*locorum asperitas*), understood not merely physically but as theological condition conducive to spiritual perfection¹³. Montevergine achieved an original synthesis by combining eremitic intensity with cenobitic structure. While the earliest followers preserved strict ascetic features, radical poverty and intense bodily discipline, the gradual adoption of the Rule of Saint Benedict marked the transition toward a stable monastic institution. This dual dimension appears clearly in the *Legenda*, which insists on

¹¹On the construction of the ascetic body and the legacy of early Christian eremitism, see Peter Brown, *The Body and Society: Men, Women, and Sexual Renunciation in Early Christianity* (Columbia University Press, 1988), pp. 213–40, <https://archive.org/details/body societymenwo0000brow>.

¹²Mercuro, 'Una leggenda medioevale di San Guglielmo'.

¹³Mongelli, 'Legenda de vita et obitu s. Guilielmi'. Refer to the "Capitolo II: De inhabitatione Montis Virgini" for the description of *locorum asperitas*.

William's personal radicalism while highlighting his capacity to ensure continuity beyond his lifetime. Montevergine becomes not only physical setting but symbolic and juridical center of his spiritual legacy. The hagiographical narrative contributes decisively by presenting Montevergine's foundation as divinely ordained outcome of William's entire vocational journey.

1.4 Hagiography as the Architect of Sacred Memory

Medieval hagiography operated far beyond the boundaries of modern biography. It was an intentional construction of "sacred memory" rather than a chronological record of facts. The *Vitae sanctorum* served as spiritual mirrors for the community, where virtues and miracles were organized to provide edifying models woven into the fabric of daily monastic life¹⁴. The *Legenda de vita et obitu Sancti Guilielmi* exemplifies this narrative strategy. The text functions as a tool for institutional legitimation on two levels: first, by establishing an uncompromising ascetic ideal of renunciation; second, by anchoring that charisma to the specific soil of Montevergine. The *Legenda* transforms the rugged Irpinian landscape into a "geography of grace," where the monastery is seen not merely as a building, but as a divinely ordained site of spiritual inheritance. A striking example is the reframing of the unfinished pilgrimage to Santiago de Compostela. While a modern reader might see a failed intent, the hagiographer reframes this as a providential "detour." This narrative choice reconciles William's universal ascetic aspirations with the local needs of the Norman South, creating a regional center of gravity for sanctity. By preventing William from reaching the Atlantic, the text justifies his *stabilitas loci*, his permanent rooting in Italy, transforming him from an itinerant pilgrim into the foundational pillar of the Verginian congregation's juridical identity.

¹⁴ For an analysis of memory as a selective and identity-shaping practice in medieval society, see Patrick J. Geary, *Phantoms of Remembrance: Memory and Oblivion at the End of the First Millennium* (Princeton Univ. Press, 1996), 7–12, 177–181.

1.5 The Legenda of John of Nusco: Authority and Authorship

The Legenda's origins are deeply embedded in the community it seeks to define. Tradition, supported by internal evidence, attributes the text to John of Nusco, a monk living close to William as his direct disciple. Composed in Latin between the late 12th and early 13th century, it stands as the "Ur-text" of the Verginian tradition. Producing such a text within the monastery's own scriptorium was a deliberate act of cultural self-definition, ensuring the community maintained control over its foundational narrative. Every subsequent retelling of William's life—vernacular or later liturgical revisions—branches from this primary source. Structure reflects high narrative self-awareness. Unlike later hagiographies subdivided into thematic chapters, the earliest redactions present continuous, rhythmic prose. Within this flow, the author demonstrates remarkable "historical" sensitivity for his time, carefully distinguishing between events witnessed firsthand by monks and those inherited through hearsay. By placing posthumous miracles in a separate, concluding section, the author draws a clear line between the saint's earthly asceticism and the supernatural power he wields from heaven. This structural choice marks the formal transition from charismatic eremitism to a settled, institutionalized religious life¹⁵.

1.6 A Tripartite Function: Memory, Liturgy, and Law

The Legenda was never intended as silent library volume. It is a functional, living document fulfilling triple role for the burgeoning Verginian Order. First, it served as institutional memory, preserving "foundational myths" and radical testimonies of first hermits gathering around William. This was particularly crucial in the context of the Norman Mezzogiorno, where new monastic foundations faced a challenge: asserting identity amidst shifting political and ecclesiastical loyalties¹⁶. Recording these origins

¹⁵ Cosimo Damiano Fonseca, 'L'eremitismo in Occidente nei secoli XI e XII', in *L'eremitismo in Occidente nei secoli XI e XII: atti della seconda Settimana internazionale di studio, Mendola, 30 agosto-6 settembre 1962* (Vita e Pensiero, 1965), 15–25.

¹⁶ See Hubert Houben, *Mezzogiorno normanno-svevo. Monasteri e castelli, ebrei e musulmani* (Liguori, 1996), 41–55, on the institutional setting of monastic foundations in the Norman South.

offered disparate followers a unified sense of identity and purpose. Second, the text was liturgical instrument, designed for reading aloud during the officium. The saint's life words would mingle with monks' prayers. In this setting, the *Legenda* became "liturgical life." Listening served as spiritual communion with the founder. Third, the text functioned as legitimacy shield. New religious orders were frequently viewed with suspicion by established hierarchies. Having documented "Life" emphasizing obedience to divine will and establishment of stable, Benedictine-inflected rule was vital.

1.7 The Evolution of the Cult of Saint William: From Middle Ages to Modernity

The cult's evolution offers a window into how a religious institution manages identity across centuries. Far from static portrait of medieval hermit, William's image has been dynamic construct, reshaped to serve the needs of the cloister, the Counter-Reformation, and modern science. During the medieval period, William's memory remained predominantly internal and local, deeply tied to Montevergine's daily life. The original *Legenda* served as "monastic mirror", text designed not for public but for community of followers sharing the saint's rigorous ascetic path. The cult maintained delicate balance: William's radical personal eremitism versus institutional need for stability. The narrative acted as foundational pillar, legitimizing the community's presence in Irpinian territory by framing William as guardian of local sacred geography ¹⁷. This cult phase was characterized by "sacred intimacy." The saint's life was lived and reread within cloister silence, far from later centuries' spectacular demands. The modern era's advent, especially the late 16th-century post-Tridentine climate, required significant reorganization of William's memory. The *Vita's* editio princeps, curated by Felice Renda in 1581, represents the first major effort bridging medieval monastic tradition and Counter-Reformation's public-facing demands. Renda's work was not merely translation, but a strategic "harmonization" of the saint's life for broader devotional audience. By enriching the narrative with paratexts, papal documents, formal presentation of the Congregation's

¹⁷ For an account of Montevergine's institutional consolidation in the Irpinian territory and the shaping of its historical memory, see Placido Mario Tropeano, *Montevergine nei secoli: dalla capanna al castello* (Edizione Padri Benedettini, 2005), 35–48.

privileges, Renda transformed local monastic story into prestigious historical record. This phenomenon reflects a broader post-Tridentine dynamic in which religious orders increasingly mobilized print culture to consolidate authority and articulate their identity within a centralized Catholic framework a broader¹⁸. Through the medium of print, the rugged, unpolished asceticism of the medieval hermit was strategically softened, giving way to the more formalized and palatable image of a "grand founder." The 17th century brought the cult's evolution to its peak with Giovanni Giacomo Giordano's work, especially his *Croniche di Montevergine* (1649). Writing within Baroque Naples's cultural climate, Giordano significantly reimagined medieval tradition. William became "Baroque Saint", powerful thaumaturge whose sanctity was proven by spectacular miracles rather than quiet discernment¹⁹. Giordano introduced or amplified episodes like the Miracle of the Wolf, where the saint tames a beast that had devoured his donkey. This effectively transformed William from humble God-seeker into master of the natural world. The "unfinished pilgrimage" to Santiago lost its original meaning as vocational crisis moment. Instead, the narrative was absorbed into a triumphant account of divine election. William was no longer portrayed merely as an eremite, but as patriarch and guarantor of the Order's expanding spiritual and temporal authority²⁰. The 20th century brought a shift from devotional embellishment to scientific scrutiny. The medieval manuscript's discovery by Celestino Mercurio in 1906 and subsequent critical edition by Giovanni Mongelli (1960–1962) acted as philological "excavation." This modern intervention allowed scholars to peel back Baroque legend layers and recover the original 12th-century *Legenda* voice²¹. Separating historical core from later ideological

¹⁸ Simon Ditchfield, *Liturgy, Sanctity and History in Tridentine Italy: Pietro Maria Campi and the Preservation of the Particular*, Cambridge Studies in Italian History and Culture (Cambridge Univ. Press, 2002), 82–94.

¹⁹ On the historiographical interpretation of Baroque sanctity and its devotional practices in southern Italy, see Jean-Michel Sallmann, *Santi barocchi: modelli di santità, pratiche devozionali e comportamenti religiosi nel regno di Napoli dal 1540 al 1750* (Argo, 1996), 185–210.

²⁰ For an analysis of the institutional and devotional reshaping of sanctity in the late sixteenth-century Kingdom of Naples, see Giulio Sodano, 'La santità a Napoli nella seconda metà del XVI secolo tra ridefinizione dei modelli e "risposta devozionale"', in *La santità a Napoli nella seconda metà del XVI secolo tra ridefinizione dei modelli e "risposta devozionale"* (1998), 167–190.

²¹ Mongelli, 'Legenda de vita et obitu s. Guilielmi'.

stratifications, modern historiography has restored the human and spiritual complexity of William's original experience. This evolutionary journey demonstrates that a saint's memory is never static. Dynamic mediation process where the present's needs, medieval monasticism, Counter-Reformation prestige, modern historical science, continually reshape the past's image to serve the community's identity²².

²² Geary, *Phantoms of Remembrance*, 7–12, 177–181.

Chapter II. The Manuscript Tradition of the *Legenda Sancti Guilielmi*

This chapter examines the manuscript tradition of the *Legenda Sancti Guilielmi* to define its overall configuration and the philological value of surviving witnesses. By analyzing the Montevergine manuscript, specifically the relationship between its Beneventan and Gothic components, I will outline the internal structure, dating, and stratification of the text. These criteria justify the adoption of the Beneventan witness as the primary reference point for comparison with the 1581 printed edition.

2.1 Establishing the Text and Posing the Problem of the Archetype

The analysis of the manuscript tradition of the *Legenda* transcends mere descriptive codicology or cataloging. To reconstruct the witnesses is to perform a critical act of "establishing" the text: identifying which specific form of William's memory was crystallized, at what historical moment, and within which institutional horizon. The *Legenda* is not merely a narrative of sanctity; it is a semiotic device for identity construction, designed to transform a charismatic, itinerant experience into a stable liturgical and narrative norm for the Verginian community ²³. The tradition is quantitatively narrow, as only two witnesses survive. However, this scarcity does not simplify the philological task; rather, it renders every detail more significant. In such a "closed" tradition, the sequence of hands, page layout, rubrics, and layers of intervention are not ancillary details but essential clues for reconstructive hypothesis. Between the late twelfth and early thirteenth century, a now-lost archetype likely crystallized the Guilielmitic memory, transforming it into an authoritative narrative functional to the burgeoning cult. My investigation seeks to reconstruct the logic of that original fixation, the precise moment when the Order first chose to stabilize its fluid charismatic origins through the permanence of the written word.

²³ On the normative and identity-building function of the *Vita* within the Norman Mezzogiorno and its role in transforming charismatic experience into institutional memory, see Francesco Panarelli, *Scrittura agiografica nel Mezzogiorno normanno: la vita di san Guglielmo da Vercelli* (Congedo, 2004), 45–60.

2.2 Montevergine Codex 1: A "Fictitious" Unity for a Complex History

The cornerstone of the Guilielmite tradition is Manuscript 1 of the State Library of Montevergine. As Giovanni Mongelli demonstrated in his definitive catalogue, this parchment codex is not a unitary creation but a composite volume consisting of two distinct codicological units²⁴. The first, written in Beneventan script, comprises folios 1r–65v; the second, in Gothic bookhand, extends from folios 66r–109v. The perception of single book entity derives partly from modern binding, executed in red-brown Moroccan leather decorated with gold, bearing on the front board the abbey's coat of arms and on the back board Abbot Gian Giacomo Giordano's arms, to whom the binding's care is attributed²⁵. This sumptuous Moroccan leather binding served not merely conservative function but ideological one: placing his own coat of arms on the back board and the abbey's on the front, Giordano "sealed" the Order's history, fusing two distinct textual nuclei into single monumental and authoritative body. Beneath this early modern "skin", the manuscript reveals complex material structure. Its manufacture rigorously follows the "Gregory rule" (also known as vis-à-vis rule), ensuring that when the codex opens, the reader always sees two hair sides or two flesh sides of parchment. Nevertheless, the break between first block (fols. 1r–65v) and second (fols. 66r–109v) is clear and structural, revealing presence of two distinct codicological units. Trimming traces observed in the second unit suggest this nucleus, originally more extensive, was physically reduced to adapt to the first block's format²⁶. A further complexity lies in production geography. Although tradition always identified Montevergine's scriptorium as place of origin, more recent studies invite looking toward the "twin" foundation of San Salvatore al Goleto. Iconographic evidence, connected with reuse of figurative models typical of the Goleto community, and documentary references to figures linked to its dependencies, allow situating the manuscript within broader network of textual circulation ²⁷. Without elevating such indications to definitive proof, they perform important methodological

²⁴ Giovanni Mongelli, *I codici dell'Abbazia di Montevergine* (Edizioni del Santuario, 1959).

²⁵ Giordano, *Croniche di Monte Vergine*.

²⁶ Veronica De Duonni, 'Montevergine: Immagini Su Pergamena' (Università degli Studi di Salerno, 2015), 179–93.

²⁷ De Duonni, 'Montevergine: Immagini Su Pergamena', 73–75.

function: reminding us that the Legenda's transmission cannot be separated from the network of institutions managing its memory, in line with approaches emphasizing social and institutional construction of memory.

2.3 The "Double Witness": Beneventan and Gothic

Within MS 1, the Legenda is attested in two complete copies sharing the same narrative core but belonging to two different graphic and cultural regimes. Their coexistence should not be interpreted as redundant duplication but as historically significant datum, indicating that the founder's memory was transcribed, reorganized, reactivated at different moments, according to changing needs and sensibilities, and that text form was accompanied, if not partly determined, by writing form. The first unit, written in late Beneventan script, appears overall regular and conservative. Employing Beneventan in the thirteenth century, when the European graphic landscape was trending toward more homogeneous and "international" forms, can be read as conscious cultural act. In southern Italy, Beneventan continued functioning as identity marker, closely connected to the Cassinese tradition and to Lombard-southern memory retaining strong symbolic and institutional value²⁸. This choice was not merely emblematic; it carried significant philological consequences. The Beneventan witness preserves a version of medieval Latin characterized by orthographic and graphic oscillations. These should not be dismissed as mere scribal errors but rather understood as traces of a locally connoted *scripta*. From the perspective of a comparative analysis with the 1581 printed edition, these oscillations are of exceptional importance: they allow us to observe clearly the linguistic nuances that early modern transmission, driven by the Council of Trent's push for uniformity, would eventually regularize, normalize, and effectively erase. Page layout further reinforces this interpretation. Rubrics and initials are not merely ornamental but

²⁸ On the Beneventan script as a distinctive and enduring southern Italian tradition closely associated with the Cassinese milieu and Lombard cultural memory, see Elias Avery Loew, *The Beneventan Script: A History of the South Italian Minuscule*, 2nd edn (Edizioni di storia e letteratura, 1980); and Virginia Brown, *Terra Sancti Benedicti: Studies in the Palaeography, History and Liturgy of Medieval Southern Italy* (Edizioni di Storia e Letteratura, 2005).

guide reader engagement with the text and articulate its internal organization. The presence of pen-flourished initials and systematic use of color, with variations highlighting key moments and transitions, point to design intended for communal reading and, most likely, liturgical use. The text is not conceived as neutral object but as functional instrument of memory and communal practice²⁹. The second unit, written in Gothic bookhand and datable to the fourteenth century, introduces significant rupture. Gothic script marks entry into more standardized graphic modernity, compatible with broader horizon of circulation and authority. Here again, script is not mere material container but cultural signal: the text enters new regime of legibility and institutional recognition. The difference is not only formal. On content level, the Gothic branch witnesses expansion of memory: miracles and updates appear that are absent from the Beneventan witness, which scholarship has rightly interpreted as evidence of redactional stratification³⁰. At this stage, the *Legenda* takes shape as "living" text, capable of recording the saint's ongoing protection and documenting, through new episodes, persistence of his charisma within the order. The Gothic copy therefore is not simply second transcription but sign of reception process and internal refunctionalization, shifting focus from foundational narrative to continually updated memory. The figurative apparatus reinforces this orientation. The historiated initials depicting the bearded and haloed saint operate as visual markers of recognition and authority, integrating Guilielmitic memory into a codified visual grammar that strengthens the text's cultic and institutional dimension. Decoration, in this perspective, does not stand at the margins of transmission but constitutes one of its active components, contributing to the construction of legibility and to the stabilization of narrative meaning. As Giulia Orofino has argued in her methodological reflections on medieval miniatures, historiated initials should be understood not merely as ornamental additions but as interpretative devices embedded in

²⁹ J. J. G. Alexander, *The Decorated Letter* (Braziller, 1978), 9–14. For the specific application to Montevergine MS 1, see Veronica De Duonni, 'Montevergine: Immagini Su Pergamena' (Università degli Studi di Salerno, 2015), 182–183.

³⁰ For an early recognition of the layered redactional structure of the *Legenda* and the presence of subsequent expansions, see Emanuele De Palma, 'Intorno alla Leggenda De vita et obitu sancti Guilielmi confessoris et heremitae', *Irpinia* IV (1932): 59–75, 130–52, 341–64, 494–523.

the communicative system of the manuscript, capable of shaping reception and guiding the reader's engagement with the text³¹.

2.4 The Book as a Ritual Object

When considered as an artifact intended for monastic community life, the manuscript's liturgical function cannot be relegated to a merely external context but must be understood as an internal interpretative key. The codex is not designed for private, silent, individual reading; rather, its structure and graphic apparatus suggest performative use, where the text is proclaimed and shared. Rubrics, initials, visual markers guide the reader's eye and render the text "navigable" according to logic functional to public reading³². The second unit further preserves folios with musical notation on four-line staff and square notation, making explicit the ritual and performative horizon to which these materials belong. Especially significant: presence of a sequence for the Mass of Saint William, whose final stanza explicitly invokes the "abbatissam et conventum." This formula is not simple devotional detail but precise indicator of community addressed and text's intended use. In this sense, MS 1 can be understood as manual for the saint's liturgical memory, an object organizing and sustaining ritual repetition and enabling true "staging" of the foundation through text³³. Within this framework, decoration plays structural role. Historiated and pen-flourished initials signal beginnings, hierarchies, key narrative moments, making the cult's subject visible on the page itself. The saint's figure does not merely illustrate the

³¹ Giulia Orofino, "“Leggere” le miniature medievali", in *Arti e storia nel Medioevo, III: Del vedere: pubblici, forme e funzioni*, III (Einaudi, 2004), 469–496.

³² On the functional organization of Italian liturgical manuscripts and the role of rubrics and graphic markers in guiding use, see Bruno Baroffio, 'I manoscritti liturgici italiani: ricerche, studi, catalogazione', *Le fonti della musica in Italia. Studi e ricerche* V (1991): 31–59.

³³ Virginia Brown, 'Il Messale medievale e le Missae votivae: esempi di pratica monastica in area beneventana', in *Il monaco, il libro, la biblioteca* (Edizioni dell'Università degli Studi, 2003). For the specific analysis of the musical sequence in MS 1 and the reference to the Abbess of Goleto, see Veronica De Duonni 'Montevergine: Immagini Su Pergamena' (Università degli Studi di Salerno, 2015), 183–184

text but renders the memory object immediately recognizable and present at the moment when the text is activated by the community.

2.5 Dating and Stratification: the Hands of History

The codex's history does not end with dating its two main units. The manuscript preserves traces of later interventions attesting to prolonged use and learned care internal to the order. Alongside principal hands, a later hand appears, active between the sixteenth and seventeenth centuries, intervening through annotations, corrections, integrations³⁴. These interventions are not philologically neutral: they indicate the text continued being read, consulted, "adjusted," and that in the early modern period, the manuscript remained authoritative reference point for the order's memory³⁵. Notes attempting to date or qualify the text, even when historically unreliable, are themselves philologically significant, revealing a will to authorize and stabilize tradition. The later hand acts as proto-editor: correcting errors, supplementing faded words, reorienting legibility. A fundamental point emerges: in the seventeenth century, Guilielmitic memory is not entrusted exclusively to printed tradition or large-scale early modern hagiographical rewritings but continues anchoring itself in the medieval codex as repository of authority.

2.6 From Materiality to Digital Modeling

Today, the Beneventan redaction presents a final layer of complexity as it transitions into a digital object. The Beneventan script, with its dense abbreviation system, characteristic ligatures, and lack of orthographic standardization, poses a significant challenge to standard HTR (Handwritten Text Recognition) models. In a digital philology framework,

³⁴ On the social and historical life of manuscripts and the stratification of written culture see Armando Petrucci, *Writers and Readers in Medieval Italy: Studies in the History of Written Culture*, ed. Charles Radding (Yale Univ. Press, 1995).

³⁵ For an analysis of the transition from monastic scriptoria to libraries and the enduring authority of manuscripts within institutional memory, see Guglielmo Cavallo, 'Dallo scriptorium senza biblioteca alla biblioteca senza scriptorium', in *Dall'eremo al cenobio: la civiltà monastica in Italia dalle origini all'età di Dante* (Libri Scheiwiller, 1987), 350–80.

these "irregularities" are not noise to be filtered out, but critical informational features of the scripta. Treating them as such requires a move away from fully automated normalization in favor of a model that preserves the manuscript's historical specificity. Consequently, the Beneventan witness serves as the primary testing ground for the experimental workflow detailed in the chapter V. The process of transcription and encoding becomes a critical act of negotiation: balancing the material resistance of the medieval hand with the requirements of computational abstraction. By refusing to erase the traces of historical stratification, this digital approach ensures that the "memory" of Saint William remains as structurally complex in the database as it is in the codex.

Chapter III. From the Legenda to Print: the 1581 Edition

This chapter analyzes the 1581 edition as editorial and institutional operation, situating it within post-Tridentine Naples and Counter-Reformation book production. Particular attention goes to Felice Renda's project, the volume's structure, and narrative and devotional strategies guiding the hagiographical text's rewriting. Within this framework, the printed edition is interpreted as an object of reception and refunctionalization, offering a privileged counterpoint to the Beneventan manuscript for observing processes of textual normalization, stabilization, and reinterpretation in the transition from manuscript culture to print.

3.1 Historical and Cultural Context: Naples and the Counter-Reformation

The 1581 edition belongs fully to the cultural climate of post-Tridentine Naples, a major center for the production and dissemination of religious literature. In this context, hagiographical printing assumed a normative function, aimed at regulating cult practices and shaping religious memory in accordance with Counter-Reformation criteria³⁶. Within this framework, the figure of William is presented not as a subject of historical inquiry, but as a stabilized model of sanctity. The Vita is transformed from a stratified medieval narrative into a harmonized text suited to spiritual edification, a process attested by the presence of ecclesiastical approvals and formal authorization mechanisms³⁷.

3.2 Felice Renda and the Verginian Congregation

The 1581 edition connects closely to Felice Renda, a religious active within the Congregation of Montevergine who promotes broad and articulated editorial project.

³⁶On the normative and confessional functions of hagiographical printing in post-Tridentine Italy, see Ditchfield, *Liturgy, Sanctity and History in Tridentine Italy*, 82–94.

³⁷De Duonni, 'Montevergine: Immagini Su Pergamena', 76. The author highlights how the reorganization of the Verginian book heritage between the 16th and 17th centuries reflects the cultural shift and the new normative function of hagiography analyzed by Giorgio Petrocchi, *La letteratura italiana del tardo Cinquecento*, Letteratura Italiana Laterza 22 (LaTerza, 1968), 158–65.

Renda does not present himself as editor in the philological sense, nor does he show interest in critical reconstruction of the *Legenda's* textual tradition. His role is rather mediator and organizer of Verginian memory, engaged in collecting and ordering heterogeneous materials to offer coherent, authoritative, fully legitimized image of the monastic institution. The *Vita Sancti Guilielmi* thus inserts into overall design including hagiography, juridical documentation, liturgical texts, miracle collections. The compiler's authority derives not from fidelity to medieval witnesses but from his belonging to the order and from the work's ecclesiastical function, conceived as instrument for consolidating institutional identity and promoting cult³⁸.

3.3 Structure and Organization of the 1581 Volume

The text does not present itself as unitary edition of the *Legenda* but as collection organized into thematic blocks, intended for selective and functional consultation. The volume opens with extensive paratextual apparatus: title pages, dedications, prefaces, followed by general and analytical indices of considerable scope. These tools do not perform merely accessory function but orient reader reception from the outset, presenting the work as repertory of contents rather than continuous narrative³⁹. Within this structure, the *Vita Sancti Guilielmi* occupies central but not exclusive position. It coexists with other *Vitae*, particularly those of Amatus and Donatus, never isolated as autonomous foundational text. Alongside the *Vita* develops wide documentary corpus: imperial and papal privileges, juridical confirmations, possession lists, monastic foundations, relic inventories. These materials bear no direct relationship to the *Legenda's* textual tradition but serve historical and patrimonial legitimation function for Montevergine Abbey. Although not direct object of present analysis, their presence contributes to defining

³⁸ On the institutional role of hagiographical authors and the ecclesiastical function of saints' lives in constructing communal identity, see Thomas Head, *Hagiography and the Cult of Saints: The Diocese of Orléans, 800-1200*, Cambridge Studies in Medieval Life and Thought, 4th ser., 14 (Cambridge University Press, 2009), 1–15, <https://doi.org/10.1017/CBO9780511562457>.

³⁹ For an analysis of how early modern printing reconfigured texts into structured and consultable formats that oriented reader reception, see Brian Richardson, *Printing, Writers and Readers in Renaissance Italy*, 1. publ (Cambridge University Press, 1999), 1–25.

ideological framework within which William's Vita is reread and refunctionalized. In this sense, the inclusion of liturgical offices reflects a shift from historical recollection to performative sanctity, reshaping narrative into functional worship. These offices, like hymns, antiphons, responsories, lectiones de vita, participate in the ritualization of memory.

3.4 Narrative and Devotional Strategies

The 1581 edition introduces systematic rewritings that become clear when compared with the manuscript witnesses. These interventions, examined in detail in the Chapter VII, reveal coherent editorial strategy aimed at devotional normalization. Linguistic normalization eliminates medieval oscillations, producing a fluent and uniform Latin prose. Narrative harmonization condenses episodes, smooths transitions, and guides interpretation along a single edifying trajectory. Interpolations introduce explicit devotional formulas, while omissions affect bodily details, extreme ascetic practices, local references, political contexts, and metatextual reflections, including the medieval authorial prologue. These interventions are not the result of faulty transmission, but of deliberate refunctionalization consistent with Counter-Reformation devotional aims.

3.5 Renda between Fidelity and Rewriting

Felice Renda's position thus lies in balance between fidelity and rewriting. He remains faithful to William's spiritual figure and to his experience's symbolic value but intervenes freely in textual material's form and organization. As Monique Goullet has demonstrated in her comprehensive study of medieval Latin hagiography, rewriting of saints' lives ⁴⁰ was a widespread and methodologically significant phenomenon, particularly in monastic contexts where liturgical and devotional needs shaped textual production. The *Legenda* is thus no longer regarded as text to be preserved in its historicity but as source to be used and reorganized according to monastic community needs and cult. The 1581 edition

⁴⁰ Monique Goullet, *Écriture et réécriture hagiographiques: essai sur les réécritures des vies de saints dans l'Occident latin médiéval (VIIIe - XIIIe s.)*, *Hagiologia* 4 (Brepols, 2005), 345–380.

therefore represents not phase in textual tradition but outcome of long reception and reinterpretation process. This interpretative framework echoes Michel de Certeau's notion of "the reorganization of history" through the lens of textual memory ⁴¹ , emphasizing how texts are not merely preserved but reworked within new cultural and institutional horizons. On this basis, the textual comparison undertaken in this study focuses exclusively on the sections devoted to William, understood as a privileged field for observing processes of rewriting and normalization carried out by the printed edition in relation to the manuscript tradition. Such a comparison does not assume an ecdotic character, since the 1581 print does not participate in the process of textual transmission proper, but represents a moment of reception and conscious refunctionalization of an already stabilized text within a new devotional, liturgical, and institutional horizon. The concrete criteria, limits, and digital procedures governing this comparison are defined in Chapter V.

⁴¹ Michel de Certeau, *The Writing of History*, trans. Tom Conley, European Perspectives (Columbia University Press, 1988), 86–112.

Chapter IV – State of Research and Modern Editions of the *Legenda sancti Guilielmi*

This chapter reconstructs the state of research on the *Legenda sancti Guilielmi* and critically discusses the main modern editions, with particular reference to Celestino Mercurio and Giovanni Mongelli's contributions. While acknowledging the decisive role of these studies in recovering, contextualizing, and critically establishing the text, the chapter highlights the methodological limits of print-based scholarship and defines the specific space occupied by the present research within contemporary digital philology.

4.1 Celestino Mercurio and the Rediscovery of the Manuscript

Celestino Mercurio played a decisive role in reviving studies on the *Legenda sancti Guilielmi*, but his principal merit wasn't simply reading the manuscript—it was its historiographical refunctionalization⁴². Before him, the text was often mediated by seventeenth-century compendia or devotional summaries that had smoothed away its asperities and linguistic peculiarities. Mercurio grasped that the Beneventan manuscript at Montevergine was not just one copy among many but the "source text" for understanding the Congregation's identity. He intuited that choosing Beneventan script indissolubly linked William's cult to the great monastic tradition of southern Italy—Monte Cassino, Benevento—conferring on the *Legenda* a "national" dignity beyond merely local significance⁴³. He strongly emphasized the caesura between *Vita* (ascetic itinerary and peregrinatio) and *Miracula* (charisma management after death), grasping that this structure served to legitimate abbatial power's continuity: the Saint continues living through protecting his community. In an era of monastic reforms, returning to John of Nusco's text reminded the community of its original eremitic roots, counterposed to excessive institutionalization pressures. However, Mercurio's approach remains

⁴² Mercurio, 'Una leggenda medioevale di San Guglielmo'.

⁴³ Guglielmo Cavallo, *Rotoli Di Exultet Dell'Italia Meridionale* (Edizioni di Storia e Letteratura, 1975), 31–45; Milvia Zanni, 'La scrittura beneventana: contesto, caratteristiche, diffusione', *Scrineum Rivista* 9 (2012), 160–62.

predominantly historical-descriptive and reflects an earlier historiographical tendency to privilege textual content over the material conditions of its transmission⁴⁴. For Mercuro, the codex was transparent vehicle of message. Missing was that sensitivity (which would mature only with "New Philology") toward material aspects: interlinear corrections, hand variations, usage stains revealing how the text was actually read during liturgy. The manuscript is valued as historical document but not fully interrogated as complex philological object. His translation, though excellent for the era, tended sometimes to normalize the "dirty" and vital medieval Latin, losing syntactic nuances indicating stratification of different oral or written sources.

4.2 Giovanni Mongelli and the Critical Edition

Decisive advancement on the philological level is owed to Giovanni Mongelli (1905–1981), author of the first modern critical edition ⁴⁵. Mongelli's work represents an indispensable reference point, finally offering text established according to scientific criteria, founded on analysis of the two known witnesses: the codex in Beneventan script and the one in Gothic book hand. Yet Mongelli's contribution cannot be understood as isolated philological operation but as natural extension of his monumental work on the *Regesti di Montevergine*. The edition (1940, then incorporated into subsequent studies through the 1960s) marks an epistemological break: it transforms the *Legenda* from hagiographic narrative to network document. Mongelli did not limit himself to transcribing the text but "anchored" it to the abbey's diplomatic reality. Every miracle, every movement of William between Monte Virgiliano and the lands of Puglia, was verified through comparison with parchments from the Verginian collection. For Mongelli, the *Legenda* is not only text but narrative index of the Congregation's patrimonial expansion. If the text narrates a cell's foundation, Mongelli seeks the corresponding donation act in the *Regesto*. In Digital Humanities terms, Mongelli's

⁴⁴ On the integration of writing practices and material support in the history of written culture, see Petrucci, *Writers and Readers in Medieval Italy*, 1–18.

⁴⁵ Mongelli, 'Legenda de vita et obitu s. Guilielmi'.

method may be described, metaphorically, as an analogue form of relational or “linked” data organisation, insofar as it systematically connected persons, places, episodes, and documentary references within a structured historiographical framework⁴⁶. His method is characterized by careful comparison of readings, accompanied by precise critical apparatus recording significant variants. He resolved with philological rigor the attribution question, consolidating the thesis of John of Nusco as primary author. His ecdotic effort aimed to clean the text from late-medieval encrustations and Baroque “normalizations,” restoring the language to that “hybrid” and vital Latin, infused with Beneventanisms, characterizing the twelfth-century Verginian scriptorium. The results achieved can be considered definitive on the ecdotic level, there is no need today for a new critical edition in the strict sense. However, precisely this “definitive” character highlights structural limitations linked to book-form and print conventions⁴⁷. Despite its monumental value, Mongelli’s edition presents limits that modern Digital Philology now brings to light. First, textual fixity: Mongelli presents a *constitutio textus*. He perceives variants as “errors” or “deviations” from an ideal archetype, losing the possibility of analyzing the hagiographic text’s *mouvance*. The critical apparatus, though precise, remains subordinate to establishing a single authoritative reading rather than documenting textual variation as constitutive element of tradition. Second, marginalization of material aspect: The interaction between text and image, such as the relationship between the miniatures and the narrative, remains unexplored. Mongelli lacked the semiotic sensitivity to see page layout and decoration as integral to liturgical performance. Third, a confessional positioning may be observed. Mongelli’s investigation remains situated within the Benedictine scholarly tradition, which, while ensuring profound theological competence, tends to privilege internal spiritual continuity over the analysis of political

⁴⁶ On the conceptual transition from material textual networks to digital data models, see Cristina Dondi, ‘Printed Books and the History of Their Transmission: From the Material to the Digital’, *Studi Di Memofonte* 26 (2021): 12–15.

⁴⁷ For a reflection on how digital philology reconfigures editorial practice and reshapes the presentation of medieval textual traditions, see Teodolinda Barolini, ‘Medieval Texts and Digital Editions: A New Philology?’, *Dante Studies*, 2007, 1–15.

and institutional tensions embedded in the text.⁴⁸ Finally, the print format itself imposes constraints. Mongelli's edition, bound to linear page succession, cannot offer synoptic visualization between witnesses. Reconstructing variants requires navigating a complex apparatus and specialized competence.

4.3 The Digital Gap: Script, Method, and Interface

From a methodological perspective, a significant gap emerges. No previous study has applied Handwritten Text Recognition (HTR) techniques to Beneventan script, nor has any dedicated HTR model been developed for this writing system. As a result, Beneventan manuscripts remain largely excluded from large-scale digital transcription workflows. Similarly, no existing digital edition addresses the *Legenda sancti Guilielmi*, and no digital project has attempted to encode, visualize, and compare such material while preserving its graphic and linguistic specificity. Finally, existing digital resources do not provide an interface that integrates textual structure, spatial references, and narrative organization in a unified environment. Text, place, and structure are typically treated as separate layers, rather than as interrelated dimensions of meaning. The present research positions itself within this methodological gap. By training a custom HTR model for Beneventan script, encoding both manuscript and printed witnesses in TEI-XML, and generating an interactive HTML interface through XSLT transformations, the project aims to overcome the limitations of print-based scholarship. The resulting digital environment enables synoptic comparison, spatial visualization, and structural navigation, making visible processes of rewriting, normalization, and refunctionalization that remain implicit in traditional editions. In this way, the thesis does not replace existing scholarship, but extends it methodologically, offering new tools to study the transmission and reception of the *Legenda sancti Guilielmi* from the medieval manuscript to the post-Tridentine printed book.

⁴⁸ On the historiographical implications of confessional perspectives in the study of the Christian Middle Ages, see John Van Engen, 'The Christian Middle Ages as an Historiographical Problem', *The American Historical Review* 91, no. 3 (1986): 530–45, <https://doi.org/10.1086/ahr/91.3.519>.

Chapter V – Digital and Philological Methodology

This chapter defines the methodological framework of the research, outlining the principles and practices adopted for the construction of a digital comparative research environment devoted to the *Legenda de vita et obitu sancti Guilielmi*. The comparison is deliberately restricted to the textual units devoted to Saint William⁴⁹. These segments constitute a coherent and homogeneous textual nucleus, suitable for observing processes of rewriting, normalization, and devotional reorientation. The purpose of this chapter is not to provide a technical description of software tools, but to make explicit the theoretical, philological, and digital assumptions that guided the editorial choices developed during the research. The digital dimension is not treated as a layer of visualization added after the fact, but as a critical device that structures the entire workflow: from image acquisition to transcription, from textual modeling to comparative visualization. In this sense, the digital environment functions as a space of verification, in which the relationships between source images, transcriptions, and interpretative choices remain transparent, inspectable, and reversible. This approach reflects a conception of digital philology in which the edition is not a fixed endpoint, but an experimental and reflexive process, capable of exposing its own conditions of construction. The transition from medieval manuscript to early modern print is thus examined into machine-readable data. The chapter is organized into six sections. Section 5.1 establishes the theoretical foundations of the digital comparative approach, focusing on material philology, the centrality of textual variation, and the inseparability of image and text as a condition for transparency and scholarly verifiability. Section 5.2 defines the criteria adopted for transcription and normalization, with particular attention to graphematic transcription as the base representational level. This choice preserves the reversibility of the data and allows both philological interpretation and computational interrogation without flattening graphic specificity.

⁴⁹ Within the eScriptorium workspace, these units correspond to items 7–27 for the manuscript witness and items 5–21 for the printed edition.

Section 5.3 discusses the selection of digital tools through a comparative assessment of eScriptorium and Transkribus, highlighting the methodological implications of adopting an environment oriented toward scholarly control, traceability of operations, and explicit modeling of editorial intervention. Section 5.4 focuses on the encoding phase, describing how the transcribed texts are formally modeled using the TEI-XML standard. This stage concerns the transformation of the normalized transcription into a structured, machine-readable document compliant with the TEI schema. Section 5.5 addresses the transformation phase, in which the encoded TEI-XML data are rendered into a navigable research interface through XSLT (Extensible Stylesheet Language Transformations). Finally, Section 5.6 clarifies the controlled and explicitly role of Artificial Intelligence within the research workflow.

5.1 Theoretical Premises

The adopted approach aligns with material and book-historical perspectives that foreground the physical conditions of textual production and transmission, challenging any conception of the text as a purely abstract sequence of signs⁵⁰. In the Beneventan manuscript, the material dimension emerges as a structuring element of textual transmission. The parchment support, far from being homogeneous, displays clear variations in thickness, surface preparation, and transparency, which directly affect the graphic rendering of the script (Figure 1). Translucency of the support frequently allows the text of the verso to interfere visually with the recto, while undulations and structural tensions, especially along the fold of the bifolium, condition the regularity of the written surface. Ruling, plausibly executed dry, is generally perceptible but uneven, with notable differences in pressure and visibility across the folios (Figure 1). Such variability suggests a preparation practice that was not rigidly standardised, consistent with an internal monastic production rather than with a professional book workshop. Nevertheless, the

⁵⁰ See for example Peter Stallybrass, 'Against Thinking', *PMLA* 122, no. 5 (2007): 1580–87; Roger Chartier, *L'ordine dei libri. Letture, scritture, biblioteche in Europa tra XVI e XVIII secolo* (Laterza, 1994), 3–22.

overall organisation of the text in columns and the management of margins point to a conscious planning oriented towards legibility and continuous use.

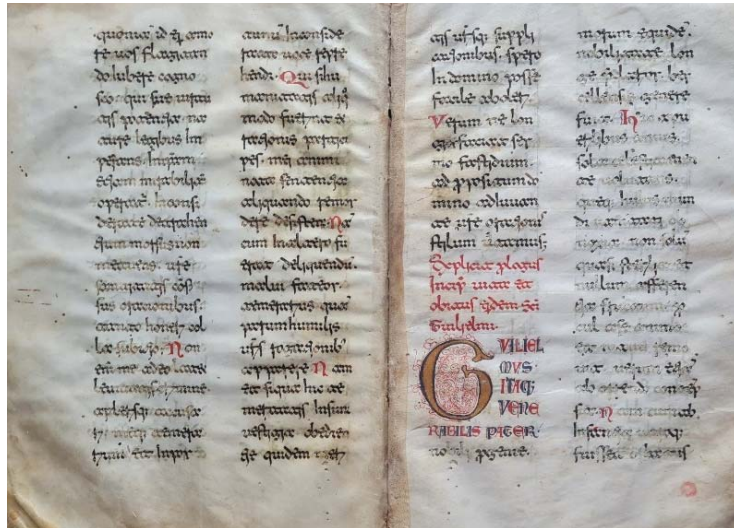


Figure 1 Inner bifolium of the section written in Beneventan script, showing evident transparency of the support, irregular dry ruling, and uneven ink absorption.

At the palaeographical level, the Beneventan script presents an overall regular ductus, though not without oscillations in stroke modulation, letter formation, and interlinear spacing. These fluctuations appear to result from the interaction between writing gesture and material conditions, such as the differing absorbency of the parchment or the variable consistency of the ink, rather than from changes of hand (Figure 2).

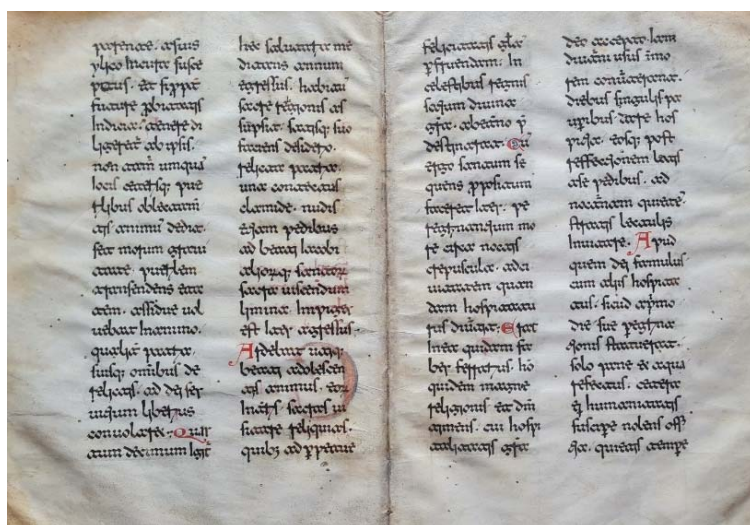


Figure 2 Detail of a column on undecorated parchment, representative of fluctuations in ductus and stroke modulation resulting from the interaction between the writing gesture and the material support.

The ink, predominantly brown, displays discontinuities in intensity and occasional chromatic alterations, further supporting the hypothesis of non-homogeneous preparation or interventions carried out at different moments. Rubricated initials and sporadic decorative elements contribute to structuring the text visually, signalling internal articulations and thresholds. The more elaborate decoration at the opening of the *Legenda* (Figure 3) contrasts with the sobriety of the rest of the manuscript, suggesting a functional hierarchy in which decoration fulfils an orientative and symbolic role rather than a purely ornamental one.

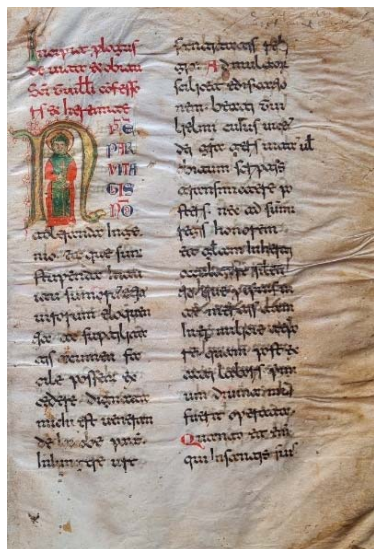


Figure 3 Opening page of the *Legenda sancti Guilielmi*, with a historiated initial and more elaborate rubrication, indicative of a textual and symbolic threshold.

The 1581 editio princeps presents a radically different material framework when compared to the Beneventan manuscript tradition. Whereas the manuscript exposes the text as a graphic event, inseparably bound to the gesture of writing and to the contingencies of its material support (Fig. 3), print substitutes this processual dimension with a stabilized and normative product. As argued by Elizabeth Eisenstein in her analysis of the printing revolution, typographic reproduction does not merely transmit texts but fundamentally reshapes their material and cultural status⁵¹. In the printed *Vita Sancti Guilielmi*, typographic uniformity, regular page layout, and standardized mise en page impose a visual order that effaces traces of production and variation (Figure 4). The page is governed by a consistent typographic grid, stable letterforms, and predictable spatial organization, presenting the text as concluded and authoritative rather than as the result of an ongoing graphic process. In this context, materiality no longer registers the act of writing but instead functions as a guarantee of textual fixity.

⁵¹ Elizabeth L. Eisenstein, *The Printing Press as an Agent of Change: Communications and Cultural Transformations in Early-Modern Europe ; Volumes I and II*, Reprint., combined paperback ed (Cambridge Univ. Press, 1997), 113–63.

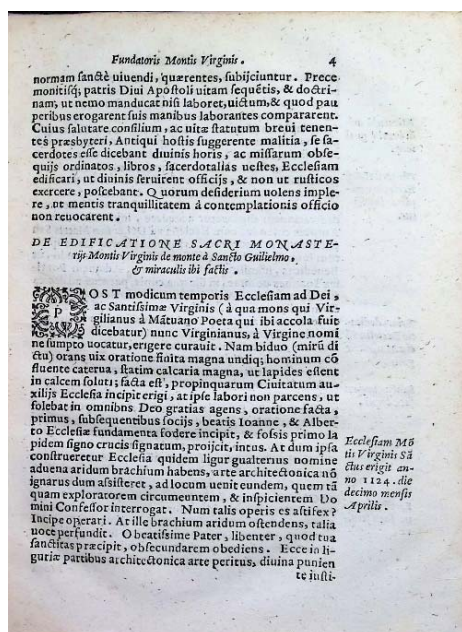


Figure 4 Internal page of the 1581 editio princeps of the Vita Sancti Guilielmi, exemplifying typographic uniformity, regular layout, and standardized mise en page

This effect is further reinforced by the presence of an articulated paratextual apparatus. Titles, running headers, pagination, and printed marginalia guide the reader's interpretation and usage of the text, orienting it toward devotional and institutional purposes (Figure 5). The Vita is thus integrated into a broader editorial architecture, no longer standing as an autonomous narrative but as one component within a structured post-Tridentine dossier that includes other vitae, documentary materials, and liturgical offices. This reconfiguration reflects broader transformations in late sixteenth-century religious print culture, where textual authority was increasingly shaped through editorial framing, compilation, and institutional ordering rather than through isolated narrative transmission⁵².

⁵²On the transformation of textual authority and editorial organization in Renaissance Italian print culture, see Richardson, *Printing, Writers and Readers in Renaissance Italy*, 1–25.

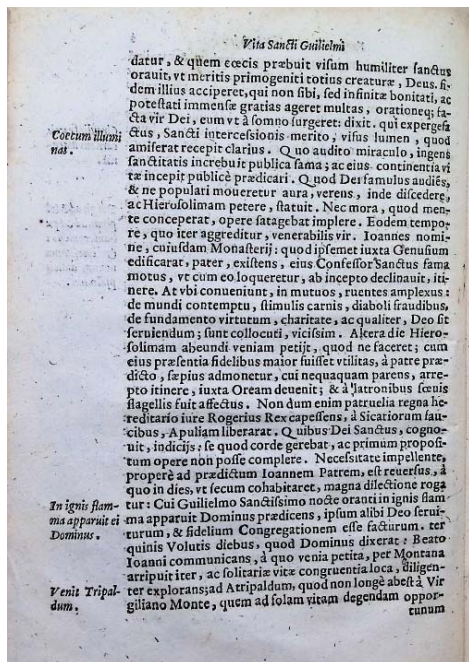


Figure 5 Printed marginalia and running title, illustrating the paratextual orientation of reading and interpretation

The frontespiece of the volume, with its explicit title, authorial framing, and engraved iconography of Saint William, visually encapsulates this transformation (Figure 6). Here, the saint is no longer introduced through the singularity of a manuscript opening page, marked by selective decorative investment, but through a reproducible and institutionally sanctioned image-text ensemble. The frontespiece asserts editorial authority and semantic closure, positioning the *Vita et Obitus Sanctissimi Guilielmi* as a definitive and normative account.



Figure 6 Frontispiece and opening, asserting editorial authority through iconography and typographic hierarchy.

Material philology, applied comparatively, makes clear that textual transmission operates not only through acts of reading and copying but through material conditions determining a text's form, authority, and function.

5.1.1 Visualization of variance

A second theoretical premise of this study is the centrality of the variant. Rather than being treated as a "disturbing element" to be eliminated through emendation, the variant is understood as vital historical and interpretative evidence. This approach aligns with Paul Zumthor's foundational concept of medieval *mouvance*, which posits that a medieval text is never a static entity but exists in a state of constant flux and recreation⁵³. In Beneventan manuscript, variant manifests itself already at material and graphic level. Ductus oscillations, ink differences, variations in rubricatory care, micro-deviations in mise en page make perceptible that text is not immobile entity but result of process. Even without witness plurality, manuscript preserves traces of redactional dynamic and use

⁵³ Paul Zumthor, *Toward a Medieval Poetics* (University of Minnesota Press, 1992), 44–52.

practices affecting text form. Conversely, in the 1581 editio princeps, the variant is structurally made invisible. Print presents no apparatus and proposes linguistically and narratively uniformed text. Tradition plurality gets canceled in favor of single stabilized version, coherent with pastoral and disciplinary needs of post-Tridentine age. The differences emerging from this comparison are not "ecdotic variants" in the strict sense, that is, alternative readings produced by competing copies. They must be read as traces of rewriting and normalization, through which *Legenda* gets refunctionalized. Variant thus becomes indicator of cultural horizon change and text function, more than problem to resolve editorially.

5.1.2 Image–Text Relationship

The third premise concerns the relationship between image and text, central to digital humanities, as highlighted by Drucker's critique of "invisible graphics"⁵⁴. In the medieval manuscript, the text coincides with its graphic and material presence: script, spatial layout, rubrication, and support are integral components of the witness. Any transcription therefore introduces an unavoidable gap between object and representation. In this project, that gap is addressed through a division of functions between environments. Image-based verification is performed within the transcription workspace: in eScriptorium, the manuscript and printed-page images remain continuously available alongside the diplomatic transcription, enabling line-by-line control of segmentation, recognition output, and editorial correction. The image is thus treated as a condition of verifiability and as an interpretative instrument within the HTR workflow. The web interface generated from TEI-XML through XSLT serves a different purpose. It does not currently incorporate page facsimiles; instead, it provides a structured and navigable representation of the encoded text, enabling synoptic visualization of selected sections, indices, and spatial exploration through a geolocated map. In this sense, the digital edition does not collapse image and text into a single display layer, but maintains a

⁵⁴ Johanna Drucker, *Graphesis: Visual Forms of Knowledge Production*, MetaLABprojects (Harvard university press, 2014), 125–130.

methodological link between them: the image anchors transcription and validation in the workspace, while the TEI-driven HTML interface supports analytical navigation and comparative reading.

5.2 Transcription and Normalization Criteria

Defining transcription criteria represents a central methodological junction of the entire work, since it determines how text gets extracted from material support, made readable, and subsequently interrogable both by editor and by digital tools. This thesis adopts graphematic transcription: a model that preserves the sequence of written signs and reduces formal variants to a coherent alphabetic system, without modernizing the language or normalizing the text ⁵⁵. This choice positions itself consciously in intermediate position between allographic transcription and normalized transcription. In particular allographic transcription, while offering extremely detailed restitution of writing, proves difficult to sustain in project aiming to construct broad, coherent, interrogable corpus, especially in HTR usage context. Systematic distinction of all formal variants of same letter would entail exponential increase in complexity, rendering transcription onerous, potentially incoherent, and ultimately little exploitable both for model training and for comparative philological analysis. As highlighted by recent methodological reflection, excessively imitative transcription also risks shifting attention from text to pure sign form, generating ambiguities and increasing human error margin. On the other hand, normalized transcription, which resolves abbreviations, regularizes spelling, introduces modern conventions, would entail significant information loss relative to source. Normalization presupposes interpretative choices not belonging to text acquisition phase but to subsequent moment of analysis or edition. Applying it prematurely would mean making invisible phenomena crucial for studying manuscript tradition, such as graphic variability, abbreviation use, morphosyntactic oscillations. In a digital philology framework, graphematic transcription offers three structural benefits: It

⁵⁵ Ariana Pinche, *Guide de transcription pour les manuscrits du Xe au XVe siècle* (2022), HAL, <https://hal.science/hal-03697382>.

maintains a clear distinction between the witness level (what is on the page) and the interpretative level (editorial intervention). By preserving original punctuation and abbreviations, the text remains a verifiable "starting datum" that can later be subjected to automated normalization or linguistic annotation without compromising the source. Automatic recognition models learn more effectively from homogeneous data. Reducing allographic variants while keeping abbreviations intact allows for the creation of more robust Ground Truth data. This ensures the model is trained on a coherent system rather than contingent editorial guesses. By remaining faithful to the material datum while using a systematic sign system, the transcription provides a solid foundation for the synoptic comparison between the medieval witness and the 1581 edition. The resulting transcribed text is not a static byproduct but a dynamic base for a chain of successive treatments—both manual and automatic—ensuring the path from parchment to data remains transparent and scientifically sound.

5.2.1 Operative Criteria of Graphematic Transcription

Applying the principles of graphematic transcription, the thirteenth-century manuscript was processed according to specific operative criteria. These choices prioritize internal coherence and philological control, ensuring the corpus is optimized for both digital interrogation and comparative analysis. The primary objective was to represent the grapheme sequence while eliminating allographic distinctions that do not carry phonological or morphological weight. Regarding oscillations between u and v, all occurrences of sign v were systematically uniformed to u, since distinction between two signs, in medieval graphic system, has no phonological or morphological value but reflects simple form variation dependent on ductus or position in line (Figure 7).



Figure 7 Detail of Beneventan script illustrating graphic oscillations between u and v.

Analogous criterion was applied to alternations between i and j, with systematic reduction of j to i, thus avoiding introduction of modern-type graphic distinction (Figure 8).



Figure 8 Alternation between i and j in Beneventan script. The form j was systematically reduced to i.

Concerning specificities of Beneventan script, long s and long r were traced back respectively to graphemes s and r. Although such forms can be represented, in digital encoding context, through specific characters proposed by Medieval Unicode Font Initiative (MUFI)⁵⁶, the choice was made not to adopt them, since they register purely formal variation lacking distinctive value on graphematic plane. Their use would have shifted transcription toward allographic level not coherent with work's methodological approach and potentially problematic for data interoperability and HTR employment. Analogous graphematic reduction was applied to capital letter treatment. All capital I

⁵⁶ 'MUFI Character Reference – R', MUFI, <https://www.mufi.info/q.php?p=mufi/chars/char/R>.

present within word or line were traced back to lowercase, as interpretable as module variations or graphic emphasis. Capital I were instead maintained exclusively in cases where they mark period beginning and result rubricated in red, since in such occurrences the letter performs structuring and visually marked function within text organization.



Figure 9 Detail exemplifying the use of long s and long r in Beneventan script. These forms were reduced to the base graphemes s and r.

Particular attention was finally reserved for treating sign &. All occurrences were normalized to e, except in cases where sign clearly presents conjunction value (et). In such circumstances, sign was maintained as indicator of autonomous lexical unit, as bearer of distinct semantic value not reducible to simple graphic variant of vowel.



Figure 10 Detail showing the use of the sign & within the manuscript text. The sign was normalized to e except where clearly functioning as the conjunction et.

5.2.2 Transcription Criteria for 1581 Print

The transcription of the printed witness avoids modernizing the text, focusing instead on establishing a uniform data layer compatible with the manuscript corpus. As in the manuscript, the distinction between u/v and i/j in 16th-century Latin typography remains largely positional or aesthetic rather than phonological. Consequently, all occurrences of v were regularized to u, and j was reduced to i. This systematic reduction ensures seamless interoperability between the two corpora while allowing for potential re-differentiation during the TEI encoding phase. (Figure 11). Regarding use of long s form variant (ſ), systematic reduction to grapheme s was proceeded with (Figure 11). Analogous attention was reserved for capital letter treatment. The transcription avoids imposing modern capitalization rules. Only letters explicitly marked as capitals in the source—such as section initials, titles, or proper names in relief (e.g., *S. GVILIELMVS* or *Diui Guilielmi Ciuis tui*), were maintained. No automatic capitalization was applied to sentence beginnings if the print did not explicitly provide it. This preserves the graphic system of the *editio princeps* without superimposing extraneous grammatical criteria. (Figure 11).

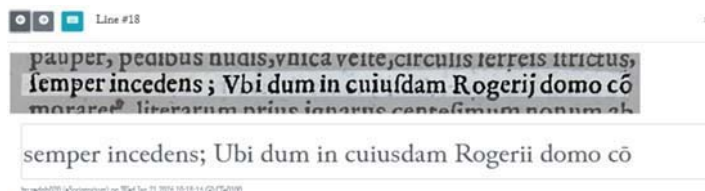


Figure 11 Detail from the 1581 editio princeps illustrating non-distinctive graphic variation (u/v, i/j, long s, and capitalization).

Particular relevance assumes finally treatment of accented vowels. Direct examination of 1581 edition shows accent presence is extremely rare, irregular, lacking systematic coherence. Such signs do not respond to recognizable rule nor perform stable distinctive function on phonological, grammatical, or semantic plane. They seem rather to fulfill occasional functions, like reading support or momentary ambiguity resolution. In absence of systematic employment, that is, regular, repeated, functionally motivated use, accents were not conserved in graphematic transcription. This choice proves coherent with humanistic and post-humanistic Latin practice, where accent is not part of ordinary graphic system and prosody is generally taken as acquired. Systematic accent use affirms

itself in other linguistic and textual contexts, like Greek, later-age vernacular, or didactic texts, but doesn't characterize late sixteenth-century Latin hagiographies. In addition The symbol & was retained whenever it clearly functioned as the conjunction et.



Figure 12 Sporadic accentuation and conjunctive use of & (et) in the 1581 editio princeps.

By applying these criteria to both witnesses, the research creates a coherent and controllable base for digital comparative analysis. This approach reduces purely formal "noise" while highlighting significant graphic elements. The differences between the manuscript and printed traditions are thus not erased, but are shifted to the encoding and analysis phases, where they can be articulated in an explicit and reversible manner.

5.2.3 Abbreviation Expansion

A further crucial aspect of transcription methodology concerns treatment and expansion of abbreviations. Different criteria were necessarily adopted for manuscript written in Beneventan script and for 1581 editio princeps, in accordance with distinct graphic systems and degrees of standardization characterizing the two witnesses. In the printed edition, abbreviations are relatively limited in number and largely conform to typographic system already stabilized by late sixteenth-century humanistic practice. Most abbreviated forms are easily reducible to presence of titulus or to conventional signs whose expansion doesn't pose interpretative difficulties. Typical examples include the suspension of nasal consonants marked by a horizontal stroke (e.g. cō for con, dō for dominus), the use of the titulus over vowels to indicate omitted m or n (e.g. quādo for quando), standard abbreviations for frequent function words or morphemes, such as q̃ for qui/quae/quod or ē for est, while the ampersand-like sign 7 regularly stands for et. Such forms admit

unambiguous expansion on the basis of context and convention, without requiring palaeographical inference or interpretative negotiation ⁵⁷. The situation differs significantly in Beneventan manuscript, where abbreviation constitutes integral and structurally pervasive component of graphic system. Here, abbreviations are not merely space-saving devices but participate fully in script logic, interacting with ductus, ligatures, and local scribal conventions. Their interpretation requires palaeographical approach grounded in specific traditions of Beneventan writing, rather than reliance on generalized medieval Latin norms⁵⁸. Expansion of Beneventan abbreviations was carried out with particular caution and consistency. A dedicated exemplificative table (see below Table 1) has been prepared, systematically correlating abbreviated forms attested in manuscript with their resolved transcription ⁵⁹. This table functions both as methodological transparency tool and as reference framework ensuring internal coherence across corpus, especially in cases where same abbreviation may admit multiple potential expansions depending on context. The adopted approach aims to balance fidelity to manuscript's graphic system with requirements of graphematic transcription and digital processing. Abbreviations are resolved to make text legible and computationally tractable⁶⁰.

⁵⁷ 'Cappelli Online', Ad Fontes – University of Zurich, Universität Zürich, <https://www.adfontes.uzh.ch/en/ressourcen/abkuerzungen/cappelli-online>.

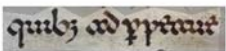
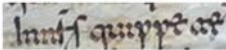
⁵⁸ Loew, *The Beneventan Script: A History of the South Italian Minuscule*, 153–225.

⁵⁹ Aaron Macks, *Reading and Writing Beneventan Minuscule* (2016).

⁶⁰ The complete normalized transcriptions of both the Beneventan manuscript and the 1581 printed edition are provided in Appendix A, ensuring full methodological transparency and allowing the reader to verify the consistency of the editorial and encoding choices described above.

TABLE 1 *SELECTED BENEVENTAN ABBREVIATIONS WITH THEIR EXPANDED FORMS.*

Abbreviations characters	Abbreviations represented through MUFI-compliant characters with &entityname	Facsimile image	Contextualized diplomatic transcription	Expansion of abbreviated forms in the interpretative transcription.
	p		nis plustrans.	nis (per-)lustrans
	p		gue . pmptius re	gue (pro)pmptius re
	p̄		p̄sto facultas.	(prae-)sto facultas.
	nō		humilitatis nō	humilitatis no(n)
	ei		quonia id ei amo	quoniam id e(ius) amo
	ē		arduissimum ē	arduissimum e(st)
	ꝛ		soluent. Hoc ita	soluent(-ur). Hoc ita
	q;		chilq; karitatis	chiliq(-ue) karitas

	^s a		torum. caritā ^s	torum carita(-s)
	m̄		qm̄ que sit nri	q(uonia)m que sit nostri
	^a q		manitatis aliq̄	manitatis aliq(uod)
	b'		ur̄is rogationib'	vostris rogationib(-us)
	b;		quib; ad ppetue	quib(-us) ad perpetue
	rī		in nosr̄is quippe tē	In n(ostris) quippe tem
	⁷ a		brutorum etia ⁷	brutorum etia(-m)
	z		gio: Ad multoz	gio: Ad multo(-rum)

	p		facultatis expmere	facultatis exp(ri)mere
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5.3 Choice of Digital Tools

The choice of digital tools is itself a methodological decision. This project adopts eScriptorium as its primary working environment, following a comparative evaluation with other platforms such as Transkribus. eScriptorium is an open source platform dedicated to analysis, segmentation, and transcription of historical documents, developed within the Scripta-PSL program at PSL University in Paris. Its design responds to the need for creating a working environment capable of integrating advanced computational tools with direct scholarly control, positioning itself as alternative to models that rigidly separate manual transcription from automatic text recognition processes⁶¹. The distinctive element of eScriptorium resides in this methodological approach: it functions as a hybrid system where AI assists rather than replaces philological judgment. Unlike fully automated "black box" systems, the platform allows for granular control over every phase of the process—from the segmentation of page regions (text, margins, images) to the final transcription. This flexibility is essential for the thirteenth-century Beneventan witness. The script's inherent complexities—dense abbreviations, material damage, and graphic variations—require a workflow where manual corrections are not just possible, but central to the process. By ensuring that every intervention is documented and reversible, eScriptorium maintains a verifiable link between the digital data and the material document. This transparency preserves the manuscript's physical dimension, allowing for a rigorous study of medieval textual transmission where human expertise guides machine recognition. eScriptorium supports training of personalized HTR models, using neural networks like those based on Kraken or PyLaia, which can be calibrated on specific

⁶¹ Benjamin Kiessling et al., *eScriptorium: An Open Source Platform for Historical Document Analysis*, 2019.

corpora. At the core of this choice lies the problem of Beneventan script. To date, no HTR model has been specifically trained on Beneventan writing. Beneventan poses a significant computational challenge due to its dense abbreviation system, frequent ligatures, variable letterforms, and lack of orthographic standardization. Generic HTR models trained on more regular scripts tend to interpret these features as noise, producing unreliable results. In this project, the training of a custom experimental HTR model for Beneventan script constitutes a central methodological contribution. The model is trained on a manually corrected ground truth dataset derived from the manuscript, establishing a controlled feedback loop between human expertise and machine recognition. The purpose of HTR here is not automation for its own sake, but the creation of a reproducible and inspectable transcription process. A comprehensive analysis of the technical implementation, training parameters, and accuracy metrics for this specific model is provided in detail in Chapter VI. A further aspect of relevance is represented by the platform's completely open source nature, guaranteeing the scholar full control over data, recognition models, and adopted transcriptive conventions. Based on technologies like Python and Docker, eScriptorium permits local installation or on private servers, avoiding dependencies on external clouds and reducing privacy risks or costs. This characteristic avoids forms of dependency on proprietary infrastructures and makes research process transparent and replicable, assuming particularly significant methodological value in philological context, where possibility of documenting and motivating choices made constitutes integral part of scientific work. The open source community around eScriptorium facilitates exchange of models and data, encouraging interdisciplinary collaborations among philologists, computer scientists, and historians. During research, Transkribus was also used, platform widely diffused in HTR field and today reference point for numerous digitization projects. Developed by University of Innsbruck and commercialized by READ-COOP, Transkribus offers user-friendly interface for uploading images, training models, and generating automatic transcriptions⁶². Its

⁶² Guenter Muehlberger et al., 'Transforming Scholarship in the Archives through Handwritten Text Recognition: Transkribus as a Case Study', *Journal of Documentation* 75, no. 5 (2019): 954–76, <https://doi.org/10.1108/JD-07-2018-0114>.

employment had prevalently exploratory and comparative function, permitting evaluation of potentialities of system strongly oriented toward automatic recognition efficiency and workflow standardization. Transkribus proved particularly useful for obtaining first automatic text restitution, especially for editio princeps, whose typographic regularity lends itself more readily to this type of treatment. For example, using models pre-trained on corpora of sixteenth-century Latin texts, Transkribus provided initial transcriptions with reduced error rate (approximately 5-10% for printed texts), which were then integrated into eScriptorium workflow for cross-comparisons. Comparison between two platforms highlighted substantial methodological difference. If Transkribus privileges approach oriented toward productivity and scalability, with advanced functionalities like batch processing of large data volumes and API integration for automations, eScriptorium configures itself as more flexible environment and more suitable for research contexts where priority isn't transcription rapidity but critical understanding of text and its materiality. Transkribus tends to "hide" technical details behind simplified interface, which can limit decision traceability (for instance, exporting trained models for local uses is not always possible). The commercial structure of Transkribus implies data and model management mediated by platform infrastructure, with costs for intensive use (for example, credits for computing hours), while eScriptorium guarantees direct control over produced materials and adopted methodological choices. Transkribus excels in large-scale projects, like entire archive digitalizations, where efficiency prevails over philological granularity. The comparative use of both platforms allowed for a critical integration of digital tools into the philological workflow. In this context, eScriptorium emerged as the most coherent methodological space for investigating the transition from the medieval manuscript tradition to its early modern printed reworking, as it preserves the complexity of the material and textual data. A decisive advantage of eScriptorium is its ability to export data in a TEI-compatible XML format⁶³. This feature highlights that the platform is not merely a tool but a functional extension of the philological method, where technology amplifies rather than replaces textual criticism. From a practical standpoint, the XML export significantly accelerates the application of XSLT (Extensible

⁶³ eScriptorium (ente collettivo), *Get Started with eScriptorium* (n.d.).

Stylesheet Language Transformations). Because the platform generates a robust, well-formed structural "skeleton", capturing coordinates, line breaks, and region types, the editor is not required to build the encoding from scratch. Instead, the workflow shifts to refining and expanding this existing framework.

5.4 Text Encoding

In order to adapt the transcribed material to the structural logic of the TEI model, the Oxygen XML Editor (version 26.1) was employed⁶⁴. The software, through its pre-installed TEI framework, enabled the automatic generation of a valid TEI-XML structure, providing a formal and standards-compliant skeleton for the encoding process. The Text Encoding Initiative (TEI) today constitutes the principal framework for the digital encoding of texts in the humanities⁶⁵. From its inception, the TEI was conceived not as a rigid or prescriptive standard, but as a flexible system of guidelines designed to balance interoperability with scholarly interpretative freedom⁶⁶. Technically, the TEI is grounded in XML (eXtensible Markup Language), which provides its formal representational model. XML is a meta-language standardized by the World Wide Web Consortium (W3C) for structuring hierarchical and machine-readable data.⁶⁷ XML enables textual data to be structured hierarchically through elements and attributes, making it possible to distinguish clearly between content and presentation. This separation constitutes one of the founding principles of TEI encoding: the text is described in structural, logical, and semantic terms, while its visualization is delegated to subsequent transformation stages, implemented in this project through XSLT in the section 5.5. Such an architecture preserves an abstract (logical) model of the text distinct from its graphic manifestation (rendering), thereby positioning encoding not merely as a technical procedure but as a

⁶⁴ Syncro Soft SRL, 'Oxygen XML Editor', Oxygen XML Editor, 2024, <https://www.oxygenxml.com/>.

⁶⁵ The Text Encoding Initiative was launched in 1988 as an international collaborative project aimed at developing standardized guidelines for the electronic representation of texts in the humanities.

⁶⁶ Its governance and ongoing development are entrusted to the TEI Consortium, a non-profit organization coordinating an international community of researchers and institutions

⁶⁷ Tim Bray et al., *Extensible Markup Language (XML) 1.0 (Fifth Edition)*, W3C Recommendation (World Wide Web Consortium (W3C), 2008), <https://www.w3.org/TR/xml/>.

form of critical argumentation. Another major strength of the TEI lies in its modularity. The Guidelines provide a wide array of elements organized into thematic modules; each project selects the components required for its specific objectives and documents these choices explicitly ⁶⁸. Structurally, every TEI document presents a relatively stable architectural framework. The root element <TEI>, associated with the official TEI namespace, encloses the entire document and formally identifies the file as compliant with the Guidelines. Within it, the document is divided into two macro-sections: the <teiHeader> and the textual content proper, contained within the <text> element. The <teiHeader> plays a central role in the economy of the document, as it gathers the metadata relating to both the digital file and its textual sources. At minimum, it includes a <fileDesc> which contains information concerning the title, editorial responsibility (Snippet 1), publication details (Snippet 2), and source description (Snippet 3).

```
<TEI xmlns="http://www.tei-c.org/ns/1.0">
  <teiHeader>
    <fileDesc>
      <titleStmt>
        <title>Legenda Sancti Guilielmi — Synopsis: 13th-century MS and Renda 1581</title>
        <respStmt>
          <resp>compiled by</resp>
          <name xml:id="MDP">Michelle De Paola</name>
        </respStmt>
      </titleStmt>
    </fileDesc>
  </teiHeader>
```

Snippet 1 Opening of the TEI-XML file, showing the <TEI> root element and the beginning of the <teiHeader> with title and editorial responsibility.

⁶⁸ The TEI Guidelines offer a vast array of hundreds of elements organized into thematic modules. Each project selectively adopts the components required for its specific objectives and explicitly documents. In this framework, simplified profiles such as TEI Lite are effective for projects with limited structural or semantic granularity, conversely, complex scholarly editions typically require more extensive customizations and a rigorous editorial declaration. This process of selection and modification is formalized through the ODD (*One Document Does it all*) mechanism, which allows researchers to define a project-specific schema while maintaining full compliance with the international TEI standard. See TEI Consortium, *TEI P5: Guidelines for Electronic Text Encoding and Interchange*, Technical standard (n.d.), <https://tei-c.org/guidelines/p5/>.

```

<publicationStmt>
  <authority>
    <choice>
      <abbr>VeDPH</abbr>
      <expan>Venice Centre for Digital and Public Humanities</expan>
    </choice>
  </authority>
  <availability>
    <licence target="https://creativecommons.org/licenses/by-sa/4.0/">CC BY-SA 4.0</licence>
  </availability>
  <pubPlace>Venice, Italy</pubPlace>
  <date when="2026">2026</date>
</publicationStmt>

```

Snippet 2 Excerpt from the <publicationStmt> element, encoding authority (VeDPH), licensing information (CC BY-SA 4.0), place of publication (Venice), and date (2026).

```

<sourceDesc>
  <listWit>
    <witness xml:id="msXIII" corresp="#Cod1">
      <bibl>13th-century manuscript, Montevergine, Beneventan script.</bibl>
    </witness>
    <witness xml:id="renda1581" corresp="#Renda1581">
      <bibl>Felix Renda, Vita Sancti Guilielmi, Naples 1581.</bibl>
    </witness>
  </listWit>

```

Snippet 3 Excerpt from the <sourceDesc> showing the <listWit> element.

Within the <sourceDesc> element, the two witnesses forming the basis of the digital edition are formally defined through a <listWit>, which identifies the thirteenth-century manuscript and the 1581 printed edition as distinct textual witnesses. This structural choice reflects the comparative architecture of the project: the manuscript and the print are not treated as successive stages of a linear transmission, but as parallel documentary entities subjected to systematic comparison. Each witness is linked to a more detailed description⁶⁹. Additional components document persons and places, as well as an explicit encoding description. The inclusion of a list of persons and a list of places serves a dual purpose. On the one hand, it functions as a controlled register of the historical, narrative, and paratextual figures appearing in the text. On the other hand, it provides a stable

⁶⁹ The full TEI-XML file, including the complete <sourceDesc> structure and codicological description, is available in the digital Appendix B.1 accompanying this thesis.

reference system that allows names within the body of the edition to be linked to structured authority entries (Snippet 4).

```
<person xml:id="p_guilielmus">
  <persName xml:lang="la" type="main">
    <forename>Guilielmus</forename>
    <roleName>Subject of the Vita; founder of Montevergine</roleName>
  </persName>
  <idno type="VIAF">190751093</idno>
  <idno type="Wikidata">Q2197784</idno>
  <birth when="1085">1085</birth>
  <death when="1142">1142</death>
</person>
```

Snippet 4 Excerpt from the <listPerson> showing the structured encoding of one character.

A similar principle applies to places: the geographical dimension of the narrative is formalized through a structured list that associates medieval toponyms with modern identifications and geospatial coordinates (Snippet 5). In this way, the sacred and historical topography of the Vita becomes computationally interrogable without reducing its philological complexity.

```
<place xml:id="mons_virginis">
  <placeName xml:lang="la" type="main">Mons Virginis</placeName>
  <location>
    <settlement>Mercogliano</settlement>
    <region>Campania</region>
    <country>Italia</country>
    <geo>40.93583, 14.72834</geo>
  </location>
</place>
```

Snippet 5 Excerpt from the <listPlace> showing the structured encoding of one place.

The header also contains an encoding description, which makes explicit the logic of segmentation, the criteria of cross-witness alignment, the treatment of paratextual elements, and the naming conventions adopted for stable referencing ⁷⁰. From a philological perspective, the <teiHeader> is not a merely technical apparatus, but a

⁷⁰ The complete <encodingDesc> elementis provided in Appendix B.1.

formalized space in which methodological decisions are declared and the interpretative framework of the edition is made explicit. In this sense, the header functions as a scholarly paratext, ensuring transparency, reproducibility, and critical accountability. The textual content of the edition is contained in the <text> element, which hosts the encoded transcription itself. In this project, <text> is organized as a comparative structure: the two witnesses are placed within a <group>, allowing the manuscript and the printed edition to be represented as parallel textual entities within the same TEI file. Each witness is encoded as a separate <text> node, identified by a stable @xml:id and associated with its own <body>. Within each witness, the narrative is structured into ordered units (<div type="unit">) that correspond to meaningful sections of the Vita (e.g., prologue, incipit, miracle episodes, foundation narrative). These units provide the primary segmentation level for the synoptic design of the edition. Inside each unit, the text is further articulated into smaller segments (<seg>), used to isolate passages that perform a specific rhetorical or narrative function (such as authorial positioning, description, dialogue, miracle report, or departure). This segmentation is not intended to replace traditional textual divisions, but to make the internal organization of the narrative explicit and to support alignment across witnesses at a functional level (Snippet 6).

```
<text>
  <group>

    <!-- WITNESS 1: MS (13th c.) -->
    <text xml:id="wit.ms_XIII" xml:lang="la">
      <body>

        <div type="unit" n="01" xml:id="ms.d.u01.prologus">
          <head>Prologus</head>
          <ab>
            <seg type="authorial-stance" xml:id="ms.u01.s01">Nostre parvitatís non toleranda ingenio, et que sunt stupenda intuitu,
            summorum etiam virorum eloquentiam ac subtilitatis acumen facile possent excedere.</seg>
            <seg type="authorial-fear" xml:id="ms.u01.s02">Vereor quippe non modicum ne, si quod arduissimum est ac difficillimum
            tractare incipiam perfectionis sapientie viris, dum quod cepero consummare
            non valeam, non immerito ridiculus fiam et, quod gravius est,
            tam sancti viri laudibus dampnum inferat nostre rusticitas eloquentie.</seg>
            <seg type="purpose-writing" xml:id="ms.u01.s03">Ad multorum scilicet edificationem, beati Guilielmi,
            cuius vicem Dei gratia geris, vitam ut obitum scriptis
            transmittere posteris nec, ad summi regis honorem et gloriam,
            inerti occultare silentio que pro ipsius vite meritis divina
            misericordia fuerit operata.</seg>
```

Snippet 6 Excerpt from the <text> element showing the comparative structure of the edition.

In other words, the <text> element operationalizes the core methodological aim of the project: to represent two historically distinct textual realizations of the same work in a

way that preserves their autonomy while making their convergences and divergences analytically traceable within the digital environment.

5.5 Transformation

The transformation layer of the project is implemented through an XSLT stylesheet that converts the TEI-XML synopsis into a navigable HTML research interface⁷¹. XSLT (eXtensible Stylesheet Language Transformations) is itself an XML-based language designed to process and reorganize XML documents: it operates by selecting elements in the source file through XPath expressions and applying predefined transformation rules, called templates, to generate a new structured output⁷². An XPath expression is essentially a path that navigates the hierarchical structure of the XML document. In practical terms, XPath answers the question “which part of the TEI file am I looking at?”. This mechanism is visible already at the highest level of the stylesheet: the root template uses the XPath expression `/tei:TEI` to match the TEI document as a whole; whenever the processor encounters the TEI root element, it applies this template and produces the entire HTML page skeleton (including the `<html>`, `<head>`, and `<body>` structure). A simpler example concerns the title: the XPath expression `tei:teiHeader/tei:fileDesc/tei:titleStmt/tei:title` navigates step by step through the TEI header and retrieves the textual content of `<title>`. That value is then inserted both in the HTML `<title>` element (for the browser tab) and in the visible page header, demonstrating how the TEI structure remains unchanged and is instead *read* and reformulated into a different representational form (Snippet 7).

⁷¹ Michael Kay, *XSL Transformations (XSLT) Version 3.0*, W3C Recommendation (World Wide Web Consortium (W3C), 2017), <https://www.w3.org/TR/xslt-30/>.

⁷² Anders Berglund et al., *XML Path Language (XPath) 2.0*, W3C Recommendation (World Wide Web Consortium (W3C), 2010), <https://www.w3.org/TR/xpath20/>.

```

<!-- ROOT -->
<xsl:template match="//tei:TEI">
  <html>
    <head>
      <title>
        <xsl:value-of select="normalize-space(tei:teiHeader/tei:fileDesc/tei:titleStmt/tei:title)"/>
      </title>

```

Snippet 7 Root XSLT template matching the <TEI> element (match="//tei:TEI"), which generates the overall HTML structure and extracts the title from the TEI header to populate the HTML <title> element.

The same principle operates at a more complex level in the synoptic comparison, where XPath is used not only to extract content, but also to coordinate and align multiple textual layers (Snippet 8).

```

<!-- SYNOPSIS -->
<div class="card anchor" id="synopsis" style="margin-top:12px;">
  <h2>Synopsis</h2>

  <xsl:variable name="ms" select="//tei:text[@xml:id=$ms-id]"/>
  <xsl:variable name="renda" select="//tei:text[@xml:id=$renda-id]"/>

  <xsl:variable name="allUnits" select="($ms//tei:div[@type='unit'] | $renda//tei:div[@type='unit'])"/>

  <xsl:for-each select="$allUnits[generate-id(.) = generate-id(key('kUnitByN', @n)[1])]">
    <xsl:sort select="number(@n)" data-type="number"/>

    <xsl:variable name="n" select="@n"/>
    <xsl:variable name="nLabel" select="format-number(number($n), '00')"/>

    <xsl:variable name="msUnit" select="$ms//tei:div[@type='unit'][@n=$n][1]"/>
    <xsl:variable name="rUnit" select="$renda//tei:div[@type='unit'][@n=$n][1]"/>

    <xsl:variable name="msSegs" select="$msUnit//tei:seg[@type]"/>
    <xsl:variable name="rSegs" select="$rUnit//tei:seg[@type]"/>

```

Snippet 8 XSLT fragment implementing the synoptic comparison: it selects the two witnesses via their @xml:id, collects all narrative units (<div type="unit">), groups them by @n, and iterates over each unit to align manuscript and printed edition segments by type.

This XPath expression searches anywhere in the document (//) for a <text> element whose @xml:id matches the parameter identifying the manuscript. The result is stored in a variable (\$ms), which is then reused throughout the transformation. Once the witnesses are isolated, the synopsis is built by retrieving all narrative units—defined in the TEI as <div type="unit">—from both witnesses and merging them into a single iterable set. In practice, XPath identifies all unit divisions and a key (kUnitByN) groups them by their

shared @n value: this provides a stable mechanism to pair manuscript and print units that belong to the same narrative block, even when their internal segmentation differs. The `<xsl:for-each>` loop then iterates unit by unit, and for each unit constructs a consistent HTML block containing the unit number and heading, an interpretive introduction (invoked through a named template), a two-column panel for marginal notes, and a synoptic table in which the text is aligned by segment type (@type). In this sense, XPath determines which narrative unit is being processed, while the template logic determines how it is rendered and how its components are distributed across the interface. Another illustrative example concerns entity linking or how the stylesheet turns TEI markup into navigation tools (Snippet 9).

```
<xsl:template match="tei:persName" mode="seg">
  <xsl:variable name="rid">
    <xsl:choose>
      <xsl:when test="@ref and starts-with(@ref,'#')"><xsl:value-of select="substring-after(@ref,'#')"/></xsl:when>
      <xsl:when test="@ref"><xsl:value-of select="@ref"/></xsl:when>
      <xsl:when test="@corresp and starts-with(@corresp,'#')"><xsl:value-of select="substring-after(@corresp,'#')"/></xsl:when>
      <xsl:when test="@corresp"><xsl:value-of select="@corresp"/></xsl:when>
      <xsl:otherwise/>
    </xsl:choose>
  </xsl:variable>

  <xsl:choose>
    <xsl:when test="string($rid)!='' and count(key('kPersonById',$rid)) > 0">
      <a class="ent person">
        <xsl:attribute name="href">
          <xsl:text>#person-</xsl:text><xsl:value-of select="$rid"/>
        </xsl:attribute>
        <xsl:apply-templates select="node()" mode="seg"/>
      </a>
    </xsl:when>
    <xsl:otherwise>
      <xsl:apply-templates select="node()" mode="seg"/>
    </xsl:otherwise>
  </xsl:choose>
</xsl:template>
```

Snippet 9 XSLT template matching `<persName>` in `mode="seg"`, which extracts the referenced identifier from `@ref` or `@corresp`, verifies its existence via the `kPersonById` key, and transforms the name into an internal HTML link to the corresponding person entry; if no valid reference is found, the name is rendered as plain text.

the XPath pattern `tei:persName` means: whenever a `<persName>` element is encountered (in the specified mode), apply this rule. Inside the template, another XPath expression extracts the referenced identifier. If a corresponding `<person>` exists in `<listPerson>`, the name is transformed into an HTML link pointing to the relevant card. Thus, the encoded

TEI reference becomes a clickable element in the interface. The same mechanism applies to place names through the `tei:placeName` template and `kPlaceById`. As a result, the interface does not simply display the edition: it activates the TEI file as a structured dataset in which entities can be browsed across the text, the indices, and (for places) the map. In addition to content selection and structural transformation, the stylesheet specifies the visual and interactive behaviour of the interface. Layout and style are defined directly in the `<style>` section embedded in the HTML `<head>`: here CSS rules assign typographic choices, spacing, and card-based design, and they also support interpretive readability by differentiating textual segments through colour-coded classes (e.g., segments tagged as *miracle-event*, *speech*, or *authorial-fear* receive distinct visual accents). This styling layer is not merely decorative: it makes the analytical segmentation legible at a glance, turning the TEI's rhetorical and functional categories into an immediately readable visual grammar. Finally, a small portion of JavaScript is included to enable dynamic functions that cannot be achieved through XSLT alone⁷³. Overall, the transformation pipeline preserves the TEI document as the stable scholarly model, while producing an HTML interface in which metadata, entities, synoptic alignment, and spatial visualization work together to support exploratory reading and philological analysis.

5.6 The Role of AI within the Research Workflow

Within this framework AI functioned as a support instrument integrated into specific phases of the research process, whose scope is here clarified in the interest of methodological transparency. The application of AI in this project can be grouped into three principal areas: (5.6.1) refinement of academic writing, (5.6.2) orientation within

⁷³ The complete XSLT stylesheet is reproduced in Appendix B.2. The appendix also contains a commented explanation of the embedded JavaScript code, detailing its role in enabling map interaction, marker generation from `<geo>` coordinates, and dynamic navigation between the map and the structured place entries.

selected literature, and (5.6.3) verification of methodological coherence and interpretative consistency.

5.6.1. Stylistic and Structural Refinement of Academic Writing

AI tools⁷⁴ were employed to assist in the revision of sections of the thesis, particularly in order to improve syntactic clarity, argumentative structure, and overall readability. The AI intervention concerned the reformulation of complex or densely structured passages, with the aim of enhancing logical articulation and linguistic precision. This function is comparable to that of an advanced editorial assistant. It did not generate arguments autonomously, or alter the scholarly substance of the analysis.

5.6.2. Accelerated Orientation within Literature

Given the ambitious scope of the project and the limited timeframe available, not all relevant materials were always accessible in printed form or could be fully consulted at every stage of writing. In such cases, AI was used to facilitate rapid orientation within specific conceptual frameworks or scholarly debates that had already been independently identified through traditional bibliographical research. In some instances, AI also suggested additional bibliographical references potentially relevant to the thematic field under consideration. These suggestions were not adopted automatically: each reference was verified before being incorporated into the thesis. Only those works that proved methodologically and conceptually coherent with the research framework were retained. For example, within the broader discussion of material philology and institutional textual reshaping, AI indicated works associated with scholars such as John van Engen or with the theoretical reflections of Peter Stallybrass and Roger Chartier. These references were subsequently examined and assessed in relation to the project's focus on textual

⁷⁴ OpenAI, *ChatGPT*, v. 5.2, n.d., <https://chatgpt.com/>; and Google DeepMind, *Gemini*, v. 3, n.d., <https://deepmind.google/models/gemini/>.

transmission, devotional rewriting, and the material conditions of textual production. These interactions did not replace direct reading where available, nor did they serve as substitutes for citation-based verification. Rather, they functioned as preliminary or complementary tools enabling more efficient navigation within a bibliographical field.

5.6.3 AI and the Comparative Analysis

Particular attention must be given to the identification of parallel textual segments discussed in Chapter VII. The alignment of corresponding units was supported by Italian translations of the texts, consulted through library-provided materials, which facilitated a preliminary semantic orientation. AI was subsequently used in a controlled manner to test these hypotheses. Selected passages were submitted in order to verify whether certain lexical, syntactic, or rhetorical nuances reinforced the interpretative proposal. For example, in relation to Figure 23, the following question was posed: “In these two Latin passages, does the second text eliminate expressions of authorial fear present in the first? Are there syntactic signals reinforcing this shift?”. In this sense, AI functioned as a stress-testing mechanism rather than as an alignment engine. It did not search the corpus independently, nor did it determine segmentation or categorization.

Chapter VI – Training model for Beneventan script

6.1 Project Setup

Images of the thirteenth-century manuscript and editio princeps were manually scanned to guarantee direct control over reproduction quality, graphic sign legibility, and material detail rendering. This preliminary phase constituted essential prerequisite for all subsequent operations, since image quality directly affects segmentation and automatic recognition effectiveness. Once scanning was completed, a dedicated project was created in eScriptorium, within which images were uploaded through import from local file system. The two witnesses were kept distinct within the project, allowing differentiated operative strategies while maintaining unitary working environment (Figure 13)



Figure 13 eScriptorium project interface with separate image sets corresponding to the manuscript witness and the printed edition.

Transcriptions were imported from Transkribus to rapidly have base text available, useful both for initial content exploration and as support for subsequent revision phases. The typographic regularity of editio princeps particularly lent itself to automatic recognition. Transcription management was set up in task-based mode (TSK) rather than manual mode. This methodological choice allows structuring work in distinct operative units, making explicit the different phases of automatic transcription, manual revision, and eventual validation. Task use favored editorial process traceability and clear distinction between different intervention levels on text.

6.2 Transcription Management

For the thirteenth-century manuscript, work in eScriptorium did not begin directly from automatic layout segmentation but from preliminary phase of manual text correction. This choice was dictated by specific characteristics of Beneventan script, whose graphic complexity, combined with the absence of HTR models actually trained on this script type, renders purely automatic approach unreliable in initial phases. The choice therefore privileged direct human intervention, aimed at establishing philologically controlled textual base on which to graft, in second moment, model training procedures. For the *editio princeps*, by contrast, the starting point was the automatic transcription produced in Transkribus, which proved generally accurate thanks to the regularity of the sixteenth-century typography. Manual corrections were nevertheless systematically applied, although limited in scope, in order to ensure full coherence with the transcription criteria adopted in this research and to correct residual errors, mainly related to abbreviation expansion, punctuation, and specific typographic conventions of the 1581 print. In both cases, preliminary manual correction phase does not represent renunciation of HTR use but its critical integration within workflow, in line with research methodological approach. Automation was employed as support and process acceleration tool, while human control guaranteed text philological quality, constituting necessary base for every subsequent phase of training, model refinement, and comparative analysis.

6.3 Layout Correction: Text Regions and Baselines

Once a reliable textual base was consolidated, work in eScriptorium continued with page layout revision. Text regions were verified and manually modified first, intervening on spatial boundaries of textual areas to ensure coherent correspondence with actual page structure. This operation entailed correct separation of columns or blocks, attribution of individual lines to respective areas, and determination of implicit reading order—fundamental element for text interpretation and subsequent automatic processing phases. Correcting text regions was not limited to graphic adjustment but was conducted according to explicit ontological approach, based on adopting SegmOnto, a controlled vocabulary designed for standardized description of manuscript and printed page

structure⁷⁵. Using SegmOnto permitted homogenizing data destined for layout analysis model training and inserting segmentation within coherent pipeline leading from image to structured document. From this perspective, each identified area was classified based on its textual, material, or paratextual function. Main text zones (MainZone), decorative areas (GraphicZone), enlarged initials (DropCapitalZone), elements linked to codex material organization (QuireMarksZone), and subsequently added texts (MarginTextZone) were thus distinguished. This classification allowed explicitly reflecting actual page organization, avoiding arbitrary interpretations and guaranteeing stable and reusable segmentation. For the thirteenth-century manuscript, continuous text was organized prevalently in MainZone:column, articulated in distinct columns (LeftPageColumn and RightPageColumn), since rubricated text remains structurally internal to column and doesn't constitute autonomous unit. MainZone:block use was reserved exclusively for cases where text presented sharp spatial and functional separation, such as to configure independent unit (for example prologues, explicit or tituli). Enlarged initials were further distinguished between DropCapitalZone:historiated, when letter contains recognizable figure with narrative or symbolic value, and DropCapitalZone:flourished, when decoration is exclusively ornamental (see Figure 14).



Figure 14 Layout annotation for the thirteenth-century manuscript. The color-coded annotation illustrates the hierarchical organization of the page: columns left (blue/violet) columns right (two shades of pink), flourished initial (green)

⁷⁵ Simon Gabay et al., 'SegmOnto: A Controlled Vocabulary to Describe and Process Digital Facsimiles', *Journal of Data Mining and Digital Humanities*, 2024, https://hal.science/hal-04343404v2/file/JDMDH_2024_Segmonto.pdf.

For 1581 *editio princeps*, region classification followed analogous criteria, adapted to print logic. The frontispiece was identified as TitlePageZone (see Figure 15) since entire page fulfills unitary bibliographic and identificative function; central coat of arms was annotated as GraphicZone:figure, while numbers and material signatures were traced back to NumberingZone or QuireMarksZone. Information added *a posteriori*, such as ownership stamps, modern signatures, manuscript notes, were systematically classified as MarginTextZone, with distinction between inner and outer based on position relative to binding. This distinction proves relevant both for HTR training quality and for reconstructing exemplar material history, understood as stratified physical object (see Figure 16).



Figure 15 Layout annotation of the title page of the 1581 editio princeps. TitlePageZone (pink), MarginTextZone: upper note (blue), MarginTextZone: outer note (light blue), MarginTextZone: lower note (green), MarginTextZone: inner note (light green) Numbering zone:item (violet).



Figure 16 On the left GraphicZone:illustration (a shadow of pink). On the right NumberingZone:folio (blue); MainZone:block (red); MarginTextZone:inner note (yellow); GraphicZone:ornamentation (dark pink); DropCapitalZone:historiated (dark violet); MarginTextZone:outer commentary (green); QuickMarkZone:signature (pink); QuickMarkZone:catchwords (violet)

Only from ontologically coherent segmentation was it possible to proceed to baseline correction, determining element for automatic recognition quality. Baselines were adjusted so that each text line corresponded to single baseline, its beginning coincided with actual line start, and all characters resulted correctly aligned. Baseline correction entailed automatic recalculation of line masks by eScriptorium, ensuring more accurate segmentation functional to subsequent recognition and model training phases (see Figure 17).



Figure 17 Baseline correction and updated line masks.

6.4 Creating the Ground Truth

From layout correction and automatic transcription revision according to criteria defined in Chapter V, ground truth was progressively constructed as reference dataset for training and evaluating recognition models. Selecting initial twenty-one pages for each witness permitted concentrating human intervention on representative sample while guaranteeing data quality and annotation work sustainability.

6.5 Iterative Fine-tuning of Recognition Models

In present work, HTR performance improvement was pursued through iterative fine-tuning processes of recognition models. Fine-tuning consists in targeted adaptation of already existing model to specific corpus, using manually corrected pages as training data. This approach permits making model progressively sensitive to graphic and material characteristics of analyzed documents, like irregular *ductus* progression, systematic abbreviation use, letter form. The iterative character of fine-tuning implies model adaptation does not occur in single phase but through sequence of successive cycles. In each cycle, model is applied to pages, errors are manually corrected on limited number

of cases, corrections are used as ground truth to refine model, and improved model is tested on new pages. When significant errors persist, cycle is repeated progressively expanding corrected data set. This approach allows obtaining sensible improvements even from relatively reduced ground truth quantities, especially when starting model is already partially compatible with application domain. Methodologically, iterative fine-tuning is founded on integration logic between automation and human control: HTR accelerates text production, while scholarly intervention guarantees philological correctness and directly orients model learning (see Figure 18).

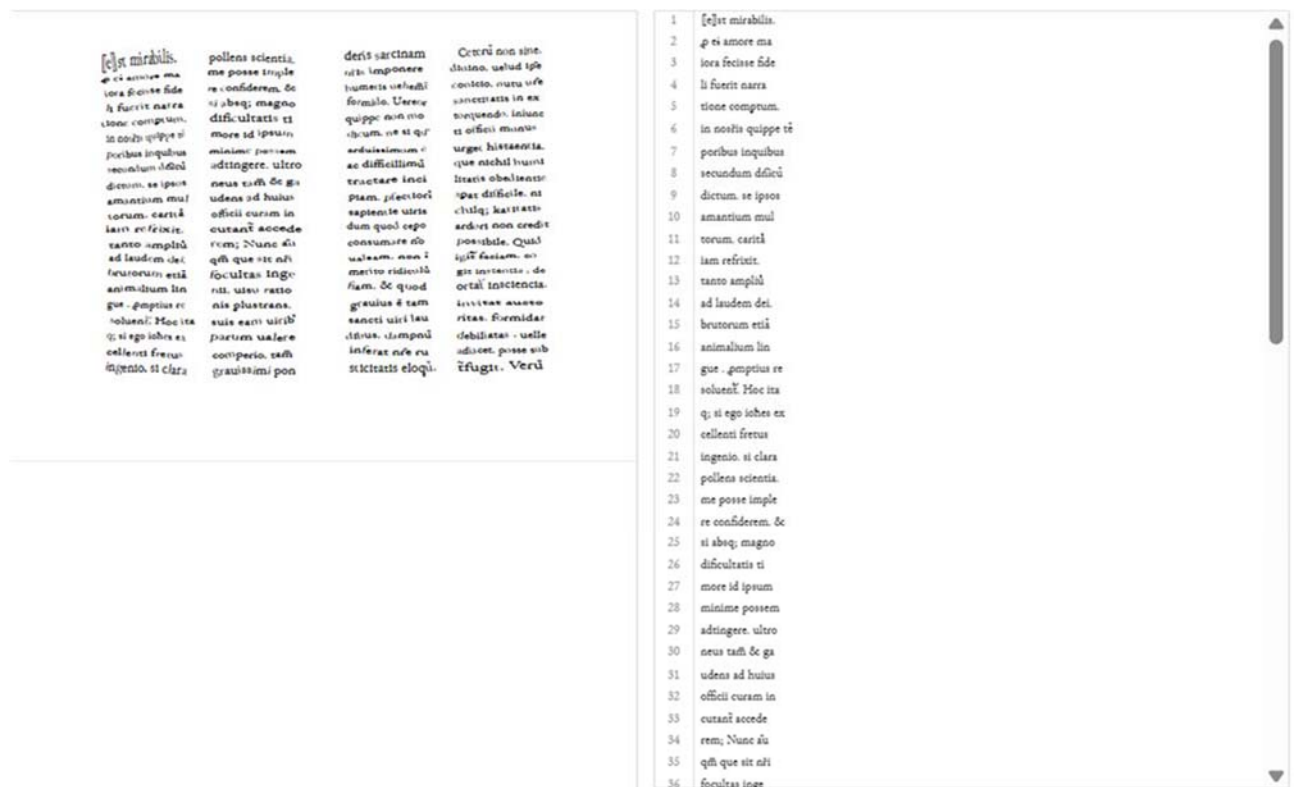


Figure 18 Example of automated transcription done with eScriptorium.

6.6 Training and Evaluation of the Beneventan Recognition Model

A central methodological outcome of the present research is the first training of a dedicated HTR model specifically aimed at recognizing Beneventan script within the Legenda Sancti Guilielmi. Unlike more common medieval Latin scripts, Beneventan presents distinctive graphic features, complex ductus, marked letter allography, frequent

ligatures, and dense abbreviation systems, that make it poorly compatible with generic medieval recognition models.

6.7 Selection of the Training Sample

For the initial training phase, a controlled sample of twelve pages of the thirteenth-century manuscript was selected (Figure 19). These pages were chosen because they are representative of the manuscript's graphic variability while remaining sufficiently homogeneous in layout and writing style. All pages were fully transcribed and manually corrected, ensuring a philologically reliable ground truth dataset. This limited but carefully curated corpus was conceived not as an exhaustive training set, but as a foundational dataset suitable for testing the feasibility of Beneventan-specific recognition and for initiating an iterative refinement process.

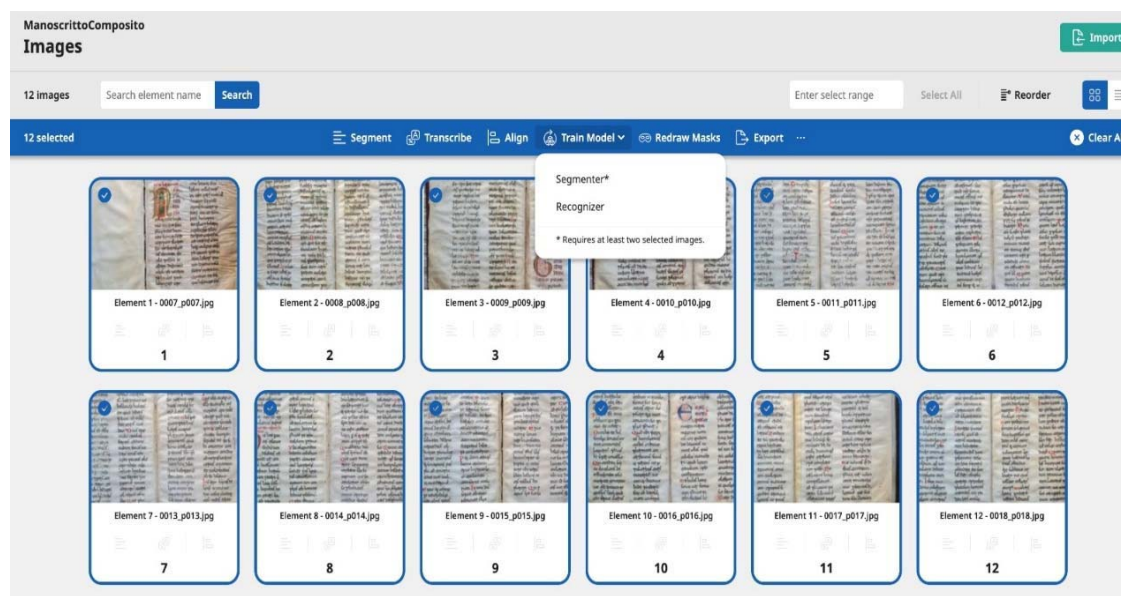


Figure 19 the twelve manually transcribed manuscript pages selected as ground truth for the initial training of the Beneventan recognition model.

6.8 Model Training Procedure in eScriptorium

Once the training sample was prepared, the recognition model was trained directly within eScriptorium using the Train Model function. From the training interface, the Recognizer

option was selected, and transcription management was explicitly set to task-based mode (TSK). This choice ensured traceability of interventions and consistency with the broader workflow adopted throughout the project. The model was assigned the name *beneventana01*, marking its status as the first experimental recognition model for this script within the project. As a starting point, the CATMuS Medieval 1.6.0 model was selected as base model. Although not designed specifically for Beneventan, CATMuS Medieval provides a robust foundation for medieval Latin scripts and allows effective fine-tuning when supported by high-quality ground truth⁷⁶. Training was then launched via the Train command, generating a new recognition model derived from the manually corrected Beneventan pages (Figure 20).

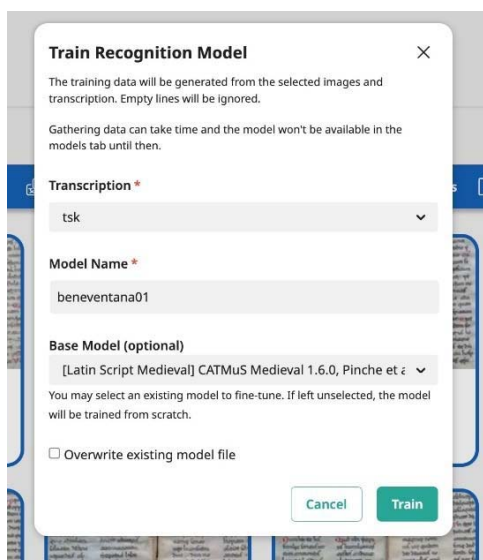


Figure 20 The configuration of the Train Model function.

⁷⁶ Thibault Clérice et al., 'CATMuS Medieval: A Multilingual Large-Scale Cross-Century Dataset in Latin Script for Handwritten Text Recognition and Beyond', paper presented at International Conference on Document Analysis and Recognition (ICDAR), 2024, hal-04453952, HAL Open Science, https://iris.cnr.it/retrieve/58f33c23-bc7b-4e15-a3d0-e3f7275c1551/ICDAR24_CATMUS_Medieval-1.pdf.

6.9 Model Application and Accuracy Assessment

To evaluate model performance, beneventana01 was applied to a manuscript page not included in the training set, namely element 43 within the eScriptorium project (Figure 21). This page served as an external test case, allowing assessment of the model's generalization capability beyond the training sample.

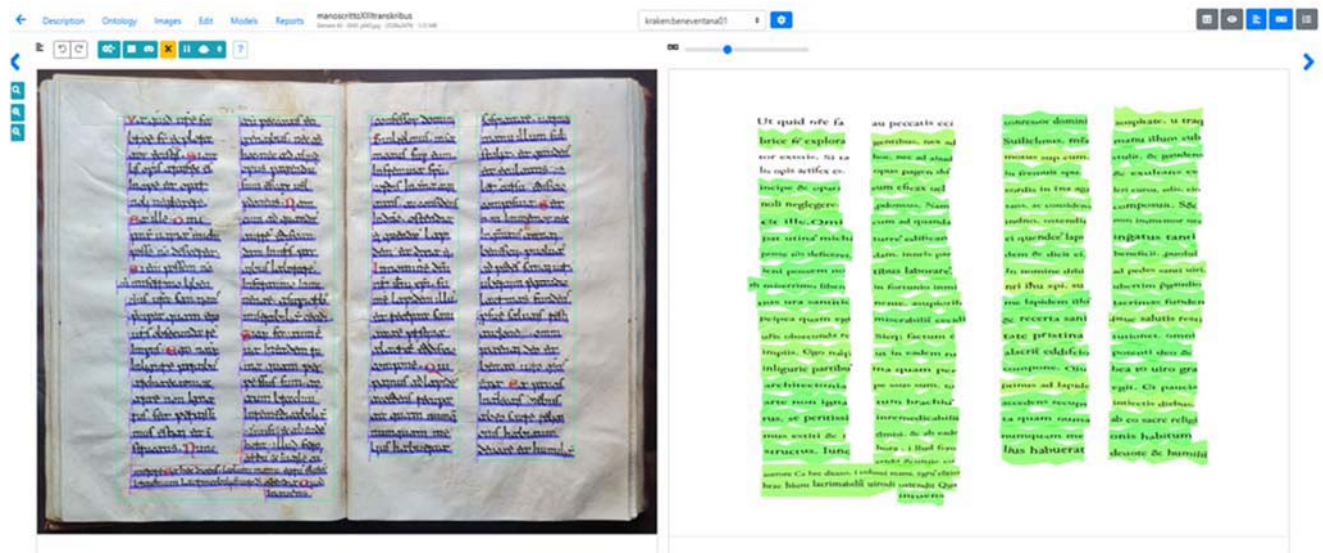


Figure 21 Recognition result generated by the kraken: beneventana01 model, replacing the original TSK transcription layer; most ligatures and abbreviations are correctly resolved.

The evaluation combined qualitative inspection of recognition output with the quantitative indicator automatically computed by eScriptorium. As shown in the model summary panel (Figure 22), the trained model achieved an accuracy of 92.8%, a result that is particularly significant given the limited size of the training corpus and the inherent complexity of Beneventan script.

Role	Script	Size	Trained from	Training Status	Accuracy	Right
beneventana01	Recognize	Latin	15.7 MB	[Latin Script Medieval] CATMuS Medieval 1.6.0, Pinche et al. (10.5281/zenodo.15030337)	✓	92.8%

Figure 22 Recognition result produced by beneventana01 on element43.

This level of accuracy confirms both the feasibility of Beneventan HTR within eScriptorium and the effectiveness of a workflow based on small but carefully controlled

ground truth samples, combined with targeted fine-tuning rather than training from scratch.

6.10 Methodological Implications

The successful training of `beneventana01` demonstrates that Beneventan script, traditionally considered resistant to automatic recognition, can be effectively approached through an integrated methodology combining manual philological control and iterative machine learning. Rather than replacing scholarly intervention, HTR here functions as an amplificatory tool, accelerating transcription while remaining fully guided by human expertise. This first model constitutes a foundational step rather than a definitive solution. Its primary value lies in establishing a methodological proof of concept, opening the way for future refinements through expanded ground truth datasets and successive fine-tuning cycles.

Chapter VII – Comparative Analysis

7.1 Preface

This chapter offers a comparative analysis of the opening section of the *Vita Sancti Guilielmi* as preserved in the thirteenth-century manuscript tradition and as re-presented in the Neapolitan editio princeps edited by Felice Renda in 1581. The investigation focuses on two primary areas: first, the proemial frame (Prologus / Praefatio) as a space of authorial and institutional legitimation; and second, the narrative incipit and selected episodes where structural continuity persists alongside significant editorial mediation. The working hypothesis is that, despite a largely shared narrative “skeleton,” the 1581 printed edition profoundly alters the reader’s mode of interaction with the page. Through syntactic simplification and the systematic use of typographic and paratextual devices, marginal notes, headings, indices, the narrative is transformed into a text designed for consultation, didactic clarity, and institutional display. The *Vita* is no longer simply read; it is navigated, indexed, and strategically framed. The comparative analysis presented here is grounded in the digital modeling discussed in previous chapters. The identification of narrative units and the selection of sample episodes are not arbitrary choices; they derive directly from the segmentation and structuring of the texts within the digital workflow. Through transcription, encoding, and alignment, the medieval manuscript and the printed edition are decomposed into discrete, navigable units, making it possible to observe patterns of continuity, omission, and refunctionalization across media.

7.2 The Evolution of the Author: From Fear to Confidence

The medieval Prologus opens with a strongly marked *captatio benevolentiae*, centred on the author’s inadequacy in relation to his subject. The narrating “I” positions himself in radical inferiority and insists on the risk of appearing ridiculous or, worse, of damaging the saint’s praise. Writing is represented as a morally exposed and spiritually dangerous act (Figure 23) In Renda’s Praefatio, the atmosphere is completely different. The struggle vanishes, and writing is no longer treated

as a problem. Renda does not apologize or hesitate, instead, he says he was simply moved by a deep desire to describe the greatness of the monastery and its founder. He shows no signs of doubt or fear that he isn't good enough for the job (Figure 23).

Synopsis

Unit 01 Prologus / Praefatio

Prologus/Praefatio: the MS frames writing as moral edification and a "curative" response to a present crisis (charity grown cold), transmitting the saint's life and miracles to rekindle faith; Renda reverses the frame, opening with an accumulative celebration of Montevergine as a visible "sacred city," consolidating institutional memory through privileges, confirmations, and public authority.

MS (13th century)	Renda (1581)
authorial-stance Nostre parvitas non toleranda ingenio, et que sunt stupenda intuitu, summorum etiam virorum eloquentiam ac subtilitatis acumen facile possent excedere.	authorial-stance Ut describerem, animo me movit.
authorial-fear Vereor quippe non modicum ne, si quod arduissimum est ac difficillimum tractare incipiam perfectionis sapientie viris, dum quod cepero consummare non valeam, non immerito ridiculus fiam et, quod gravius est, tam sancti viri laudibus dampnum inferat nostre rusticitas eloquentie.	

Figure 23 Example of segment-level alignment in the synoptic interface, displaying the authorial-stance and the authorial-fear passage from the manuscript alongside the corresponding (or absent) segment in the 1581 edition.

Legitimation comes from the strength of the institution and a network of ecclesiastical and political authorities explicitly evoked in the dedicatory apparatus. Writing becomes a project grounded in culture and society (Figure 24).

	institutional-legitimation Illustrissimo ac Reverendissimo Domino Guido de Ferreriis, Vercellensi, Sanctae Romanae Ecclesiae Cardinali tituli Sanctorum Viti et Modesti.
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Figure 24 Synoptic detail showing the replacement of medieval authorial self-legitimation with explicit institutional legitimation in Renda's Praefatio.

7.3 Purpose of Writing: From Moral Edification to Institutional Celebration

In the medieval prologue, the motivation for writing is expressed as the edification of the faithful and the transmission of the saint's memory to posterity. Writing responds to a present perceived as morally fragile, charity has "grown cold" (*refrexit*), so writing was like a spiritual medicine to fix a broken present (Figure 25). Renda reverses the perspective. His introduction does not mention a crisis at all. Instead, he builds a list of everything that makes Montevergine great: the crowds of pilgrims, the beautiful buildings, the holy relics, and the welcoming hospices. He is not trying to heal a sick world; he is showing off a magnificent one. (Figure 25).

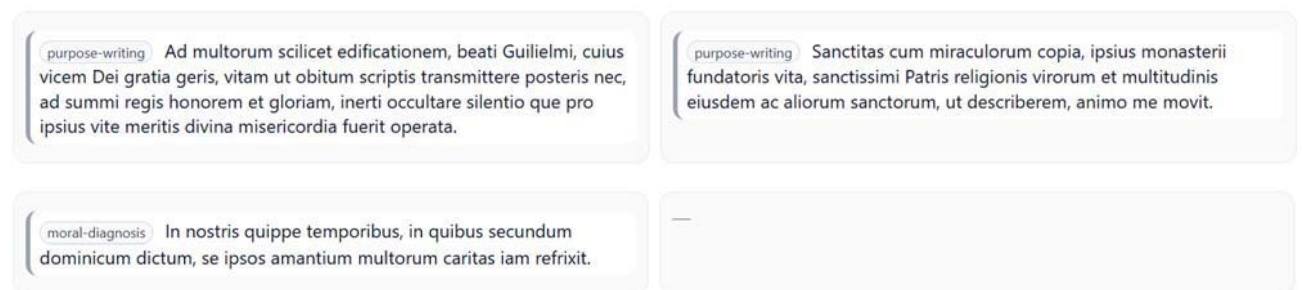


Figure 25 Synoptic comparison shows the shift from medieval edification centered on the saint's life to an early modern celebration of Montevergine as an institutional and sacred space.

The monastery of Montevergine is no longer presented merely as a place of retreat, but is celebrated as a true "sacred city" that dominates the landscape. Renda constructs an image of solid, visible splendor: he cites the "great devotion of the faithful" (*magna fidelium devotio*) and the "gathering of peoples" (*populorum concursus*), but focuses above all on the physical magnificence of the structure (Figure 26). The text functions to consolidate an institutional memory legitimized by privileges and public recognition.



Figure 26 Synoptic detail highlighting Montevergine as a civitas rather than a monastic settlement

7.4 The Mandate to Write: From Obedience to Patronage

In the thirteenth century, the motivation for writing was internal and vertical: a monk wrote out of obedience to a superior, often describing the task as a "heavy burden" (*gravissima sarcina*). Legitimacy was found in this act of submission and in a deep trust in divine help (Figure 27). By 1581, this mandate shifted outward. Instead of humble obedience, the work was justified by its connection to the world; dedications to powerful figures made the logic of patronage explicit. Writing was now placed within a network of social relationships that provided public visibility and institutional protection (Figure 27).

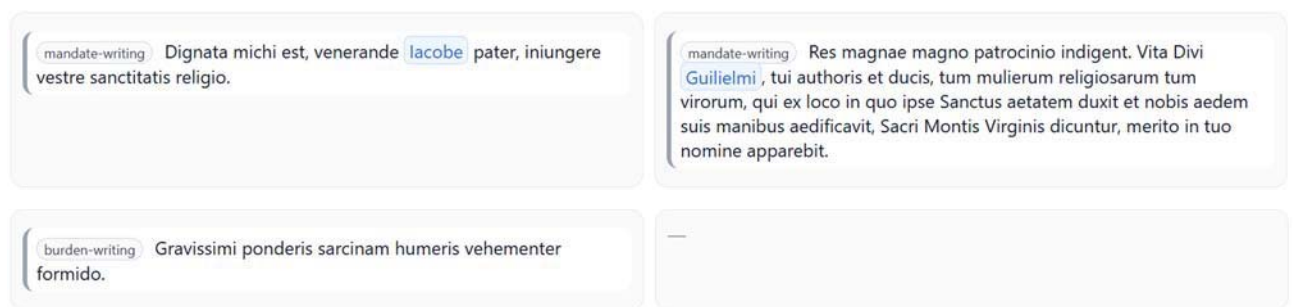


Figure 27 Synoptic comparison shows the shift from authorial burden to institutional authority.

7.5 The Evolution of the Miracle: From Narrative Struggle to Searchable Data

The way miracles are documented undergoes a radical transformation. In the thirteenth century, the medieval author approaches miracles with a sense of overwhelming weight. For him, these events are difficult material to process, so much so that he expresses a deep-seated fear of being unable to finish the work he has started. The miraculous is a spiritual burden, an "exposed" act of writing that requires divine mercy to navigate (Figure 28). By contrast, in Renda's 1581 text, miracles lose their "problematic" narrative status and become informational units. Renda employs a systematic approach that anticipates modern data management:

- **Standardized Labels:** Miracles are introduced using repetitive formulas, such as *Miraculum de...*, making them instantly recognizable to the reader.
- **Information Retrieval:** The use of indices, chapter divisions, and marginalia turns the miraculous event into a segment that can be easily catalogued and consulted.
- **Liturgical Integration:** The inclusion of *Officia* (liturgical offices) shows that the saint's life is no longer just a story, but a stable, integrated part of church practice.

From a digital perspective, this is not merely a stylistic difference: Renda anticipates a logic of indexing and retrieval that is formally realized today through markup and interface design. What is embedded narratively in the manuscript is externalized and stabilized in the paratext of the printed page (Figure 28).

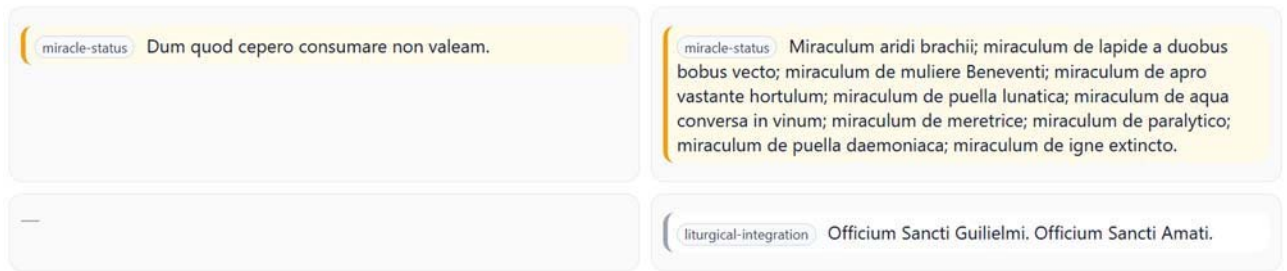


Figure 28 Synoptic comparison shows the shift from narrative miracle to institutional miracle catalogue.

7.6 The Saint: From Individual Charisma to Institutional System

William himself changes profile. In the older text he is a charismatic hermit, whose holiness is a direct work of God. His sanctity is oriented toward divine glory and is described as something so vast it is difficult to fully capture in human words. In this earlier context, the author views the saint's life as a spiritual mystery to be preserved for the edification of the faithful (Figure 29). By 1581, Renda presents a different version of Saint William: he is now primarily a founder and legislator. His greatness is no longer measured by private prayer or hidden miracles, but by the tangible success of his order (Figure 29). Renda focuses on:

- The Institutional Network as William's importance tied to the vast network of monasteries he established.
- Political Legitimacy as his status is confirmed by the donations and privileges secured from powerful emperors and popes.
- Geographic Authority as His memory is mapped across the "topography of possessions," stretching from Vercelli to Sicily.

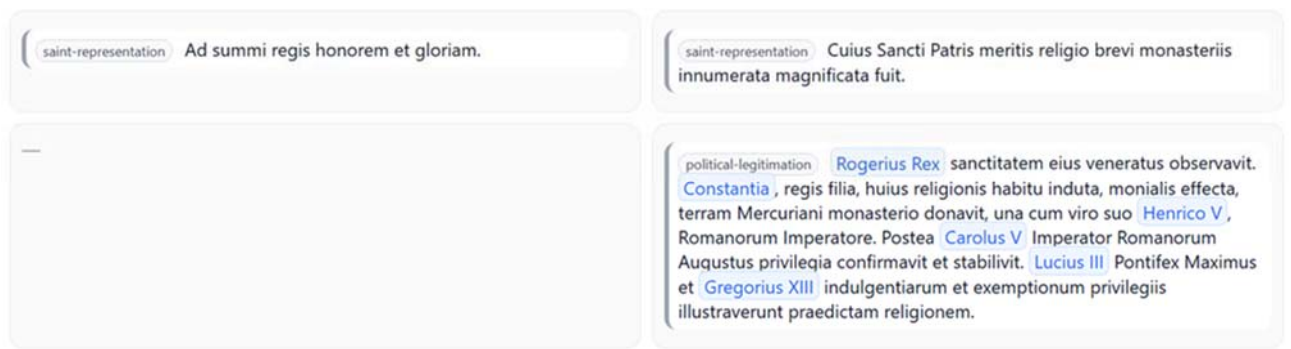


Figure 29 Synoptic comparison shows the shift from spiritual exemplar to politically legitimated saint.

7.8 From Moral Justification to Public Legitimation

The medieval prologue concludes with sobriety and functional restraint. Once the author has justified his choice to write, framing it as a necessary act of obedience and spiritual "medicine", he simply moves into the narration. The goal was to prove the work was worthy of being written despite the author's own perceived inadequacy. By contrast, Renda's *Praefatio* ends with a formula that is both liturgical and performative. It acts as a seal of orthodoxy and devotion, celebrating the "magnificence" of the monastery and its founder rather than apologizing for the text. Instead of asking the reader for indulgence or forgiveness for his "poor" writing, Renda directs the reader's reception toward an act of collective praise (Figure 30).



Figure 30 Synoptic comparison shows the shift from textual conclusion to liturgical praise.

7.9 Identity Incipit

Both the medieval text and Renda's 1581 work begin with a traditional identity formula based on the pairing of nobility of birth (*nobilitas generis*) and nobility of morals (*nobilitas morum*). The lexical and syntactic similarities between the two versions are so striking that they suggest a close textual relationship. Whether through direct dependence or a very closely shared tradition, this initial section shows that even as the author's

purpose changed, the fundamental language used to define the saint's identity remained remarkably stable (Figure 31).

Unit 02 Incipit, Pueritia, and Interiority	
Incipit and early formation: both texts share the nobilitas-topos, but the MS emphasizes inner rumination and rational detachment, whereas Renda streamlines motivation and accelerates narrative action.	
MS (13th century)	Renda (1581)
nobilitas-topos nobili progenie, morum quidem nobilitate longe preclarior.	nobilitas-topos patria ortus nobili progenie natus, morum nobilitate præclarior.

Figure 31 Synoptic comparison of the incipit shows a shared *nobilitas* topos.

7.10 *Contemptus mundi* and the Construction of Interior Life

The journey from childhood (*pueritia*) to the choice of an ascetic life is a shared theme in both texts, yet the depth of the motivation differs significantly between the two eras. In the medieval manuscript, the withdrawal from the world is presented as a prolonged and intense mental process. The narrator allows the reader to enter William's mind, showing him weighing reality through almost philosophical categories. The world is not just abandoned; it is judged as vain and "sterile". Through the use of absolute formulations (such as *non umquam*) and the core verb *assidue volvebat*, sanctity is portrayed as a continuous labor of thought. William does not leave Vercelli abruptly; he "ruminates" on the project of flight through sustained meditation and cognitive effort. In this context, sanctity is defined by intention and internal struggle (Figure 32).

rational-detachment queque huius mundi vanitati obnoxia, non solum quasi sterilia et nullum afferentia fructum, procul a se animo removit, verum etiam aborrendo contempsit.	—
active-sanctity non tamen umquam iocis ceterisque puerilibus oblectamentis animum dedit, set, morum gravitate puerilem transcendens etatem	—
meditative-rumination assidue volvebat in animo qualiter, patria suisque omnibus derelictis, ad Dei servitium liberius convolare.	—

Figure 32 Synoptic detail shows interior formation and rational detachment in the medieval text but omitted in Renda.

In Renda's 1581 text, the same information exists, but it is organized with more assertive hierarchy: the internal motivation is resolved quickly to move toward action. His William does not evaluate the world's sterility; he simply "despises worldly delights." Where the manuscript builds a moral profile through the struggle to transcend youth, Renda merely certifies that William "gave himself to no vice". The focus shifts from interiority to action. Departure from the homeland is no longer the outcome of long deliberation (*volvere in animo*), but a resolute act (Figure 33).

—	moral-certification nullo vitio animum dedit.
—	resolute-action mundi dilectamenta contemnens, sola diuina mente, revolutus
—	immediate-departure patriam suoque relinquens, ut ad Dei servitium libere euolaret.

Figure 33 Synoptic comparison shows the shift from interior discernment to immediate action.

7.11 Assumption of the habit, *peregrinatio*, and the *faber ferrarius*

The transition to the fourteenth year and the start of the *peregrinatio* are described in almost identical terms in both texts. However, a significant paratextual shift occurs: while the manuscript presents a continuous narrative flow, Renda uses marginal notes to transform the event into an identifiable unit. This anticipates modern navigation and

indexing functions that were absent in the medieval witness (Figure 34)

Unit 03 Peregrinatio and Faber's Episode	
Peregrinatio and the blacksmith: in the MS, authority is grounded in obedience and spiritual submission (ascetic practice defended from within); in Renda, the episode becomes more "navigable," supported by paratext and a more externalized rhetoric of legitimacy.	
MS (13th century)	Renda (1581)
habit-assumptio Quartum decimum igitur hec salutaria meditans annum egressus, habitum sacre religionis assumpsit satisque suo faciens desiderio, relictā patriā, una contextus clamide, nudis etiam pedibus ad beati <i>Iacobi</i> aliorumque sanctorum sacra visendum limina, impiger est iter aggressus.	margin Habitu albo sacrae religionis induitur habit-assumptio Quartumdecimum annum attingens, habitu albo sacrae religionis est indutus, nudus pedibus unaque veste, coeptus paupertatis exemplo Christum imitans; sancti Sepulcrum, beati Iacobi Apostoli, aliorumque sanctorum templa visere cupiens, iter aggreditur.

Figure 34 Synoptic comparison shows peregrinatio as a shift from spiritual obedience to institutional legitimation.

The episode of the *faber ferrarius* shows an extremely high level of convergence. In both versions, the blacksmith is a God-fearing man who welcomes the poor, washes their feet, and provides them a place to rest. William accepts only bread and water and chooses to sleep on a hard surface. The blacksmith is shocked by William's refusal of better food and fears his hospitality is being insulted. William responds by explaining his abstinence as the sequela Christi (following of Christ) and a discipline against vice (Figure 35)

Despite the narrative agreement, the extent of the justification varies significantly between the two authors. In the manuscript, William's response is more articulated and defensive, explicitly asking that his behaviour not be attributed to pride but to humility and remembrance of sins. In Renda, the same meaning is preserved, but the formulation is shorter and more linear, with less development of self-accusatory clauses and moral motive (Figure 35).

hospitality-ritual Erat in ea quidam faber ferrarius, homo quidem magne religionis et Deum timens, cui hospitalitatis gratia Deo accepto, iam diuturni usus in morem converterant, diebus singulis pauperibus dare hospitia, eosque post refectionem, lotis a se pedibus, ad nocturnam quietem stratis lectulis invitare.	hospitality-ritual In quandam urbem circa noctis crepusculum adveniens, a quodam fabro ferrario, magnae religionis viro, fuit susceptus hospitio. Is Dominum amans, Domini servis hospitalitatem impendens, hospitem pedibus lotis, comedenda non pauca parabat.
ascetic-practice Apud quem Dei famulus cum aliis hospitatus, sicut a primo die sue peregrinationis statuerat, solo pane et aqua refectus, cetera eius humanitatis suscipere nolens officia, quietis tempore secundum morem nuda requievit in humo.	ascetic-practice A quo confessor sanctus, solo pane et aqua refectus, cetera sibi apposita renuens, ad nocturnam quietem stratis lectulis invitatus, quietis tempore nudus requievit in humo.
ascetic-defense Et ille: Absit, absit, ut in fraterne dilectionis obsequiis numquam fuerit aliqua michi contemptio vel, quod a Deo creata et humanis usibus deputata, velut sordidam aborrescam. Set, quoniam meorum sum non immemor delictorum, deliciosioribus cibis et potibus sicut plerique peccatores abstineo. Ceterum, quod vestre humilitatis non suscepi officia, ne arrogantiae queso ascribas nec contemptioni adtribuas, set quod vestre sanctitatis officiis me miserum et peccatorem indignum conspicio et quod superbienti et periture parcere carni, nepharium esse existimo.	ascetic-defense Absit ut in caritatis obsequiis, a Deo creata et humano usui deputata, abhorrendo reculem, nec tua non amem obsequia; sed Christi vestigia sequens, a delitiosis cibis potuque, ut possum, abstineo.

Figure 35 Synoptic comparison shows the shift from lived asceticism to exemplary virtue.

7.12 The iron rings

In the medieval manuscript, the episode is defined by an explicit secrecy pact. This framing gives the act of penance a specific spiritual dimension: it is an exercise in voluntary concealment and internal discipline. The meaning of the rings is woven directly into the narrative through this pact of silence. In the printed edition, while insistence on secrecy is reduced, a strongly functional marginal note appears, transferring interpretation from discursive texture to the margin. This shift is crucial: Renda relocates the interpretative burden from narrative development to paratextual framing, precisely the principle that also underlies modern interface logics (indices, segmented views, navigational cues) (Figure 36).

Unit 04 The Iron Hoops and Secrecy	
The iron hoops: technical description is closely shared, yet the MS builds secrecy as a narrative ethic, while Renda shifts interpretive force to the margin and to rapid moral decoding.	
MS (13th century)	Renda (1581)
	margin Circulis ferreis carnem macerat
technical-description Duos ergo michi circulos ferreos ad hunc modum facias, ut eorum unus ventrem pectus alter circundet, a quorum inferiori brachia duo ferrea porrigantur, unum a dextro latere alterum a sinistro. Que per humeros ad alteram inferioris circuli partem pervenientia, utrimque predictis circulis fortiter clavis colligentur.	technical-description Quorum altero pectus, altero ventrem circumdaret, et per humeros duae protenderentur laminae ferreae, strictis clavibus circuli utrisque colligarentur.
interior-discipline Tu autem quod petiero, sicut libenter attribues, ita rogo ut in silentio habeas, et quod dederis pretium, ad nullius precor aures.	

Figure 36 Synoptic comparison shows the shift from interior secrecy to marginal moral decoding.

7.13 The miracle of the blind man

In both versions, the healing of the blind man follows an identical structure: the daughter signals the praying saint, the blind man is brought forward, William attributes the healing to a "visitation from God" (visitatio Dei), and the man wakes from a sudden sleep with restored sight. However, the interpretation of the miracle's aftermath reveals a significant shift in authorial focus. (Figure 37).

Unit 05 The Blind Man's Miracle: From Habit to a Crisis of Humility	
The blind man's miracle: both preserve the prodigy and the saint's refusal of personal glory, but the MS expands the episode into a fuller drama of humility and reputation, whereas Renda segments it as a discrete, quickly consultable miracle unit.	
MS (13th century)	Renda (1581)
	margin Caecum illuminat
incipit Per idem tempus, homo quidam erat in prefato loco, qui lumen amiserat oculorum.	incipit Die quadam evenit ut Christi confessor sub ardenti sole in solitariis rupibus Deum oraret.
discovery-ritual Hunc dum forte ab agro redeuntem filia duceret, eminus aspiciens, tunc eidem e vestigio nuntiare curavit, quod Guilielmum heremitam in rupe fixis genibus orantem videret.	discovery-ritual Quo tempore oppidi vir erat oculorum lumine cassus, quem redeuntem ab agro eius filia dum duceret, eminus aspiciens eidem nuntiare curavit Dei Sanctum orantem vidisse genibus saepe flexis in rupe; sed caecus ductus a filia sancti pedibus volutans, ut lumen recipiat, precibus petebat assiduus.

scenography-contemplative Erat namque sancto viro in consuetudine, dum maximus estus solis incumberet, ad rupem quandam exire ubi verum solem iusticie totis nisibus implorare.	—
petition Qui protinus, spe sue salutis concepta, filiam orat, ut ad venerabilem Dei virum eum perduceret. Cum ergo ad <i>Guilielmum</i> esset homo perductus, provolutus ad genua eius, rei familiaris inopiam, curam alende sobolis pretendens, miserabiliter cepit orare, ut, sui miseritus, lumen sibi rederet oculorum.	—

Figure 37 Synoptic comparison shows the shift from dramatic humility to segmented miracle.

In the thirteenth-century text, the miracle is not the conclusion but the start of a deep spiritual crisis. The narrator explores William's inner unrest (*inquietude*) as public fame erupts. Described as a "foremost guardian of humility" (*precipuus humilitatis custos*), William views the "popular breeze" (*popularis aura*) as a threat that could inflate the ego and destroy his ascetic discipline. His decision to flee toward Jerusalem is framed as a necessary act of spiritual self-preservation. In this context, sanctity is defined not just by the power to heal, but by the ability to resist the glory that follows (Figure 38). Renda retains the theme of William's fear of human glory, but he fundamentally alters the way this information is delivered to the reader. The 1581 edition transforms the episode into a clearly labeled, isolated segment. Headings and marginalia, such as *Cæcus illuminat* (The blind man illuminated), allow the reader to identify the event instantly. These paratextual tools accelerate the transition between events; the moral lesson is not lost, but it is rendered immediately accessible and searchable rather than being buried in a long narrative exploration of the saint's mind. (Figure 38).

humility-defense Quod ubi vir Domini audivit, id sue virtutis non esse commemorans, eius condolens infortunio, cepit continuo ammonere, quatinus in tribulationibus a Dei servitio non cessaret. Potens est enim, aiebat « qui percutit, et mederi ».	humility-defense Quod vir Dei ut audivit, et id suae non esse virtutis commemorans, caeco passiones ac tribulationes Dei visitationes esse nuntiat; et dum haec loqueretur admonens, infirmus sopori datur.
miracle-event Dum hec et his similia santus vir eum ammonens loqueretur, predictus homo sopori concessit. Qui tandem, sompno evigilans, benedictione a sancto accepta, continuo ut est domum regressus, lumen quod amiserat clarius quam umquam habuerat recepit.	miracle-event Oratione facta, vir Dei ut a somno surgeret dixit; qui expergefactus, Sancti intercessionis merito, visus lumen quod amiserat recepit clarius.
ascetic-crisis Quod ubi precipus humilitatis custos audivit, plurimum contristatus simulque veritus ne popularibus auris moveretur, utcumque statuit inde recedere seque ad Hierosolymam conferre.	ascetic-crisis Quo audito miraculo, ingens sanctitatis increbuit publica fama; quod Dei famulus audiens, et ne populari moveretur aura, inde discedere statuit.

Figure 38 Synoptic comparison shows the shift from humility and crisis to isolated miracle.

7.14 Ioannes – *latrones* – *visio in igne*

The sequence involving the encounter with the venerable Ioannes, the attack by bandits (*latrones*), and the concluding divine vision represents one of the most stable theological nodes in the *Vita*. In both the medieval manuscript and Renda's 1581 edition, this "vocational unit" maintains surprising structural consistency, adhering to the same order of events and overall meaning (Figure 39).

Unit 06 Ioannes, the Brigands, and the Vocational Vision: Discernment of Mission	
Vocational unit (Ioannes – brigands – vision in fire): a highly stable narrative sequence; Renda strengthens the turning point through paratext (margin note) and compresses connective tissue, reinforcing the scene as an immediately identifiable node.	
MS (13th century)	Renda (1581)
margin In ignis flamma apparuit ei Dominus	
encounter Erat eo tempore magni meriti magnique nominis vir quidam Deo devotus nomine Iohannes, pater cuiusdam monasterii, quod iuxta Genusium ipse construxerat. De huius itaque sancti viri fama, cum predictae rei gratia faciens iter audisset, opere pretium sui laboris esse putavit, si ab incepto itinere declinaret, causa colloquendi cum predicto Dei viro.	encounter Eodem tempore quo iter aggreditur, venerabilis vir Ioannes nomine, cuiusdam Monasterii, quod ipsemet iuxta Genusium aedificaverat pater existens, eius Confessor Sanctus fama motus, ut cum eo loqueretur, ab incepto declinavit illic manere.
spiritual-dialogue Ubi ergo in mutuos ruentes amplexus conveniunt, vicissimque datur copia fandi, sermo inter eos non fuit (quid enim tales potius loquerentur?) nisi de contemptu rerum mundanarum et celestium appetitu, et qualiter soli Deo sit serviendum.	spiritual-dialogue At ubi conveniunt, in mutuos ruentes amplexus, de mundi contemptu, stimulis carnis, diaboli fraudibus, de fundamento virtutum, caritate, ac qualiter Deo sit serviendum, sunt collocuti vicissim.

Figure 39 Synoptic comparison shows a stable vocational unit shared by both witnesses.

The core of this episode is the conflict between individual intention (*propositum*), William's desire to reach Jerusalem—and communal benefit (*utilitas communis*). Ioannes advises William that staying to save the faithful is more useful than his personal pilgrimage. When William ignores this advice, he is attacked by bandits, an event that serves as a providential indicator that his original plan is blocked. In both texts, the violence is set in Apulia, described as not yet pacified by Roger (the restorer of justice). This historical frame anchors the divine intervention in a real-world horizon. (Figure 40).

pastoral-argument Altero die, profecturus a predicto viro, licentiam petiit, insinuans quod orationis causa Hierosolymam tendere vellet, suumque desiderium amplius differre non posse. Et ille: « Noli, frater, frustra fatigari, noli quod adimplere non poteris, non profecturus incipere. Maior est quippe ad fidelium salutem tua mora utilitas quam propositi fieri pro voluntate participem ».	pastoral-argument Altera die Hierosolymam abeundi veniam petiit; quod ne faceret, cum eius praesentia fidelibus maior fuisset utilitas, a patre praedicto saepius admonetur.
historical-context Cuius monitis ardore sancti itineris nolens prebere ascensum, mox iter arripuit. Qui cum iuxta Oream devenisset, a latronibus detentus, crudis est affectus verberibus. Nondum etenim patruelia regna hereditario iure capessens, ille iniquorum omnium metus, equitatis amator, malorum omnium exterminator, optimus siquidem tranquillatis et pacis patronus, Rogerius videlicet, rex magnificentissimus, feliciter triumphans a rapacium et latronum faucibus Apuliam liberat.	historical-context Cui nequaquam parens, arrepto itinere, iuxta Oream devenit, et a latronibus saevis flagellis fuit affectus. Non dum enim patruelia regna hereditario iure Rogerius Rex capessens, a Sarracenorum faucibus Apuliam liberat.
discernment-climax In hoc tandem certis cognovit indiciis, secundum Dei famuli dictum, quod corde gerebat, opere complere non posse.	discernment-climax Quibus Dei Sanctus cognoscit indiciis se quod corde gerebat ac primum propositum opere non posse complere.

Figure 40 Synoptic comparison shows the shift from personal intention to communal utility, historicized through violence.

The final turning point is the vision of the Lord in a flame of fire, which resolves the tension between William's plan and the divine will. In Renda's *editio princeps*, the marginal note foregrounds this miracle, turning a narrative climax into a searchable, identifiable node. In both witnesses, the outcome is the same: the private pilgrimage to Jerusalem is officially replaced by a communal mission to found a religious center (Figure 41).

forced-return Necessitate itaque compellente, ad predictum patrem sub omni est celeritate regressus. A quo, dum per singulos dies fraterna dilectione, ut secum cohabitaret, plurimum rogaretur, ei Dominus in visu apparuit, predicens quod et ipse per se congregationem fidelium esset facturus ideoque oportere inde ipsum recedere, alibi Domino servituum.	forced-return Necessitate impellente, prope ad praedictum Ioannem Patrem est reversus, a quo in dies, ut secum cohabitaret, magna dilectione rogatur.
divine-revelation Et volutis ergo diebus quindecim, predicti viri voluntati renunciavit, prosequens diligenter que fuerant sibi iniuncta a Domino.	divine-revelation Cui Guilielmo Sanctissimo nocte oranti ignis flamma apparuit Dominus, praedicens ipsum alibi Deo servituum et fidelium Congregationem esse facturum.

Figure 41 Synoptic comparison shows the shift from negative sign to revelatory reassignment.

7.15 The *Lorica* and the *Cophia*: From Secret Penance to Ascetic Archive

The transition from the broken iron rings to the acquisition of the *lorica* (iron tunic) and the *cophia* (iron head covering) highlights a fundamental shift in how sanctity is "seen" by the reader. In the thirteenth-century text, the shift to heavier iron is driven by an explicit psychological and moral motivation such as the Risk of Visibility: because the iron rings break frequently, William is forced to visit blacksmiths often. This "public exposure" threatens his humility. The journey to Salerno to obtain a *lorica* is not just about increasing physical pain, but about protecting humility. By wearing a full tunic under his clothes, William can keep his penance entirely hidden from the public eye.

This logic peaks with the *cophia*. Authentic asceticism is presented as invisible; its value lies in its withdrawal from the human gaze. The iron head covering becomes a material emblem of the interior virtue of secrecy (Figure 42). Renda preserves the entire sequence, Tripaldum, the broken rings, Salerno, and the acquisition of the iron gear, but he strips away the deep psychological layers. The narrative moves rapidly from the practical inconvenience of the broken rings to the intensification of asceticism. The *lorica* is presented as a tool for increased mortification rather than a strategy of concealment. In the 1581 edition, the episode is framed by marginal glosses that immediately interpret the objects in penitential terms. The reader is guided to understand the function of the iron at a glance. While the *cophia* is mentioned, its role as a secret moral quality is attenuated. Instead of a hidden symbol of invisibility, it becomes a documented item in the saint's "ascetic armoury", an identifiable unit of his holiness (Figure 42).

Unit 07 Loricæ et Cophia: Ascetic Intensification and Concealment	
Loricæ and cophia: the MS foregrounds invisibility and fear of praise as moral strategy; Renda retains the ascetic armament but favors a quicker penitential reading, reinforced by marginal interpretation and indexing cues.	
MS (13th century)	Renda (1581)
margin Loricæ magni ponderis carnem macerat	
itinerary Inde itaque, accepta profectus licentia, per montana iter facere coepit, loca singula diligentius explorando solitariae vitae convenientia. Pervenit Tripaldum , quod non multum distat a Virgiliano monte. In hoc vico in domo cuiusdam matronae aliquantulum commoratus.	itinerary Ad Atripaldum , quod non longe abest a Virgiliano Monte, quem ad solam vitam degendam opportunum esse cognovit, pervenit. In domo Matronae cuiusdam acceptus hospitio.
penitential-limit Interea quoniam circuli, quos ad carnis macerationem induerat, frequentius rumpebantur, eosque totiens ferrariis ostendere et similes fieri ab ipsis quaerere oportebat, plausum hominum metuens vir prudentioris consilii Salernum proficiscitur.	penitential-limit Circulos ferreos, quos portabat, ruptos invenit.
lorica-intent Sperans ibi aliquem invenire a quo ferream loricae numquam depositurus acciperet.	lorica-intent Vir prudentioris consilii, ne quos secrete nudam carnem domabat palam ostendere aliis, ut a milite quodam magni ponderis loricae, illam numquam depositurus, quaerens acciperet, Salernum proficiscitur.
lorica-acquisition Nec eum fefellit opinio. Nam postquam primum Salernum fuit ingressus, quidam miles occurrens, eius cognita voluntate, quotquot habuit loricæ ostendit eiusque subiecit arbitrio ut quam vellet meliorem acciperet. Maioris itaque ponderis vestem indutus, compos voti effectus, gratulabundus ad predictum remeat vicum.	lorica-acquisition Quam statim ingresso Dei viro miles occurrit; eius petitioni loricæ, ut meliorem reciperet, quotquot habuit libenter ostendit; quarum maioris ponderis unam accepit, et illa sub veste indutus, iterum Atripaldum remeat.
lorica-secrecy Maioris ponderis vestem indutus, sub habitu perseverabat, ne maceratio carnis palam hominibus appareret.	lorica-secrecy Illa sub veste indutus, nuda carne coopertus, occulto habitu perseverabat.
cophia-acquisition In quo etiam, ut galeatus secure posset ad bellum procedere, ad modum sui capitis ferreum tegmen sibi fieri iussit, quod vulgo cophia dicitur.	cophia-acquisition Et in domo praedictae Matronae dum commoraret, capitis tegmen ferreum est adeptus.
cophia-secrecy Quam postquam Domini miles in capite sumpsit, eam ulterius non removet, sicque eam latenter portavit, ut vitae suae tempore nemini umquam foret compertum.	cophia-secrecy Capiti imponens, et a nemine compertum, ulterius non removet.

Figure 42 Synoptic comparison shows the shift from ascetic concealment to legible mortification.

7.16 The Spring and the Bear: Sacred Labor and Restored Harmony

The discovery of the spring and the subsequent encounter with the bear represent a moment of narrative stability, where the "horizontal" reality of physical work resists being replaced by purely "vertical" divine intervention. In both the medieval manuscript and

Renda's 1581 edition, the discovery of the *fons Sancti Guilielmi* is presented as a realistic, step-by-step process rather than an abstract miracle. The spring is found through a combination of observation, hard physical labor, and civil mediation (diplomacy). The water is considered holy not because it appeared out of thin air (*ex nihilo*), but because of the immense effort required to find and secure it. It is a moment where sanctity confronts human laws and physical exhaustion before it becomes an object of devotion. While the story remains the same, Renda's marginal label acts as a "cutting tool." It extracts this long narrative chain and transforms it into a countable unit, ready to be cataloged as a specific institutional asset (Figure 43).

Unit 08 Fons et Ursus: Empirical Discovery and Restoration of Order	
The spring and the bear: effort and miracle are interwoven; the MS integrates the prodigy into eremitic routine (damage–repair–repetition–rebutal), while Renda adds an “empirical search/persistence” prelude and labels the episode as a catalogable miracle.	
MS (13th century)	Renda (1581)
—	margin Miraculum de Urso fontem perturbante
—	empirical-search Una die Confessor Sanctus, aquam, quam volebat in montis cacumine posse inveniri, cum socio Petro cuncta perquirens, lutum ursarum vestigiis conculcatum inspicit; quod manibus, prius orando elevatis in caelum, genibus flexis, effodientes aliquantulum aquae invenere surgentis.
—	persistence Mane sequenti, pro penuria aquae non modicum solliciti, affluentiore quaerentes, solito labori non parcendo, montana discurrunt.
discovery-damage Die quadam, cum gratia hauriendi aquam cella exiret, Dei famulus in praedicto fonte parum aquae invenit; ursus enim veniens fontem conculcaverat et eum fere oppilaverat.	—
restoration-labor Quid multa? Fontem restituit, domum regressus est.	—
iterative-struggle ursus autem nihilominus, singulis diebus adveniens, aquam sorbebat, fontem conculcabat.	iterative-struggle At ursus pluries hoc faciens, fontem perturbat.
patience-limit Quod cum diu perpetiretur Guilielmus , die quadam ad hauriendum aquam egressus, beluam bibentem invenit.	patience-limit Cui vir Dei unica die imperat.
holy-rebuke Eamque his verbis alloquitur: «Quid est quod agis? Alieno, ut video, labori iniuriose incumbis; aquam, quam propriis manibus ego effodio, perturbas et sorbes. Vade hinc et cave ulterius ne accedas».	holy-rebuke «Quid agis? Alieno labori non parcis? Fontem, quem manibus purgo, tu indies post potum saepe conturbas? Amplius cave ne venias».

Figure 43 Synoptic comparison shows spring sanctified through labour and mediation, not ex nihilo miracle.

The correspondence between the two witnesses becomes almost verbatim during the episode of the bear. The rhetorical power of this scene was clearly seen as untouchable by Renda. When the bear enters and muddies the spring, the "miracle" is not a display of violence, but a restoration of order. The animal does not roar; instead, it lowers its head, loses its ferocity, and slips away into the woods, never to return. This scene evokes the image of Eden, where sanctity restores the lost harmony between man and nature. The

"word of the just man" exercises a natural authority over beasts, returning the world to a state of original peace.(Figure 44).

miracle-response Ad cuius imperium venerandi patris, mox depresso in terra capite ursus, nihil feritatis ostendens, protinus recessit et ad fontem amplius non est reversus.	miracle-response Qui venerandi patris imperio, demisso capite, ursus, nil feritatis ostendens, facti poenitens, erubescens, ac amplius non reversus, aufugit.
--	--

Figure 44 Synoptic comparison shows harmony restored through the saint's word.

7.17 The Foundation of Montevergine: From Communal Practice to Institutional Monument

The narrative regarding the foundation of the monastery and William's eventual departure is where Renda's 1581 rewriting most aggressively transforms the text. While the medieval manuscript treats the foundation as a sober, organic process, Rendareimagines it as a monumental historical event. In the thirteenth-century manuscript, the foundation is described with restraint: William is on the mountain, people arrive, and a church is built. The focus is on managing offerings and internal group dynamics. (Figure 45).

setting Virgiliano mons, in quo cum ante latis presbiteris et nonnullis aliis fratribus habitabat, ob nimiam frigiditatis intemperantiam, nisi in tribus mensibus difficilis est et ad ascendendum valde laboriosus.	setting Quo die (ut nunc fit etiam) maxima populi multitudo confluens aurum, argentum et alia asportabat;
offerings tempore ergo quo poterat, maxima populi multitudo ad eum confluens, aurum, argentum et quae habere poterant ad pedes eius offerebant.	offerings quae Pater benigne suscipiens,
dispensatio quae benigne suscipiens, tamquam bonus dispensator, quae necessaria noverat fratribus retinebat, cetera pauperibus erogabat.	dispensatio necessaria monachis retinebat; alia pauperibus erogabat.

Figure 45 Synoptic comparison shows the shift from sober foundation to interpretative expansion.

Renda's early modern intervention adds layers of "spectacular" sacrality. William prays for two days, personally digs the foundations, and marks the first stone with a cross. Renda adds a chronological marginal note fixing the date as 10 April 1124. This

transforms a legendary narrative into a verifiable "birth certificate" for the Order to present to contemporary legal and ecclesiastical authorities (Figure 46).

MS (13th century)	Renda (1581)
	margin Ecclesiam Montis Virginis Sanctus erigit anno 1124 die decimo mensis Aprilis
	margin Miraculum aridi brachii Gualterii
	margin Die tertia Maii Ecclesia completa inspicitur
	margin Prima dedicatio Ecclesiae Sanctae Mariae Virginis
	margin Sanctus mutam facit loqui
	margin Lupus pro asino facit servire
	margin Exemptio facta ab Episcopo Abellinensi
	margin Sacerdotum murmuratio
	margin Primus Abbas Guilielmus
	margin Secundus Abbas loco eligitur D. Albertus nomine
	margin Regulam diui Benedicti pro norma tradit
	margin Esus carnis, ouorum, & casei prohibet cum suis

Figure 46 Synoptic comparison shows the shift from narrative flow to dated, indexed foundation.

A further divergence concerns the density and function of prodigies. In the manuscript miracles like the healing of the mute woman (*De muliere muta*) are autonomous sections that slowly build William's reputation *before* the foundation begins. Renda, instead, integrates miracles directly into the building site. He adds the healing of the architect Gualtiero's withered arm (absent in the manuscript), framing it as spectacular proof that God endorses the construction and guarantees its success (Figure 47).

	miracle-mute In qua erat mulier quae per annos septem muta silebat; ad Sancti tamen Confessoris interrogationem libera voce respondit. Quo viso miraculo omnes Guilielmum Sanctum praedicare coeperunt.
	miracle-wolf In nomine Gloriosae Virginis Pater Sanctus lupo imperat quod opera quae per Asellum fierent ipse subiret; qui feritate reiecta, capite flexo viri Dei suscipit imperia; atque inceptum ab Asino opus usque ad eius vitae spatium, non sine aspicientium admiratione, libenter perficit; his multisque miraculis templum et Monasterium construxit et auxit.

	miracle-builder At dum ipsa construeretur Ecclesia, quidam ligur Gualterius nomine advena, aridum brachium habens, arte architectonica non ignarus, dum assisteret, ad locum venit eundem, quem tamen exploratorem circumeuntem et insipientem Domini Confessor interrogat: «Num talis operis es artifex? Incipe operari». At ille brachium aridum ostendens, talia voce profudit: «O beatissime Pater, libenter quod tua sanctitas praecipit obsecundarem obediens. Ecce in Liguriae partibus architectonicae arte peritus, divina puniente iustitia et meis peccatis exigentibus eam, dum turrin construerem cecidi, ita ut hoc brachium irremediabiliter perderem». Quod intuens Dei Confessor confisus in Domino ei lapidem ostendit dicens: «In nomine Iesu sume lapidem illum et aedificio compone»; qui vestigio parens, sospitatem recuperat.
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Figure 47 Synoptic comparison shows the shift from ethical foundation to miraculous proof.

Interestingly, the conflict over money remains almost identical in both texts. Both describe William as a "good steward" who gives everything to the poor, infuriating the priests who demand a treasury. Renda does not soften William's evangelical radicalism. This suggests that even during the Counter-Reformation, the founder's absolute poverty was a non-negotiable part of the Order's identity (Figure 48)

presbyters-request hec sacerdotes intuiti, avaritiae telo iam dudum percussi et ad misericordia Dei diffisi, ceperunt prius blandis vocibus venerabili patri rogando persuadere, quatinus in futuro providens, quae offerrentur non tam largius expenderet, set potius arcam inveniret, in qua ad opus ipsius ecclesiae pecunia reponderetur.	presbyters-request Quod praedicti presbyteri, per habitus susceptionem monachi effecti, a cupida avaritia ducti, misericordia Dei diffisi, ne hoc faceret expostulabant;
fear of poverty posse etenim fieri testabantur, quod ab hac liberalitate populus cessaret ipsique rerum necessariarum temptarentur inopia.	fear of poverty postea hoc fieri testabantur, ut populi ab hac liberalitate cessarent, ipsique inopia rerum tenerentur.
escalation qui, postquam secus ac arbitrati sunt rem vident procedere neque eorum precibus dari assensum, testabantur enim venerabilis pater ecclesiam pecunia potius destrui quam edificari ipsosque nichil terrenum debere in saeculo possidere.	escalation At potius iidem praeter eorum opinionem evenire vident; dentibus infrendentes res eorum meritis acquisitas deseri et non pauperibus erogari,
accusation tandem insanis vocibus in clamorem prorumpunt, dicentes eum contra ius facere, cum bona ecclesiae, quae comunia sunt, quae etiam plus pro suis officiis et orationibus quam pro suis meritis offerebantur, eis invitis pauperibus erogaret.	accusation ante Christi Confessorem prorumpunt.
response-intro ille vero, ad eorum clamores humiliter ac blande respondens, talibus est eos exhortatus alloquiis:	response-intro Quod Dei famulus sentiens, dictis illos solatur amicis; cognoscens autem se inter illos non posse proficere.

Figure 48 Synoptic comparison shows correspondence in the episode of financial conflict.

The most revealing metamorphosis occurs in how William leaves the monastery when the conflict becomes irreconcilable. In the manuscript this is a gesture of prudence: he departs to avoid harming his own soul and those of others, seeking silence at Laceno—a choice of individual spiritual freedom. In Renda it becomes an institutional handover. Before departing, William is called “First Abbot,” appoints Alberto as successor (“Second Abbot”), and fixes enduring dietary rules (no meat, eggs, or cheese). The shift is not doctrinal but organizational: Renda recasts withdrawal as continuity, ensuring that departure does not interrupt institutional stability (Figure 49).

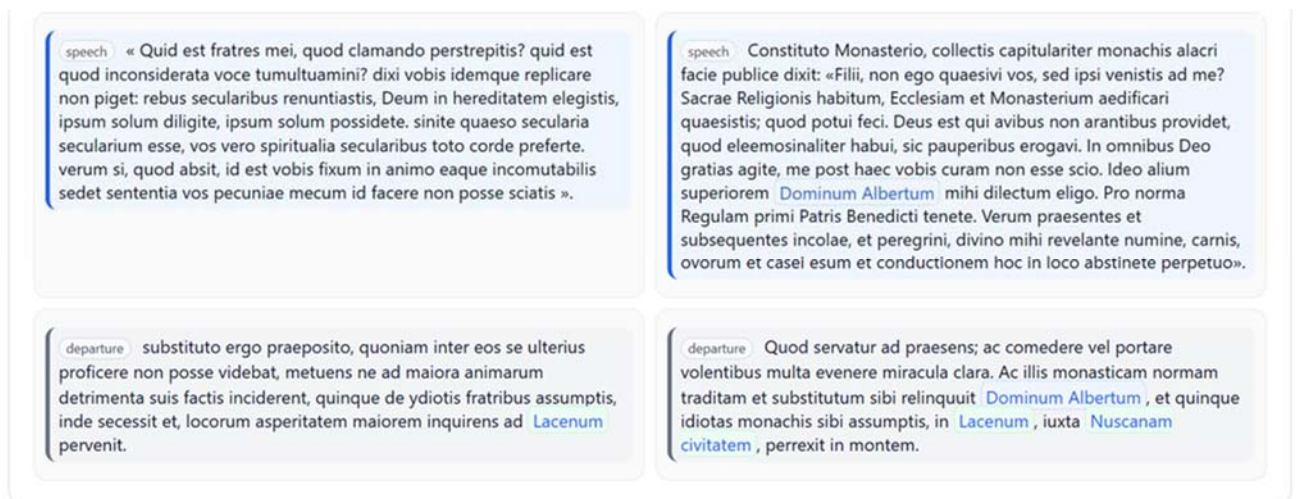


Figure 49 Synoptic comparison shows the shift from spiritual exit to organizational handover.

The comparative analysis conducted in this chapter has demonstrated that the relationship between the thirteenth-century manuscript and the 1581 printed edition is not one of simple transmission, but of structural and functional transformation. While the narrative skeleton remains largely stable: episodes, theological turning points, and key motifs often correspond closely, the communicative logic of the text changes profoundly.

Chapter VIII – Results

The primary research output of this project is the interactive digital edition⁷⁷, generated through XSLT transformation of the TEI-XML corpus. More than a mere presentation layer, this environment constitutes the methodological core of the thesis: it translates textual encoding into an operational analytical space. Rather than offering a linear transcription to be passively read, the interface enables multidimensional inquiry through structured comparison, entity navigation, and spatial exploration. In doing so, it effectively redefines the relationship between philological encoding and scholarly interpretation, moving from static data to dynamic knowledge.

8.1 Synoptic Architecture and Functional Comparison

The core of the interface is a dual-pane synoptic layout that operationalizes the comparative architecture defined in the TEI <group>. Rather than a static side-by-side display, alignment is programmatically enforced through shared @n attributes at the unit level. The XSLT transformation leverages these identifiers to synchronize the thirteenth-century manuscript with Renda's 1581 edition, grounding the comparison in encoded structure rather than visual proximity. Interactive features, such as scroll-lock synchronization and segment highlighting on hover—render the analytical categories (e.g., *authorial-fear* vs. *institutional-legitimation*) as a visual grammar. This materializes the thesis's core argument: that the transition from manuscript to print was a deliberate rhetorical and functional shift.

8.2 Paratext as Filterable Metadata

The systematic marginalia of the 1581 edition, encoded via <note place="margin">, are transformed from peripheral annotations into structured, searchable data. By converting these notes into clickable blocks, the interface allows users to isolate categories such as

⁷⁷ <https://depMichelle.github.io/thesis-s-code/>

Miracula, *Chronologia*, or *Locus*. This transition from narrative flow to modular "data units" reveals Renda's editorial strategy: the transformation of a continuous spiritual biography into a didactic, consultable archive. Material features of early modern printing are thus reconceived as a functional infrastructure for information retrieval.

8.3 Geographical Modeling and Spatial Interactivity

The edition operationalizes TEI geographic metadata through an integrated Leaflet/OpenStreetMap module. This layer moves beyond illustrative cartography by linking <geo> coordinates directly to the encoded text. Selecting a place name in the edition triggers a dynamic "center-map" action. The map reconstructs the Order's expansion and the saint's itinerary, visualizing how sacred memory is tied to specific territorial claims. This spatial layer demonstrates that hagiographic geography is not merely descriptive but a structural component of the institution's identity, made visible through the translation of XML coordinates into a navigable research tool.

8.4 Authority Files and Entity-Centered Navigation

Traditional indices are reconfigured as dynamic authority files within the <teiHeader>. The <listPerson> and <listPlace> elements act as centralized registries, which the interface exposes through expandable panels. Through bidirectional linking, every entity, from Saint William to King Roger, serves as a research node. Users can navigate from an entry in the authority list to every specific occurrence across both witnesses. This transforms passive labels into structured data points, enabling a prosopographical and network-based analysis of the *Vita*'s historical and legendary actors.

8.5 Methodological Transparency: The Header as Apparatus

In this environment, metadata is not hidden but foregrounded as a scholarly apparatus. The interface explicitly displays the contents of the <teiHeader>. In this way the user is not presented with a closed product but with a verifiable interpretative model where every editorial intervention is open to critical examination.

8.6 Current Limitations of the Model

Despite the analytical and methodological achievements described above, the project presents structural limitations that form an integral part of its critical reflection. These constraints do not weaken the validity of the model; rather, they clarify its epistemological boundaries and define trajectories for future development.

8.6.1 Manual Segmentation and Interpretative Subjectivity

A primary reflection concerns the nature of the typological classification within the segments. Categories such as *rhetorical-function*, *institutional-emphasis*, or *miracle-structure* are not neutral, automatically generated data points; they are hermeneutic decisions assigned through scholarly interpretation. While the digital environment renders these interpretative acts transparent, encoding them explicitly via `<seg type="...">` attributes, it does not eliminate subjectivity. Instead, it formalizes it. The digital environment renders interpretation visible and verifiable, but it remains dependent on editorial judgment. In this sense, the model exemplifies a key principle of digital philology: encoding is not neutral transcription but structured interpretation.

8.6.2 Granularity and the Macro-Structural Focus

Currently, the alignment mechanism operates at the level of narrative units (`@n`) and functional segments. While this facilitates a comparative analysis of hagiographic strategies, the model does not yet descend into the micro-lexical layer. This means that while macro-structural transformations are computationally visible, finer details, such as sentence-by-sentence variations, clause-level shifts, or specific lexical substitutions, are not yet aligned. The focus remains on rhetorical and institutional recalibrations rather than syntactic or lemmatized comparison.

8.6.3 The Gap in Paleographic Integration

Although the edition is built upon rigorous manuscript transcription and HTR workflows, a significant limitation lies in the current lack of direct synchronization between the

encoded text and the original manuscript images. As a result, materiality is effectively captured at the structural and paratextual levels, but it is not yet fully integrated at the visual-paleographic level.

8.6.4 From Exploratory Interaction to Computational Analytics

Finally, while the HTML output is dynamic in its navigational affordances, supporting synchronized scrolling, filtering, and geospatial interaction, it remains a "read-only" environment in terms of complex data generation. The interface functions as an exploratory and comparative tool rather than a fully data-driven analytical dashboard. Currently, the model cannot automatically generate comparative statistics by segment type or provide frequency analysis across witnesses.

8.7 Future Developments

The limitations identified in the previous section do not signal conceptual weaknesses; rather, they delineate a structured roadmap for the next phase of development. Each constraint points toward a potential methodological and technical expansion, aimed at transforming the current edition from a comparative environment into a fully integrated digital research ecosystem.

8.7.1 Modeling Interpretative Plurality

The acknowledged subjectivity of manual segmentation opens the door to a more reflexive encoding architecture. Future iterations of the project could move beyond a single interpretative layer by adopting stand-off markup. This would allow for multiple, parallel typological layers, theological, rhetorical, or institutional, to coexist without cluttering the primary XML tree. By integrating provenance tracking (using attributes like `@resp` and `@cert`) and Git-based collaborative workflows, the edition could explicitly document degrees of editorial certainty. In this framework, interpretation is no longer a singular, static claim but a documented, layered, and dialogic process.

8.7.2 From Macro-Structure to Micro-Lexical Analysis

The current macro-structural alignment provides a foundation that can be extended into the realm of computational linguistics. By moving from narrative units to tokenized segmentation (using TEI <s> or <w> elements), the model could support lemma-based alignment and automated collation via tools like CollateX⁷⁸. Such an evolution would allow the project to move from observing structural comparability to measuring textual variance. Researchers would be able to perform quantitative analyses on institutional vocabulary or miracle-related terminology, bridging the gap between qualitative rhetorical comparison and stylometric investigation.

8.7.3 Reintegrating Materiality: IIIF and Paleographic Layers

A major trajectory for future development concerns the visual reintegration of manuscript materiality. By implementing the International Image Interoperability Framework (IIIF), the interface could provide high-resolution, synchronized viewing of the original folios alongside the transcription⁷⁹. Linking specific segments to image coordinates via @facs attributes would complete the model's treatment of materiality as computable infrastructure. Furthermore, adding paleographic annotation layers, detailing scribal hands, abbreviations, and correction patterns, would allow the digital environment to support traditional diplomatic analysis alongside its existing structural affordances.

⁷⁸ CollateX is an open-source software for the automated collation of textual witnesses. Widely used in digital philology and digital humanities, it enables sequence alignment at token, word, or character level and supports computational generation of textual variants and TEI-compatible outputs. It is particularly suited for micro-lexical comparison and the production of digital synoptic editions. See: Ronald Haentjens Dekker, *CollateX*, released 2023, <https://collatex.net/>.

⁷⁹ The International Image Interoperability Framework (IIIF) is a consortium-developed set of open standards designed to enable interoperable, high-resolution image delivery and synchronized viewing across digital cultural heritage collections. The IIIF Presentation API provides structured metadata for organizing and displaying digitized manuscripts within interactive environments. See: International Image Interoperability Framework Consortium, *IIIF Presentation API 3.0 Specification*, Technical Specification (IIIF Consortium, 2023), <https://iiif.io/api/presentation/3.0/>.

8.7.4 The Transition to a Data-Driven Research Laboratory

While the current HTML interface is highly interactive, it remains a "read-only" environment. The next logical step is to transition toward a data-driven research platform powered by an XML-native database like eXist-db⁸⁰. This would enable real-time XQuery-based interrogation, allowing users to generate their own comparative metrics and frequency tables on the fly. The goal is to transform the edition into a computational laboratory where narrative patterns, entity networks, and spatial data are not just navigable but extractable for use in external analytical environments such as Python⁸¹ or Gephi⁸².

⁸⁰ eXist-db is an open-source native XML database designed for storing, querying, and managing structured XML documents. It supports XQuery and related web technologies, enabling real-time interrogation of encoded corpora and the dynamic generation of analytical outputs. Its architecture makes it particularly suitable for digital scholarly editions and data-driven research environments based on TEI-XML. See: eXist-db Project, 'eXist-Db Open Source Native XML Database', Technical Documentation, eXist-db Project, <https://exist-db.org/>.

⁸¹ Python is an open-source, high-level programming language widely adopted in scientific computing, data analysis, and digital humanities workflows. Its extensive ecosystem of libraries supports statistical analysis, text processing, and network computation. See: Guido Van Rossum, *Python*, Python Software Foundation, released present 1995, <https://www.python.org/>.

⁸² Gephi is an open-source software platform for network analysis and visualization, frequently employed in digital humanities research for mapping entity relationships and exploring graph structures. See: Mathieu Bastian et al., *Gephi*, Gephi Consortium, released present 2009, <https://gephi.org/>.

Conclusion

The digital synoptic edition and comparative analysis presented in this thesis demonstrate that the transition of the *Legenda Sancti Guilielmi* from a thirteenth-century Beneventan manuscript to Felice Renda's 1581 printed edition was not a neutral act of preservation, but a radical institutional refunctionalization. Through the lens of digital philology, I have observed how a narrative born of ascetic interiority and spiritual "ruminatio" was systematically reconfigured into a searchable, didactic, and politically legitimized archive. The medieval author's "fear" and emphasis on the saint's hidden life were replaced by Renda's celebration of Montevergine as a "sacred city", a transformation rendered visible in this project through the explicit tagging of functional segments and paratextual marginalia. Methodologically, this work argues that the TEI-XML environment is not just a tool for storage, but a space for "computational hagiography." By modeling materiality as computable infrastructure, where marginal notes become filters and toponyms become coordinates, this project bridges the gap between traditional diplomatic philology and modern data science. In conclusion, the digital output serves as a prototype for a new kind of scholarly interaction with hagiographic sources. While the current model has boundaries regarding lexical granularity and paleographic synchronization, it establishes a verifiable and extensible framework. By documenting its own interpretative subjectivity and providing a roadmap for future IIIF and HTR integration, this project moves toward a sustainable research infrastructure. Ultimately, it proves that the digital medium does not flatten the historical depth of the text; rather, it provides the multi-layered visibility necessary to understand how the memory of a saint is constructed, negotiated, and stabilized across the centuries.

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Appendix A – Full Normalized Transcriptions

A.1 - Thirteenth-Century Manuscript (Normalized Text)

The following transcription presents the fully normalized Latin text of the thirteenth-century Beneventan manuscript (Codex 1, Montevergine). Abbreviations have been expanded and orthography regularized according to the editorial principles outlined in Chapter V. The text is provided in continuous reading form to facilitate philological verification.

Incipit prologus de vita et obitu sancti Guilielmi confessoris et heremite.

Nostre parvitatibus non toleranda ingenio, et quae, sunt stupenda intuitu, summorum etiam virorum eloquentiam ac subtilitatis acumen facile possent excedere, dignata michi est, venerande Iacobe pater, iniungere vestre sanctitatis religio. Ad multorum scilicet edificationem, beati Guilielmi, cuius vicem Dei gratia geris, vitam ut obitum scriptis transmittere posteris nec, ad summi regis honorem et gloriam, inertem occultare silentio quae pro ipsius vite meritis, tam in eius milicie tempore quam post exacti laboris premium, divina misericordia fuerit operata. quanto etenim qui in sanctis suis //

est mirabilis, pro eius amore maiora fecisse, fidei fuerit narratione compertum, in nostris quippe temporibus, in quibus secundum dominicum dictum, se ipsos amantium multorum caritas iam refrixit, tanto amplius ad laudem dei brutorum etiam animalium lingue promptius solventur. Hoc itaque, si ego Iohannes excellenti fretus ingenio, si clara pollens scientia, me posse implere confiderem, et si absque magno difficultatis timore id ipsum minime possem attingere, ultroneus tamen et gaudens ad huius officii curam incunctanter accederem. Nunc autem, quoniam quae sit nostri facultas ingenii, visu rationis perlustrans, suis eam viribus parum valere comperio, tamen gravissimi ponderis sarcinam nostris imponere humeris vehementer formido. Vereor quippe non modicum ne, si quod arduissimum est ac difficillimum tractare incipiam perfectionis sapientie viris, dum quod cepero consummare non valeam, non immerito ridiculus fiam et, quod gravius est, tam sancti viri laudibus dampnum inferat nostrae rusticitas eloquem. Ceterum non sine divino, velud ipse conicio, nutu vestre sanctitatis in extorquendo, iniuncti officii munus urget instantia, quae nichil humilitatis obedientie sperat difficile, nichilque karitatis ardori non credit possibile. Quid igitur faciam? cogit instantia, deortatur inscientia, invitat auctoritas, formidat debilitas, velle adiacet, posse subterfugit. verum, //

quoniam id eius amore vos flagitando iubere cognosco, qui suae virtutis potentia naturae legibus imperans, in ipsam etiam mirabiliter operatur, inconsiderate detrahentium morsus non metuens, vestre sanctitatis confisus oracionibus, tanto oneri colla subicio. Non enim me adeo latet levitatis crimine a plerisque accusari meque temerarium et importunum inconsiderata voce reprehendi. Qui si humanitatis aliquo modo fuerint et

rationis participes, mei animi nota sententia aliquando remordere desistent. Nam, cum in altero fuerat delinquendum, malui, fateor, temerarius quam parum humilis vestris rogationibus apparere. Nam, etsi qua hic temeritatis insunt vestigia, obedientie quidem meritis vestrisque supplicationibus spero in domino posse facile aboleri. Verum, ne longior faciat sermo fastidium, ad propositum, domino adiuvante, vestre orationis stilum vertamus.

Explicit prologus.

<Cap. I.> Incipit vita et obitus eiusdem sancti Guilielmi.

GUILIELMUS itaque venerabilis pater nobili progenie, morum quidem nobilitate longe preclarius, bercellensis genere fuit. Hic, a puerilibus annis sola celestia mente volutans, queque huius mundi vanitati obnoxia, non solum quasi sterilia et nullum afferentia fructum, procul a se animo removit, verum etiam aborrendo contempsit. Nam, cum ab infantia utroque fuisset orbatus //

parente, a suis illico in cura susceptus, etsi propter future probitatis indicia teneri diligeretur ab ipsis, non tamen umquam iocis ceterisque puerilibus oblectamentis animum dedit, set, morum gravitate puerilem transcendens etatem, assidue volvebat in animo qualiter, patria suisque omnibus derelictis, ad Dei servitium liberius convolaret. Quartum decimum igitur hec salutaria meditans annum egressus, habitum sacre religionis assumpsit satisque suo faciens desiderio, relicta patria, una contextus clamide, nudis etiam pedibus ad beati Iacobi aliorumque sanctorum sacra visendum limina, impiger est iter aggressus. Ardebat utique beati adolescentis animus eorum in terris sacras visitare reliquias, quibus ad perpetue //

felicitatis gloriam perfruendam, in celestibus regnis socium divina gratia ab eterno predestinabat. Cum ergo, sanctum sequens propositum, faceret iter peregrinantium more, circa noctis crepuscula ad civitatem quandam hospitaturus divertit. Erat in ea quidam faber ferrarius, homo quidem magne religionis et Deum timens, cui hospitalitatis gratia Deo accepto, iam diuturni usus in morem converterant, diebus singulis pauperibus dare hospitia, eosque post refectionem, lotis a se pedibus, ad nocturnam quietem stratis lectulis invitare. Apud quem Dei famulus cum aliis hospitatus, sicut a primo die sue peregrinationis statuerat, solo pane et aqua refectus, cetera eius humanitatis suscipere nolens officia, quietis tempore //

secundum morem nuda requievit in humo. cuius ut abstinentiam et habitum diligentius hospes advertit, eum vere Dei famulum ratus, decrevit, ita sequenti mane maturius solito de sompno consurgere, ut non prius a suo iret hospitio, quam communem cum ipso posset ad libitum sermonem conserere. Sero namque preterito, propter silentium, quod ut monachus observabat, nec verbum potuit ab eo elicere. Tempesti vius itaque de strato consurgens, ei iam proficienti, iam recedenti, etiam iam exire paranti, festinus occurrit, supplici voce deposcens, quatinus eum sue sanctitatis dignaretur affatibus. Tum Dei famulus, prout erat sereno vultu affabilis, morum facilitate cunctis amabilis, //

caritatis visceribus circa Deum et homines affluens, eius petitionibus facile dedit ascensum. Hospes igitur, sui desiderii compos effectus, talibus est exordiis eum letabundus affatus. Quamvis peccaminum mole depressus, vitiorum tabe pollutus, nec ad celum erigere oculos, nec sanctorum cetibus auderem sociari, eis tamen in nostro susceptis hospitio divine mie dono largifluo, pro nostre facultatis opibus, iam dudum studui ministrare, Ipsique etiam quelibet sibi apposita, cum gratiarum actione sumentes, nostre parvitatatis numquam sprevere officia. in te autem rem, frater, insolitiam et novam conspicio, qui et appositorum tibi quedam tangere aborrescis, et mea tanquam peccatoris et iniqui, quod fateor, contemnis obsequia. et //

ille absit, absit, ut in fraterne dilectionis obsequiis numquam fuerit aliqua michi contemptio vel, quod a Deo creata et humanis usibus deputata, velut sordidam aborrescam. Set, quoniam meorum sum non immemor delictorum, deliciosioribus cibis et potibus sicut plerique peccatores abstineo. Ceterum, quod vestre humilitatis non suscepi officia, ne arrogantiae queso ascribas nec contemptioni adtribuas, set quod vestre sanctitatis officiis me miserum et peccatorem indignum conspicio et quod superbienti et periture parcere carni, nepharium esse existimo. Eius postquam religionem verborum humilitate, quod aliis coniectarat indiciis, iam evidenter hospes agnovit, cupiens semper eiu comitatu sanctissimo refoveri, talibus eius animum a suo proposito temptavit deflectere. Votum michi est, in meo prediolo quandam edificare ecclesiam propriisque rebus eam ditare. Nunc autem, si tibi placet, noli, frater, recedere, mecum maneto, eamque edificatam vestre providentiae committo arbitrio. Ad quem sanctus: Quamquam in administrandis rebus ecclesiarum Domino famulari rem constet egregiam, tamen, quod a puero sanctorum visitare limina concupivi, cepti mutare sententiam, queso ignoscas, non est consilium. postquam igitur hospes a suo proposito non facile posse mutari sanctum cognovit, iterum atque iterum blandis precibus exhortatus, supplici tandem voce deposcit, quatinus de suis aliquid saltem dignaretur //

accipere. tum denique, tante dilectionis visa instantia, venerandus vir metuens ne, ab eo nichil accipiens, ipsum penitus contristaret, talibus est effatus sermonibus: Quoniam ad capiendum de vestre benignitatis studio me tantopere exhortaris, licet, que ad procuracionem corporis attinent, eorum prorsus nichil indigeam, vestre fiam libentius caritatis morigerus. Tu autem quod petiero, sicut libenter attribues, ita rogo ut in silentio habeas, et quod dederis pretium, ad nullius precor aures. Duos ergo michi circulos ferreos ad hunc modum facias, ut eorum unus ventrem pectus alter circundet, a quorum inferiori brachia duo ferrea porrigantur, unum a dextro latere alterum a sinistro. Que per humeros ad alteram inferioris circuli partem pervenientia, utrimque predictis circulis fortiter clavis colligentur. Eius postquam petitionem hospes accepit, plurimum secum ammirans, quod homo videlicet id etatis, sibi ipsi renuntians, tantam in Dei dilectione haberet constantiam tantumque temporalium omnium rerum contemptum, sub omni celeritate studiosius petita perfecit eique perfecta concessit. Que, ubi accepit, illud Evangelii memorans, Qui vult venire post me, abneget semethipsum et tollat crucem suam et sequatur me, ea sibi continuo cum maximo gaudio ad mortificationem carnis aptavit, et valefaciens ab eo discexit. His ergo sumptis deliciis, et una ut dixi veste contemptus, nudis etiam //

pedibus, septemtrionalia frigora lustrans, sanctorum limina visitavit, in quibus, quanta fuerit perpeusus pericula, non est nostre facultatis exprimere.

<Cap. II.> De homine ceco curato in Melfia.

His ita peractis, a sancto studio non desistens, venerandi viri animus incessanter ardebat Hierosolimam petere, quod tinus loca sanctissima, in quibus humani generis facta est reparatio, cernere mereretur. verum quia quod ardenti animo geritur, omnis est more impatiens, si libera perficiendi sit presto facultas, ad multorum salutem in Apuliam predictae rei gratia Melfiam perrexit, ubi aliquandiu in domo cuiusdam Rogeri commoratus, litteralis scientie prius ignarus, centesimum nonum non amplius ab homine didicit psalmum. Quem edoctus, //

mira Dei potentia, mira clementia, tanta postea Domino largiente sacre Scripture fuit ei peritia, ut facile posset adverti spiritum Domini, cui toto corde adhererat, loqui per os eius. scriptum quippe est: Qui adhaeret Domino, unus spiritus est. quenam enim erant Scripturarum mysteria sibi incognita? que sententiarum absconsa profunditas? omnia certe qui condidit secundum ineffabilem sue dispensationis gratiam sibi manifestius revelarat. Profectus inde ad oppidum quoddam, monte Solicolum veniens, circiter duos annos apud quendam militem Petrum nomine mansit. Nemini autem credibile debet videri quod sanctus vir, in Apuliam tanto desiderio transfretaturus adveniens, tamquam sui oblitus propositi, a sancti itineris deferbuisset //

amore. Idem namque fervebat in animo desiderium et in ea meditatione ignis ardebat amoris. Ille autem, a quo gressus hominis diriguntur quique ad multorum salutem destinaverat, Deus, ab incepto revocabat itinere quatinus eius sanctitatis exemplo ad amorem eterne vite multi accenderentur. Erat eo tempore venerabilis viri cibus panis et aqua, ad recreationem potius quam ad saturationem. Si quando vero deliciosiora fercula sumere vellet, ea erant sine oleo cum aceto legumina, quod etiam ad carnis attenuationem frequenter bibere consueverat. Per idem tempus, homo quidam erat in prefato loco, qui lumen amiserat oculorum. Hunc dum forte ab agro redeuntem filia //

duceret, eminus aspiciens, tunc eidem e vestigio nuntiare curavit, quod Guilielmum heremitam in rupe fixis genibus orantem videret. Erat namque sancto viro in consuetudine, dum maximus estus solis incumberet, ad rupem quandam exire ubi verum solem iusticie totis nisibus implorare. Qui protinus, spe sue salutis concepta, filiam orat, ut ad venerabilem Dei virum eum perduceret. Cum ergo ad Guilielmum esset homo perductus, provolutus ad genua eius, rei familiaris inopiam, curam alende sobolis pretendens, miserabiliter cepit orare, ut, sui miseritus, lumen sibi rederet oculorum. Quod ubi vir Domini audivit, id sue virtutis non esse commemorans, eius condolens infortunio, cepit continuo ammonere, quatinus in tribulationibus a Dei servitio non cessaret. Potens est enim, aiebat « qui percutit, et mederi ». Dum hec et his similia sanctus vir eum ammonens loqueretur, predictus homo sopori concessit. Qui tandem, sompno evigilans, benedictione a sancto accepta, continuo ut est domum regressus, lumen quod amiserat clarius quam umquam habuerat recepit. Hoc itaque audito miraculo, fama sue sanctitatis cepit clarescere eiusque vite continentia publice predicari. Quod ubi precipus humilitatis custos audivit, plurimum contristatus simulque veritus ne

popularibus auris moveretur, utcumque statuit inde recedere seque ad Hierosolimam conferre. //

Nec mora quod animo decreverat, iter arripiens, ope cepit implere. Erat eo tempore magni meriti magnaeque nominis vir quidam Deo devotus nomine Iohannes, pater cuiusdam monasterii, quod iuxta Genusium ipse construxerat. De huius itaque sancti viri fama, cum predictae rei gratia faciens iter audisset, opere pretium sui laboris esse putavit, si ab incepto itinere declinaret, causa colloquendi cum predicto Dei viro. Ubi ergo in mutuos ruentes amplexus conveniunt, vicissimque datur copia fandi, sermo inter eos non fuit (quid enim tales potius loquerentur?) nisi de contemptu rerum mundanarum et celestium appetitu, et qualiter soli Deo sit serviendum. Altero die, profecturus a predicto viro, licentiam petiit, insinuans quod orationis causa Hierosolimam tendere vellet, suumque desiderium amplius differre non posse. Et ille: « Noli, frater, frustra fatigari, noli quod adimplere non poteris, non profecturus incipere. Maior est quippe ad fideliū salutem tua mora utilitas quam propositi fieri pro voluntate participem ». Cuius monitis ardore sancti itineris nolens prebere ascensum, mox iter arripuit. Qui cum iusta Oream devenisset, a latronibus detentus, crudis est affectus verberibus. nondum etenim patruelia regna hereditario iure capessens, ille iniquorum omnium metus, equitatis amator, malorum omnium exterminator, optimus siquidem tranquillatis et pacis //

patronus, Rogerius videlicet, rex magnificentissimus, feliciter triumphans a rapacium et latronum faucibus Apuliam liberarat. In hoc tandem certis cognovit indiciis, secundum Dei famuli dictum, quod corde gerebat, opere complere non posse. Necessitate itaque compellente, ad predictum patrem sub omni est celeritate regressus. A quo, dum per singulos dies fraterna dilectione, ut secum cohabitaret, plurimum rogaretur, ei Dominus in visu apparuit, predicens quod et ipse per se congregationem fidelium esset factururus ideoque oportere inde ipsum recedere, alibi Domino servituum. Et volutis ergo diebus quindecim, predicti viri voluntati renunciavit, proseguens diligenter quae fuerant sibi iniuncta //

a Domino. Inde itaque, accepta profectus licentia, per montana iter facere cepit, loca singula diligentius explorando, solitarie vite convenientia. Quae ubi minus pro sententia animi comperit, pervenit Tripaldum, quod non multum distat a Virgiliano monte. In hoc vico in domo cuiusdam matrone aliquantulum commoratus, ab eius habitatoribus diligenter inquirens, cognovit premissum montem ydoneum et opportunum esse ad solitariam vitam ducendam. Interea quoniam circuli, quos ad carnis macerationem induerat, frequentius rumpebantur eosque totiens ferraris ostendere et similes fieri ab ipsis querere oportebat, plausum hominum metuens vir prudentioris consilii //

Salernum proficiscitur, sperans ibi aliquem invenire a quo ferream lorica numquam depositurus acciperet.

Nec eum fefellit opinio. Nam, postquam primum Salernum fuit ingressus, quidam miles occurrens, eius cognita voluntate, quotquot habuit loricas ostendit eiusque subiecit arbitrio, ut quam vellet meliorem acciperet. Maioris itaque ponderis vestem indutus, compos voti effectus, gratulabundus ad predictum remeavit vicum. In quo etiam ut et galeatus secure posset ad bellum procedere, ad modum sui capitis ferreum tegimen sibi

fieri iussit, quod vulgo cophia dicitur. Quam postquam Domini miles in capite sumpsit, eam ulterius non removit sicque eam latenter portavit, ut vite sue tempore nemini umquam foret compertum. inde cum prefata matrona cepit habere consilium quo modo in predicto monte illo posset aquam invenire. et illa: Domine, est in iugo eiusdem montis, prout fama refert prenuncia veri, quidam heremita. is, si qua est aqua in hoc monte, certissime docebit. assumpto itaque quodam socio petro nomine, montem ascendit heremitam invenit, qui pater, eius cognita voluntate, dixit eum aquam posse invenire, si in supercilio montis quereretur. mox ab ipso digressus, cum socio diligentius cuncta perscrutans, tandem inspicit lutum sine aqua non odicum, ab ursinis conculcatum vestigiis. quo accedentes manibus pro rastro fungentes lutum effodiunt. tandem ab eodem loco, a quo lutum //

prohiciebant, aquam aliquantam vident emergere. interim, advesperascente die, aliquatulum progredientes, nocturnae quieti ydoneum locum inveniunt. ubi ergo sequens dies effulsit, nequaquam solito parcens labori, nocturni instituta propositi avide exequitur. Interim venatores occurrunt, qui, de aqua consulti, humanitatis studio ad uberiores fontes illum deducunt. quibus abeuntibus, praedictus Dei famulus cum comite in aspectu illius fontis persistens, a custodibus cuiusdam castelli Merculiani nomine visus est, //

qui, arbitantes eos latrones esse, confestim prorunt, capiunt, et contumeliose deponunt eumque usque ad baiulum ipsius castelli deducunt. qui, ubi eius sacris auditis sermonibus, cuius esset sanctitatis cognovit, eum ilico in pace dimisit. cum igitur ad iam saepe dictum fuisset vicum reversus, nullius more patiens, assumptis quibusdam consanguineis et vicinis illius mulieris, apud quam hospitabatur, ad locum, in quo prius aquam invenerit, ascendit, ubi, quadam domuncula ab eisdem sibi aedificata, solus ibi cum Domino venerabilis heremita remansit.

<Cap. III.> De urso fontem turbantem et fugato

Die quadam, cum gratia auriendi aquam cella exiret, in praedicto fonte parum aquae invenit, ursus enim veniens //

fontem conculcaverat et eum fere oppilaverat. quid multa? fontem restituit, domum regressus est. ursus autem nichilominus, singulis diebus adveniens, aquam sorbebat, fontem conculcabat. quod cum diu perpetitur, die quadam ad auriendum aquam egressus, beluam bibentem invenit eamque his verbis alloquitur: « Quid est quod agis? alieno, ut video, labori iniuriose incumbis, aquam, quam propriis manibus ego effodio, perturbas et sorbes. vade hinc et cave ulterius ne accedas ». ad cuius imperium, mox depresso in terra capite, ursus, nihil feritatis ostendens, protinus recessit et ad fontem amplius non est reversus. Victus eius erat eo quidem tempore tantum fabae et castaneae, quas propriis manibus collegabat, et ordeicius panis idemque subcinericius. interim, emenso annis spatio, quidam monachus, eius sanctitatis fama comperta, ad illum veniens, suppliciter orat, ut eum secum habitare permetteret. cuius postquam constantiam cognovit, eius voluntati non contradicens, in suo sacro comitatu suscepit. hic, inter multa quae de eo fideliter narrare consueverat, quoddam difficile et multis fere incredibile commemorabat. testabatur namque quod, in nocturnis horis, quam plurimum

scire poterat se obdormisse, ylico a strato, si nudum saxum hoc poterit nominari, consurgens, ante crucem, quam in cellula sibi ipse confixerat, uno pede inixus, sacris orationibus //

usque mane vacabat. duorum vero annorum peracto curriculo, iam per universas illius regionis partes eius nomen innotuit eiusque celebri fama ubique clarescente, viri et mulieres summa cordis alacritate ad eum concurrebant. inter quos quidam de sacerdotibus convenientes, dum eius sacris disciplinis institui cupiunt, sub eius magisterio se ad Dei servitium mancipaverunt. quibus inquirentibus quam regionis normam eos observare perciperet, « Meum est » ait « consilium, fratres, ut propriis manibus laborantes, victum et vestitum nobis et quod pauperibus erogemus acquiramus et, iri statutis horis convenientibus, divina celebremus officia ». cuius salutare consilium brevi tempore presbiteri tenuerunt. nam, antiqui hostis perculsi malitia, inter se prius clanculo conquerentes, publica tandem voce clamare coeperunt, se sacerdotes esse divinisque deputatos officiis, ideoque non oportere eos laborare nec in cultu telluris ut rusticos exerceri. set potius par esse, ecclesiam in monte edificari, libros, sacerdotalia vestimenta emi, ita ut eos divinis tantum vacare officiis. quorum voluntati metuens refragari, ne ipsorum seditionibus, solita mentis tranquillitate omissa, a contemplationis lumine mentis aciem declinaret, eorum satisfactorius desiderio, uno contentus comite asellum ascendens, Barum perrexit. ubi inter amicos et notos omnia pro voto sacerdotum inveniens, dum peracto negotio, Gravinum regreditur, ibi eius sotius cepit infirmari. septem ergo diebus exactis, postquam cognovit eum non facile ab infirmitate posse convalescere, cepit eum rogare quatinus, asellum ipse ascendens, ad proprium locum secum regrederetur. ille vero, cognito qui molestum satis erat Dei viro pedibus incedere, tum quia orationibus, ieiuniis et vigiliis debilis erat, tum quia ferrea lorica indutus, precabatur ut, se potius dimisso, ad fratres reverteretur. quid opus est verbis? eius auctoritate devictus imperio, asellum ascendit eumque venerabilis pater nudis pedibus sequens (mira patientia, mira humilitas!), usque ad destinatum locum ei ministrare non destitit. Libris igitur et //

sacerdotalibus vestimentis acceptis, ceperunt ylico sacerdotes rogare, quatinus sibi ecclesiam in monte construeret. quo audito, iam non inconsulte, ut prius, de praedictis rebus desiderio fratrum se satisfactorium spondet, set potius, ad secretum quandam locum digressus, flexis genibus fontem totius pietatis humiliter cepit orare quatinus, si ecclesiam in loco illo sibi edificari placeret, tantam frequentiam populi illuc mittere dignaretur, quatinus eodem die calcariam construere cepissent. vix oratione completa, tanta multitudo populi supervenit, ut ad eius imperium et calcariam laborare cepissent et ligna incidere, tantaque deservivit instantia, ut altero //

die igne supposito lapides solverentur in cementum. nec mora, auxilio adiacentium civitatum, ecclesia edificatur paucis diebus nec non et cellulae ad utilitatem fratrum. edificata ergo ecclesia et ad Dei servitium non parva multitudine ibi coadunata, placuit ei ex communi consilio, ut ad honorem Dei Genitricis semperque virginis Mariae praedicta dedicaretur ecclesia. profectus itaque ad Avillanensem episcopum, cuius territorium erat, quem esset de ecclesia, sua fratrumque petitio, humiliter ostendit. ille vero, eius audito desiderio, cum magna cordis iucunditate sponndit pro eius velle se satisfactorium suis petitionibus. constituto die, ecclesia dedicata est.

<Cap. IV.> De muliere muta et soluta

Ad huius sanctae dedicationem ecclesiae maxima populi multitudo convenit. in qua mulier quaedam afuit, quae, per septem annos locutione amissa, muta silebat. quae, sanctitate huius viri audita, anxia de sui corporis salute, nutu quo poterat cum consanguineis ubi vel quisnam esset Dei famulus inquisivit. quid multa? ad eum deducta et ad eius genua procumbens, a Dei famulo quid quaereret inquisita est. et illa subito (mira Dei potentia!) ad eius interrogationem, sine aliquo impedimento, libera voce respondit. quod ubi miraculum multitudinis auribus insonuit, omnes uno ore Deum laudantes, eum sanctum publice predicare ceperunt. mulier etiam, salutem accepta, non ingratitude rea, per omnes fines regionis illius, quanta pro amore sancti viri sibi Deus impenderat, incessanter predicabat.

<Cap. V.> Miracula de marmore

Interea sanctitate huius viri divulgata, illarum partium procures, summa devotione subsidia quaque poterant ad sustentationem fratrum, gratanti animo sibi offerebant. inter quos quidam Adam nomine, auctoritate Fringentini episcopi, quandam ecclesiam ad honorem Sancti Cesarii martiris dedicatam optulit. ad quam dum frequenter visendam homo Dei pergeret, vidit fortuito marmoreum sarcophagum, cuius antiquitus ibi relictum maiorem partem terra cooperuerat. huius itaque utilitate ad praedictam perpensa ecclesiam, precepit astantibus fratribus discooperiri et ad ecclesiam sine mora deferri. eo itaque ad ecclesiam recedenti, illi avidè cupientes sui patris obtemperare preceptis, discooperto marmore, quinque paria boum ad illud trahendum insimul adiuxerunt. quos, postquam stimulis et crudis instantibus verberibus, nec posse movere inspicunt, rem ylico ad patrem referunt. quo audito, subridens, prout eius moris erat semper in vultu, ut diximus, hilaritatem habere, eorumque increpans inertia, ad locum ubi marmor illud iacebat, per se ipse pervenit. tunc quatuor boum paribus ammotis, duos boves qui remanserant baculo quem manu gerebat percutiens eos imperat ire. //

ad cuius vocem tanta facilitate motus est lapis, tamquam si non marmoreum saxum, sed aridum lignum fuisset ipseque pedes boum sequens, vestigia, usque ad ianuam ecclesiae, quae peracto fere stadia distabat, detulit, quod usque ad hodiernum diem adhuc in ipsius cernitur fronte ecclesiae.

<Cap. VI.> De monte Virgiliano

Virgilianus mons, in quo cum ante latis presbiteris et nonnullis aliis fratribus habitabat, ob nimiam frigiditatis intemperantiam, nisi in tribus mensibus difficilis est et ad ascendendum valde laboriosus. tempore ergo quo poterat, maxima populi multitudo ad eum confluens, aurum, argentum et quae habere poterant ad pedes eius offerebant. quae benigne suscipiens, tamquam bonus dispensator, quae necessaria noverat fratribus retinebat, cetera pauperibus erogabat. hec sacerdotes intuiti, avaritiae telo iam dudum percussi et ad misericordia Dei diffusi, ceperunt prius blandis vocibus venerabili patri rogando persuadere, quatinus in futuro providens, quae offerrentur non tam largius expenderet, set potius arcam inveniret, in qua ad opus ipsius ecclesiae pecunia reponderetur. posse etenim fieri testabantur, quod ab hac liberalitate populus cessaret

ipsique rerum necessariarum temptarentur inopia. qui, postquam secus ac arbitrati sunt rem vident procedere neque eorum precibus dari assensum, testabantur enim venerabilis pater ecclesiam pecunia potius destrui quam edificari ipsosque nichil terrenum debere in saeculo possidere. tandem insanis vocibus in clamorem prorumpunt, dicentes eum contra ius facere, cum bona ecclesiae, quae comunia sunt, quae etiam plus pro suis officiis et orationibus quam pro suis meritis offerebantur, eis invitis pauperibus erogaret. ille vero, ad eorum clamores humiliter ac blande respondens, talibus est eos exhortatus alloquiis:

« Quid est fratres mei, quod clamando perstreptitis? quid est quod inconsiderata voce tumultuamini? dixi vobis idemque replicare non piget: rebus secularibus renuntiastis, Deum in hereditatem elegistis, ipsum solum // diligite, ipsum solum possidete. sinite quaeso secularia secularium esse, vos vero spiritualia secularibus toto corde preferte. verum si, quod absit, id est vobis fixum in animo eaque incommutabilis sedet sententia vos pecuniae mecum id facere non posse sciatis ». substituto ergo praeposito, quoniam inter eos se ulterius proficere non posse videbat, metuens ne ad maiora animarum detrimenta suis factis inciderent, quinque de ydiotis fratribus assumptis, inde secessit et, locorum asperitatem maiorem inquirens ad Lacenum pervenit.

A-2 - Renda 1581 (Normalized Text)

The following transcription presents the normalized Latin text of Felice Renda's 1581 printed edition. Orthographic modernization and typographical normalization follow the criteria described in Chapter V.

ILLUSTRISSIMO,

AC REVERENDISSIMO DOMINO

GUIDO DE FERRERIIS

Vercellensi.

SANCTAE ROMANAE ECCLESIAE

Cardinali tituli Sanctorum Viti et Modesti.

D. FELIX RENDA, HUMILIS

Servus. Salutem.

Res magnae magno patrocinio indigent; magnoque viro donandae sunt. Vita Divi Guilielmi, cuius tui authoris ducisque, tum Mulierum Religiosarum, tum Virorum, qui ex loco in quo ipse Sanctus aetatem duxit et nobis aedem suis manibus aedificavit, Sacri Montis Virginis dicuntur, merito iureque optimo munusculum nostrum in tuo nomine apparebit. Tu generis nobilitate, tuo favore, vitae sanctitate, bonarum litterarum doctrina, facile haec nostra tueri poteris. Quare maius patrocinium labori nostro parare nequivi. Adde hoc, quod ipse Christi Confessor, ut infra in eius vita dicetur, licet vixerit et in caelum migraverit in hoc Regno. Natus est Vercellis, quae est Urbs in Gallia Cisalpina patria tua. Praeterea tu, qui horum similium librorum lectione delectaris, legas ambo huius

tui civis, mei ducis, vitam; admiraberis profecto gratiam, in qua apud Deum fuit, ut multa miracula fecerit, templa, domosque viris suis sociis et viris et mulieribus, in Sicilia, in Brutiis, in magna Graecia, Lucania, Apulia, Samnio aedificaverit; Regem Rogerium eius sanctitatem veneratam observasse. Quid de eius vita dicam? Adeo dura, agrestis et sancta, ut praeter panem et aquam nihil gustaret; circulis ferreis cinctus; vix veste indutus; humi iaceret. Quae plura in eius vita leges. Accipe igitur hoc parvum munusculum, et ipse Sanctus a Deo impetrabit ut diu beateque vivas. Vale.

Neapoli Kalendis Martiis 1581.

IOANNIS FRANCISCI LOMBARDI

NEAPOLITANI

AD ADMODUM REVERENDUM

Dominum Felicem de Renda Theologum et Priorem
Montis Virginis Neapolis.

Octastichon

REND A tuum nomen super aethera docte volabit,
Dum saeculis Montis facta stupenda sacri.
Aeternum vives GUILIELMI nomine, AMATI,
Dum quos DONATI miracula sacra feres.
Perge igitur generose Prior, iam perfice captum;
Sanctus opus, ut Monachos gravet et alliciat.
His populi exemplis crescent devotio CHRISTI,
Atque bonus Pauli ex dogmate miles eris.

ILLUSTRI AC

EXCELLENTI DOMINO

PAVLO REGIO,

Theologo Neapolitano.

D. FELIX RENDA, SERVUS.

Salutem.

Quanta sit in Dei et Sanctorum affectio tua, Sacrae Theologiae Doctor Illustris, devotissimum opus, fidelissime huius Civitatis Sanctorum Patronorum, quod fecisti, et aliorum Sanctorum quotidie factis, in Italico sermone Regi memorando declarasti. Propterea inter virorum illustrium te numerari agnosco. Tuae devotionis, illustris doctrinae, hoc opus de Vita Sanctissimi Guilielmi, meae Religionis Patris institutoris et eiusdem aliorum Sanctorum, cui propitiae commendatur, illustrando, ut Italico sermone clarifices, suppliciter exoro. Dulcedine enim talis ordinis Italicae compositionis tuae non nullas animas ad Deum suosque Sanctos conversas; et, quod maius, a saeculi huius vanitatibus fugientes, habitum sacrarum Religionum indutas Deo servire, a multis saepe percipio. Quod si tibi favoris gratia fit, fidelibus fuit per alias non modicam utilitatem

adducere mihi; meaeque Religionis utilitas et solatium maximum erit. Illud plurimum tibi commendo. Vale.

ADMODUM REVERENDO
D. FELICI RENDAE
THEOLOGO DIGNISSIMO.
PAVLVS REGIVS. Salutem.

Mirifice gratulor tui viri ingenii expositiones esse, describere vitam moresque Sancti Guilielmi, aliorumque Sanctorum sub Montis Virginis regula praeteritorum. Quod a divino spiritu inspiratum reputo, dum te duce haec lego, viros pios ad veram disciplinam ductos, calamum impulisse; nec mediocri periculo me gaudeo, dum me invitas ad tractandum Italico sermone ea quae Latina lingua condis. Illud velim, mea intentione semper fuisse, sacros Patres nostros gloriosa memoria recordari, praesertim saeculorum fastu. Legi enim multos catholicos viros Sanctorum virorum lectione ad veram disciplinam ductos fuisse. Quae propterea ad infideles convertendos, ut fideles haerere, ut beatae confirmationes, ut confirmata laudis memoria ampliari, ad describendas Sanctorum vitas, quorum exemplo multi peccata delinquerent et caritatem amplecterentur. Quod si mea ipsa intentio hoc peragerem infeliciter, quanto libentius ac alacrius illud perficere conabor, te ad haec opus invitante. Resta solum tibi gratias referre pro collatis in me laudibus; quae non mihi, sed Sanctis, quorum pias descriptas laudes refero; tibi etiam ago, et rogo ne ipsum opus deseras, sed laboranti animo illud perficias. Semper enim mei animi promptitudinem alteram videbis, ut tibi obsequar in praesentem. Vale.

IN VITA SANCTISSIMI
PATRIS GUILIELMI.

Capitulum Primum continet.

Sanctissimus Guilielmus habitum ad austeram Religionem induitur.
A fabro ferrario acceptus hospitio, circulos ferreos, quibus carnem maceraret, suscipit.
Apuliam peragrans, Melphim et Genuam nominat discipulis.
Caecum orando illuminat.
In ignis flamma apparuit ei Dominus, praedicans religionem esse faciendam.
Lorica magni ponderis carnem macerat.
In Virginis Monte veniens, aquam propriis manibus effodiens, immensam, quae hodie dicitur fons Sancti Guilielmi.
Aedificat cellam, hodie dictam propriam eremiticam.
Miraculum de Urso fontem perturbante.
Sacerdotibus dat institutum.

Capitulum Secundum.

Ecclesia Montis Virginis a Sancto Guilielmo fundatur anno.
Miraculum aridi brachii.
Qua die completa fuit Ecclesia et consecrata, et a quo.
Dedicationis tempore mutum fecit loqui.
Lupum pro asino servire fecit.
Regulam Sancti Benedicti pro norma tradidit, prohibens carnis, ovorum et casei esum et asportationem.

Miraculum de lapide a duobus bobus vecto, et ad montem Lacenum veniente.
Secunda apparitio Domini in ea forma qua passus est, facta Sanctissimo Guilielmo.
Miraculum de muliere Beneventi.
Grammaticum superat et poena grammatici.
Miraculum de apro vastante hortulum.
Miraculum de puella lunatica.

Capitulum Tertium

De aedificatione tertii monasterii Sancti Salvatoris de Goleto.

Monialium instituit monasterium maximum.
Miraculum de puella caeca Beneventi illuminata.
Miraculum de aqua conversa in vinum.
Miraculum de igne extincto capillari.
Miraculum de puella lunatica.
Miraculum de meretrice quae cum Sancto concumbere voluit.
Monasterium secundum monialium aedificat.
Melphi tertium monasterium monialium facit.
Panormi sub titulo Sanctae Mariae Bussinae, cum privilegio Rogerii Regis, magnum monasterium fecit. Privilegium.

Capitulum Quartum

De obitu Sanctissimi Patris et miraculis.

Diem sui obitus Rogerio Regi revelat.
Monialibus praedicit et mortis suae diem revelat.
Miraculum de muliere surda in exsequiis factum.
Miraculum de paralytico.
Miraculum de puella daemoniaca per accessum ad sepulcrum sanata.
Secunda consecratio Montis Virginis.
Miraculum de paralytico.
Miraculum de daemoniaca Henrici Imperatoris tempore quae Hierusalem.
Virginis imaginem quae territur ad praesens venire fecit et privilegio terram Mercuriani monasterio donavit. Privilegium.
Bulla Coelestini Papae Tertii.
Numerus religionum Montis Virginis.
Miraculum de puero claudo tempore Federici Imperatoris.
Privilegium primum. Privilegium secundum.
Officium Sancti Guilielmi.

IN VITA SANCTI AMATI EPISCOPI

Capitulum Primum continet

Sanctus Amatus cum Ioanne ad Sanctum Guilielmum accessit et habitum religionis Montis Virginis induitur.
Monasterium Magni virorum dictum Sanctae Mariae de Fontiliano aedificat.
Miraculum de claudo.

Apparuit ei Angelus Domini.
Miraculum de vincto catenis.
Sanctus in episcopali dignitate eligitur.
Miraculum de primicerio.
Miraculum de puella lunatica.
Miraculum de oppresso a diabolo.
Monachorum plura monasteria facit.
Miraculum de clerico.
Miraculum de paralytico et daemoniaca.

Capitulum Secundum

Tempore obitus.
Miraculum de lampade.
Miraculum de daemoniaco liberato.
Miraculum de captivo liberato.
Miraculum de claudo.

Capitulum Tertium

Tempore translationis.
Miraculum de paralytico.
Miraculum de caeco.
Miraculum de puero.
Officium Sancti Amati.

IN VITA SANCTI DONATI MONACHI

Capitulum Primum continet
Quia a poenitentia carnem macerabat.
Miraculum de furto ignito et scapulari purgato.
Miraculum de urso.
Officium de communi simplici.
Privilegia in favorem eius.

Praefatio.

IN Maximum celebratissimae Sacrae Montis Virginis de Monte Monasterium, magna fidelium Devotio, Italiae huius Regni populorum concursus; Ambitus Montis cacumen; lata via; Vestibula plana; Claustra splendidissima; Imperialia Moenia; Alta Aedificia; Magnifica tecta; Religiosissima sacella; Sanctissimae Virginis Magnae Matris imago; Reliquiarum, et Sanctorum Corporum numerus. Ingentis Ecclesia, cum cellarum copia; hospitium magno nitore refulgens (quod non modo oppidum, sed Civitas videri a longe), ornamentis decorata magnificis; Sanctitas cum Miraculorum copia; ipsius Monasterij fundatoris; vita Sanctissimi Patris Religionis virorum; et Multitudinis eiusdem, et aliorum Sanctorum; ut describerem, animo me movit. Praedictum Monasterium, circum se Montes scopulosos, inaccessos, praecipites, et ita per altos, ut fecundam aeris regionem videntur attingere, ac objectos continere nivibus habet. Vix hyberno tempore, ob nimium glaciary ingentes horrores, habitabile: cum pluviae descendens e caelo statim convertantur in nivem. At Mons frigoribus non subjacet; temperie aestiva, segetum

commoditatem, varietatem fructuum frumentorum, leguminum, copiam non modicam, et pecudibus pascua, collium, et virentium convallium pabula, numerosas diversorum animalium armenta foecunda producit. Ac surgentes Mons, nonnullos scaturit fontes; ex quibus Sanctus fundator propriis effoderat manibus; quibus Monasterium construxit, et auxit. Cuius Sancti Patris meritis Religio brevi Monasterijs innumerata magnificata fuit. Sicilia, a Siciliae Rege Rogerio suo familiari, cuius auxilio Panormi Monasterium Virorum, Sanctae Mariae Bussinae, et Mulierum Sancti Salvatoris construxit. Post Melphiam, Catania, et Virginis, et Sancti Salvatoris gloriam, a Guilielmo Rege multa fuerunt monasteria, et templa constructa. Ac Constantia Regis filia huius Religionis habitu induta, et Monialis effecta professa (quam Henricus V. Romanorum Imperator Augustus, dispensatione Pontificis duxit uxorem) Reverendissimam una cum viro Henrico, Montis Virginis Monasterio, Terram Mercuriani donavit. Fredericus Imperator Patris, et Matris devotionis in Religionem hanc, non immemor factus: ei Roccellam Siciliae, possessiones, bonum multa loca dono dedit. Et tanta catholica Religio fuit Siciliae Regum, et Imperatorum, quod Sicilia, Calabria, Basilicata, Apulia, et Campania innumeras virorum, et mulierum Monasteria construxerunt, ac constructa privilegiis decorarunt. Item Carolus Primus, Secundus, Tertius, Robertus Reges, et Domina Joanna Regina uxor Ludovici Regis. Antea Tarenti Principis, et Regni Siciliae Vicarii Generalis, filij Catharinae Imperatricis Constantinopolis (quae Imperatrix suam imperialem auream, et pretiosos lapides insigniam coronam, ut ad praeses videretur ad Sanctissimae Virginis caput accomodari) quorum Ludovici Regis, Catharinae matris: Ioanna uxor ipsorum, et filiarum corpora in praedicto Sacro Monasterio, ante aram Virginis dicatam, collocata iacent: quae privilegio Regum Alphonsi, et alii Reges approbarunt, postremo vero Christianissimus Carolus V. Imperator Romanorum Augustus confirmavit, stabilivit. In Castello novo, et Nobilis huius Civitatis Neapolis 1536. Est a Lucio III. Sanctae Sedis Pontifice Maximo, usque ad praesentem diem Deus conservavit. Dominus Noster Papa Gregorius XIII. Indulgentiarum, exemptionum privilegijs illustrata manet praedicta Religio.

BENEDICTUS DEUS.

GUILIELMUS Vercellensis,

patria ortus nobili progenie natus, morum nobilitate praeclarius, a teneris annis mundi delectamenta contemnens, sola divina mente revolutus, nullo vitio animum dedit. Ab infantia utroque parente orbatus, in curam fuit susceptus a suis; qui, et in se propter futurae perfectionis indicia, tenerrime diligeretur ab eis; patriam suoque relinquens, ut ad Dei servitium libere evolaret, quartumdecimum annum attingens, habitu albo, ut purus a vitiis sacrae religionis est indutus, nudus pedibus unaque veste, coeptus paupertatis exemplo Christum imitans, sancti Sepulcrum, beati Iacobi Apostoli, aliorumque sanctorum templa visere cupiens, iter aggreditur. Sanctum propositum sequens, dum suum peregrinans perageret iter, in quendam urbem adveniens circa noctis crepuscula a quodam fabro ferrario, magnae religionis viro, fuit susceptus hospitio. is dominum amans, domini servis hospitalitate impendens, hospitem pedibus lotis,

lateral Marginalia:

*Habitu albo sacrae religionis induitur
A fabro ferrario Sanctus Guilielmus accipitur hospitio*

//

comedenda non pauca parabat; a quo confessor sanctus, solo pane et aqua refectus, cetera sibi apposita renuens, ad nocturnam quietem stratis lectulis invitatus, quietis tempore nuda requievit in humo. Cuius abstinenciam et humilitatem pius faber advertens, sanctum Dei famulum esse ratus; cum sero nec verbum quidem elicere potuisset. Mane sequenti solito de somno consurgens, cum eo sermone conferere decrevit. Itaque mane hospes festinanter de strato prosiliens, proficiscenti et exire paranti, supplici voce deposcens ut secum alloqueretur, occurrit. Quem festinus sic eum alloquitur. Sero ut monachus profundo silentio silens, quod tunc non potui, nunc dicere non erubesco. Licet sim vitiorum mole depressus nec sanctorum coetibus audiam socialis, eis tamen in nostro susceptis hospitio Dei fretus auxilio, largiflua dona quae nobis gratis ipse donavit, largiter studui iam dudum pauperibus ministrare; quin nostra numquam cum gratiarum actionibus sumentes renuerunt caritatis officia. Tu autem, vir, abhorrens apposita tangere: num mea peccatoris contemnis obsequia? At famulus Dei, ut erat vultu sereno ac hilari facie, est alloquutus. Absit; ut in charitatis obsequiis a Deo creata et humano usui deputata abhorrendo reculem, nec tua non amem obsequia sed Christi vestigia sequens, a delitiosis cibis, potuque ut possum abstineo; cuius religionem faber agnoscens, ad habitandam Ecclesiam, quam in suo condidisset praediolo, Dei famulum invitavit obnix; ad quem sanctus: Et si in Ecclesiis Domino famulari rem esse mihi constet egregiam, coepti tamen non est consilium mutare sententiam; a puero enim Sanctorum limina visitare cupiens haud impiger fui. At hospes, a proposito sanctum non posse mutari cognoscens, ut saltem de suis rebus aliquid dignaretur accipere, pia voce deposcit. Tanta affectionis instantia visa, Venerabilis Pater ne moerentem relinqueret illum, duos ferreos circulos quibus corpus affligeret, quorum altero pectus, altero ventrem circumdaret, et quibus per humeros duae protenderentur laminae ferreae, strictis clavibus circuli utrisque colligarentur, ut sibi fierent, humiliter postulavit. Cuius petitionem faber accipiens, tene-

later Marginalia:

*Faber cum sancto alloquitur
Sanctus Guilielmus semper hilaris et facie serenus alloquebatur*

//

ram mirans aetatem, iuvenili in corpore robur et maximam in Dei dilectione constantiam, omni qua valuit celeritate consecutus, et effectos Dei viro gratanter ipse donavit; quem dulciter amplexens veniam petiit. hospitis limina post terga relinquens, circulos quos gaudens accepit ad carnis macerationem aptavit. Pauper et humilis abiens septentrionalia frigora lustrat, multa sanctorum limina visitando, Hierosolymam petere vehementer ardebat. Verum quod aestuanti geritur animo, omnis est morae impatiens; si libera perficiendi est praesto facultas, cum multorum salute in Apuliam venit, Melphimque perrexit, pauper, pedibus nudis, unica veste, circulis ferreis strictus, semper incedens. Ubi dum in cuiusdam Rogerii domo commoraretur, literarum prius ignarus, centesimum

nonum ab eo didicit psalmum; quem edoctus largiente Deo, in eo tanta fuit sacrae Scripturae peritia ut spiritus Domini per os eius, qui adaerentibus ei profunda, ac alta misteria spirat loqui videretur a cunctis. Novi ac veteris testamenti, quae antea sibi erant incognita, et sententiarum absconsa profunditas, fuerunt nota et manifesta veritas. Ac inde profectus ad oppidum quoddam soli colli Montis apud militem quendam nomine Petrum, biennium fere, ad recreationem potius, quam ad fatietatis nomen, solo pane corpus reficiebat, et aqua, et si delitiosos aliquando cibos sumere vellet, erant sine oleo, sed cum aceto legumina, sic vivens habitabat in maxima pace. Deus autem ad multorum salutem destinatum ab incepto revocabat itinere, ut eius exemplo ad vitae amorem multi accenderentur aeternum. Die quadam evenit ut Christi confessor sub ardenti sole in solitariis rupibus Deum oraret. Quo tempore oppidi vir erat oculorum lumine cassus, quem redeuntem ab agro eius filia dum duceret, oeminus aspiciens eidem nunciare curavit, Dei Sanctum orantem vidisse genibus saepe flexis in rupe; sed caecus ductus a filia sancti pedibus volutans, ut lumen recipiat precibus petebat assiduus, quod vir Dei ut audivit, et id suae non esse virtutis commemorans, coeco passiones, ac tribulationes Dei visitationes esse nunciat, et dum haec loqueretur admonens, infirmus sopori datur.

lateral Marginalia:

Circulis ferreis carnem macerat

Pergit ad Melphim, ad Apuliam veniens; et centesimum nonum didicit psalmum

//

datur et quem coecis praebeuit visum, humiliter sanctus oravit, ut meritis primogeniti totius creaturae Deus fidem illius acciperet, qui non sibi, sed infinitae bonitati ac potestati immensae gratias ageret multas, orationeque facta, vir Dei, cum ut a somno surgeret: dixit, qui experge sactus, Sancti intercessionis merito, visus lumen quod amiserat recepit clarius. Quo audito miraculo, ingens sanctitatis increbuit publica fama; ac eius continentia vitae incipit publice praedicari. Quod Dei famulus audiens, et ne populari moveretur aura, verens, inde discedere ac Hierosolimam petere statuit. Nec mora, quod mente conceperat, opere satagebat implere. Eodem tempore, quo iter aggreditur, venerabilis vir Ioannes nomine, cuiusdam Monasterii; quod ipsemet iuxta Genusium aedificarat pater, existens, eius Confessor Sanctus fama motus, ut cum eo loqueretur, ab incepto declinavit illic manere. At ubi conveniunt, in mutuos ruentes amplexus, de mundi contemptu, stimulis carnis, diaboli fraudibus, de fundamento virtutum, charitate, ac qualiter Deo sit serviendum, sunt collocuti, vicissim. Altera die Hierosolimam abeundi veniam petiit; quod ne faceret; cum eius praesentia fidelibus maior fuisset utilitas, a patre praedicto saepius admonetur; cui nequaquam parens, arrepto itinere, iuxta Oream devenit; et a latronibus saevis flagellis fuit affectus. Non dum enim patruelia regna hereditario iure Rogerii Rex capessens, a Sarracenorum faucibus Apuliam liberarat. Quibus Dei sanctus cognoscuit indiciis: se quod corde gerebat ac primum propositum opere non posse complere. Necessitate impellente, propere ad praedictum Ioannem Patrem est reversus, a quo in dies, ut secum cohabitaret, magna dilectione rogatur: Cui Guilielmo sanctissimo nocte oranti ignis flamma apparuit Dominus praedicens, ipsum alibi Deo servitutum, et fidelium Congregationem esse facturum. Ter quinis volventibus diebus, quod Dominus dixerat: Beato Ioanni communicans, a quo venia petita, per montana arripuit iter, ac

solitariae vitae congruentia loca diligenter explorans, ad Atripaldum, quod non longe abest a Virgiliano monte, quem ad solam vitam degendam oppor-

later Marginalia:

*Caecum illuminat
In ignis flamma apparuit ei Dominus
Venit Atripaldum*

//

tunum esse cognovit: pervenit. In domo Matronae cuiusdam, acceptus hospitio, circulos ferreos, quos portabat ruptos invenit. Vir prudentioris consilii, ne quos, secrete nudam carnem domabat palam ostendere aliis: ut a milite quodam magni ponderis lorica, illam numquam depositurus, quaerens acciperet, Salernum proficiscitur; quam statim ingresso Dei viro, miles occurrit; eius petitioni loricas, ut meliorem reciperet, quotquot habuit libenter ostendit; quarum maioris ponderis, ut indueretur, unam accepit, et illa sub veste indutus, iterum Atripaldum remeat; et in domo praedictae Matronae dum commoraret capitis tegmen ferreum est adeptus; capiti imponens, et a nemine compertum, ulterius non removet. Priusquam discederet Matronam consuluit, si in vertice Vergilii montis habitaret aliquis, cui mulier ait. Aliqui in iugo montis quendam Heremitam esse homines dicunt. Assumpto socio, ut viam ostenderet, nomine Petro. Spiritu intus, galea, circulis ferreis et lorica nuda carne coopertus, Christi miles armatus; inde profectus in praemisum montem ascendit. Ibique Haeremita, antea a Matrona alique; monstratum: invenit, quem humiliter salutans, ut cum illo cohabitaret, desiderium aperit. Cui Haeremita respondit. Benedictus Deus, qui me tecum servo suo associari, dignatus est. Sancte simul in dies paterno amore de Dei servitio caelestique gloria viventes, colloquebantur. Una die Confessor Sanctus, aquam, quam volebat in montis cacumine, posse inveniri, cum socio cuncta perquirens, lutum Ursarum vestigiis conculcatum inspicit; quod manibus prius orando elevatis in coelum, genibus flexis, effodientes aliquantulum aquae invenere, surgentis. Advesperascente autem die, ad antrum lapidis, ita a natura productum (quod ut fuit ad praesens extat) reversi, usque ad noctis tertiam horam disciplinis ac orationibus vacantes, ad quartam se quieti dederunt. Mane sequenti, pro penuria aquae non modicum solliciti, affluentiorum quaerentes, solito labori non parcendo: montana discurrent. In venatores incidunt, qui de aqua consulti ad uberrimum fontem Lydiae, non longe ab eo de Phidia, eos perducunt; Quos abeuntibus illis, montis, et silvarum custodes,

later Marginalia:

*Lorica magni ponderis carnem macerat
Aqua quae adhuc fons Sancti Guilielmi dicitur manibus propriis effodiens invenit*

//

invenientes solos, eos arbitantes esse latrones, ad Mercuriani Baiulum deducunt: qui, eorum cognita sanctitate, in pace dimisit. Sanctissimus Guilielmus ad locum in quo socium invenit, iterum misit; at ipse iterum Atripaldum revertitur, assumptis quibusdam

consanguineis et vicinis matronae, cuius antea erat usus hospitio. Cum illis ad locum in quo prius manibus aquam repererat ascendit, ibique iuxta antrum praedictum casulam quandam aedificat; et aedificatam nomine proprio Poenitentiae vocat; in qua aedificatoribus gratias agit, ac illis redeuntibus solus Dei sanctus cum Christo remansit. In alia cellula ab eisdem constructa, primo manente socio Ioannes nomine, Deo unanimiter serviebant. Die autem quadam a cella, quae prope praedictum fontem erat egrediens, ursum perturbantem fontem, quem Sanctus cum socio propriis effoderat manibus, ac conculcantem invenit. At ursus pluries hoc faciens, cui vir Dei unica die imperat dicens: Quid agis? Alieno labori non parcis? fontem, quem manibus purgo, tu indies post potum saepe conturbas? Amplius cave ne venias? Qui venerandi patris imperio demisso capite, nil foeritatis ostendens, facti poenitens, erubescens ac amplius non reversus, aufugit. Erat Sancti Confessoris eo tempore victus, subcinericius ordeaceus panis, fabae sine oleo crudae; ad recreationem castaneae, quas suis manibus colligebat. Interim elapso anni spacio, Interim elapso anni spatio, quendam sanctae vitae monachum Albertum nomine, qui eius sanctitatis famam intelligens ad ipsum venit ut secum habitare permetteret, supplici prece poposcit; in suo comitatu suscepit. Tanta erat poenitentia eius quod semel comedebat in die; sero in nuda humo aliquantulum sopori datus, surgens ante crucem quam habebat in cellula, usque ad ortum solis, ut lapis immobilis genibus flexis orationi vacabat; die operi et disciplinis insistebat. Duobus autem annis elapsis, per omnes regiones, ac provincias Sancti Patris increbescente fama, quod virorum et mulierum ingens ad eum multitudo currebat, inter quos quidam fuerunt sacerdotes saeculares, qui sub eius magisterio se ad Dei servitium mancipari ac sacris disciplinis cupiebant institui. Et sub custodia Dei viri

later Marginal:

Capitur ab his qui furore insequuntur

Edificat casulam quae hodie videtur in Virginis Monte et Poenitentia vocatur

Corpus Ioannis adhuc miracula facit, daemones ab oppressis expellit in Virginis Monte

Miraculum de urso fontem perturbante.

S. Albertum in discipulum accipit.

//

normam sancte vivendi quaerentes, subiiciuntur. Praece monitisque patris, Divi Apostoli vitam sequentis, et doctrinam, ut nemo manducat nisi laboret, victum et quod pauperibus erogarent suis manibus laborantes compararent. Cuius salutare consilium ac vitae statutum brevi tenentes presbyteri, Antiqui hostis suggerente malitia, se sacerdotes esse dicebant divinis horis, ac missarum obsequiis ordinatos, libros, sacerdotalia vestes, Ecclesiam aedificari, ut divinis servirent officiis, et non ut rusticos exercere, poscebant. Quorum desiderium volens implere, ut mentis tranquillitatem a contemplationis officio non revocarent.

DE EDIFICATIONE SACRI MONASTERII

Montis Virginis de monte a Sancto Guilielmo, et miraculis ibi factis

Post modicum temporis Ecclesiam ad Dei ac Sanctissimae Virginis (a qua mons, qui Virgilianus a Mantuano Poeta qui ibi accola fuit dicebatur) nunc Virginianus, a Virgine nomine sumpto, vocatur, erigere curavit. Nam biduo (mirum dictu) orans, vix oratione finita magna undique hominum confluente caterva, statim calcaria magna, ut lapides essent in calcem soluti, facta est, propin quarum Civitatum auxiliis Ecclesia incipit erigi, at ipse labori non parcens, ut solebat, in omnibus Deo gratias agens, oratione facta, primus, subsequentibus sociis beatis Ioanne et Alberto, Ecclesiae fundamenta fodere incipit, et fossis primo lapidem signo crucis signatum projicit intus. At dum ipsa construeretur Ecclesia, quidam ligur Gualterius nomine advena, aridum brachium habens, arte architectonica non ignarus, dum assisteret, ad locum venit eundem, quem tamen exploratorem circumeuntem et inspicientem Domini Confessor interrogat. Num talis operis es artifex? Incipe operari. At ille brachium aridum ostendens, talia voce profudit. O beatissime Pater, libenter quod tua sanctitas praecipit obsecundarem obediens. Ecce in Liguria partibus architectonicae arte peritus, divina puniente iustitia

later Marginalia:

Ecclesiam Montis Virginis Sanctus erigit anno 1124 die decimo mensis Aprilis

//

te iustitia et meis peccatis exigentibus eam, dum turrim construerem cecidi, ita ut hoc brachium irremedica biliter perderem. Quod intuens Dei Confessor confisus in Domino ei lapidem ostendit dicens. In nomine Iesu sume lapidem illum et aedificio compone, qui vestigio parens, sospitatem recuperat. Lapidem laetus suscepit postea ab eo sacrae Religionis habitum indutus ac eius discipulus effectus, iugiter ipsius obsequabatur imperio. Paucis vero diebus Ecclesiam erecta fuit, de libris, paramentis indumentisque providere volens, cum socio Salernum adiit inde reversus Avellini Episcopum, ut ad Ecclesiae dedicationem dignaretur accedere, invitavit, dicens. Antistes colende, cum Ecclesia ad Dei et suae Matris Sanctissimae sit in monte erecta virgineo, die qua Deus spiritum suum igneis linguis misit in discipulos, sacrandam, ut benedicas humiliter poscens exoro. Ad quem Pontifex Ioannes nomine, in die qua cupis, paratus ad dedicationem accedam. A quo discedens, cum socio ad praedictum rediit montem. Proximo mense Maii, in die Pentecostes anno 1124. constituto die, Avellanensis Episcopus Dominus Ioannes religiosissimus, una cum clero suorum fratrum, ad Ecclesiae consecrationem venit; ad quam innumera gentis multitudo confluit. In qua erat mulier quae per annos septem muta silebat, ad Sancti tamen Confessoris interrogationem libera voce respondit. Quo viso miraculo omnes Guilielmum Sanctum praedicare coeperunt. Facta Ecclesiae dedicatione Episcopoque discesso, Monasterium, ut monachi cum cellulis commode starent, construere incipit; ipse primus incipiens, sequentibus sociis. Asello, qui erat in loco lapides, ligna et victualia ducebat, fatigato dum mitteretur ad pascua, Lupus invaditur; cuius dentibus dilaniatus incubum efficiebatur; quod Pater Sanctus intuens. in nomine Gloriosae Virginis lupo imperat quod opera quae per Asellum fierent ipse subiret; qui feritate reiecta, capite flexo viri Dei suscipit imperia; atque inceptum ab Asino opus usque ad eius vitae spatium, non sine aspicientium admiratione, libenter perficit, his multisque miraculis templum et Monasterium construxit et auxit. Inde constructo

later Marginalia:

Miraculum aridi brachii Gualterii
Die tertia Maii Ecclesia completa inspicitur
Prima dedicatio Ecclesiae Sanctae Mariae Virginis
Sanctus mutam facit loqui
Lupus pro asino facit servire

//

Monasterio Virginum, cum latis presbyteris montem et nonnullis monachis incolebant. Annis duobus elapsis praedictus Avellanensis Episcopus die quo Ecclesiam consecravit, visitaturus advenit; cui Pater Sanctus se, suos, Monasterium et omnia bona conferens, Episcopus sua pietate Monasterium, sacra, monachos ab omni onere (sicut in privilegio talis exemptionis anno 1126. in archivio Montis Virginis ad praesens, ut nuper facto servatur) nullo dioecetano iuri inscribi, cum consensu capituli sui, episcopali imperio sic fieri iussit. Quo die (ut nunc fit etiam) maxima populi multitudo confluens aurum, argentum et alia asportabat; quae Pater benigne suscipiens, necessaria monachis retinebat; alia pauperibus erogabat, quod praedicti presbyteri per habitus susceptionem monachi effecti, a cupida avaritia ducti, misericordia Dei diffusi, ne hoc faceret expostulabant; postea hoc fieri testabantur, ut populi ab hac liberalitate cessarent, ipsique inopia rerum tenerentur. At potius iidem praeter eorum opinionem evenire vident; dentibus infrendentes res eorum meritis acquisitas deserui et non pauperibus erogari, ante Christi Confessorem prorumpunt. Quod Dei famulus sentiens, dictis illos solatur amicis. Cognoscens autem se inter illos non posse proficere. Constituto Monasterio, collectis capitulariter monachis alacri facie publice dixit, Filii, non ego quaesivi vos, sed ipsi venistis ad me? Sacrae Religionis habitum, Ecclesiam et Monasterium aedificari quaesistis; quod potui feci. Deus est qui avibus non arantibus providet, quod eleemosinaliter habui, sic pauperibus erogavi. In omnibus Deo gratias agite, me post haec vobis curam non esse scio. Ideo alium superiorem Dominum Albertum mihi dilectum eligo. Pro norma Regulam primi Patris Benedicti tenete. Verum praesentes et subsequentes incolae, et peregrini, divino mihi revelante numine, carnis, ovorum et casei esum et conductionem hoc in loco abstinete perpetuo. Quod servatur ad praesens; ac comedere vel portare volentibus multa evenere miracula clara. Ac illis monasticam normam traditam et substitutum sibi relinquit Dominum Albertum, et quinque idiotas monachis sibi assumptis, in lacenum, iuxta Nuscanam Civita

later marginalia:

Exemptio facta ab Episcopo Abellinensi.
Sacerdotum murmuratio.
Primus Abbas Guilielmus.
Secundus Abbas loco eligitur D. Albertus nomine.
Regulam diui Benedicti pro norma tradit.
Esus carnis, ovorum, & casei prohibet cum suis.

//

Solebat Dei famulus divi Caesarii saepissime templum adire, quod quidam Adam, frequentini Episcopi licentia, construxerat; a quo non satis longe iacebat ingens sepulcri saxum, in quodam agro repertum, quod quinis bobus nequaquam moveri poterat. Id videns subsistit; ut eius moris erat, semper hilari vultu discentis quibus bobus, duos percutiens baculo imperat ire, ii lapidem, qui usque ad hunc diem in fronte templi cernitur, mira facilitate transtulerunt Hunc Lacenum montem vir Sanctus incolens, sibi, fugientibus aliis, focus singula tignia erexit; focus ob frigoris asperitatem, non multo post ab eo discesserunt, redeunt ad locum unde venerant. Ipse sic humano solatio destitutus, vulsis radicibus herbis vescebatur. Et dum contemplationi vacaret, Beatus Ioannes, quem supra meminimus, cum eo habitaturus ad illum accessit; cum quo pie aliquantulum vivens, noctu diuque ad contemplationis studium, laborem sanctaque colloquia incumberebat. Quodam die, dum unanimiter orarent, Dominus in forma qua crucem passus est apparuit eis dicens. Si pro aliis passus sum, et vos pati necesse est. Hoc mando vobis: hinc abcedite; mihi Ioannem in Oriente et Guilielmum in Occidente servire oportet. Ad dum viri Dei discedendi facerent moram, tuguriolum in quo ambo manebant et omnia alia aspiciunt igne cremari; sic manifeste comprehendentes se Dei iussu illic amplius manere non posse. Itinere itaque arrepto, ad Cuneatum veniunt montem, et in cellula quadam ab eis constructa per paucos dies manserunt. Postea Sanctus Ioannes, a Sancto Guilielmo monastico habitu sumpto, non sine lacrimis a Dei viro discedens, petens benedictionem, post amborum sanctissimos amplexus (ut alter alterum precibus iuvarent dicentes), solus a solo veniam obtinens, in Garganum secessit montem. Ubi monasterio a se constructo, ingenti numero sociorum, ad extremum vitae diem permansit in servitio Dei. Ad vero Sanctum Guilielmum in Cuneato permanente monte visendum et audiendum e longinquo magna hominum multitudo currebat. Inter quos quidam Beneventanus civis, eius familiaris, desiderio sanandae uxoris ad Sancti pedes se abiiciens, suum desiderium aperit. Cui

later Marginalia:

De miraculis factis post discessum à Virginis Monte.

Miraculum de lapide duobus bobus vecto.

Ad Montem Lacenum venit.

Secunda apparitio Domini in ea forma qua passus est mortem.

Prodigium.

S. Ioannes eius discipulus in Gargano Monasterium maximum erigit.

In Cuneato montem manet Sanctus Guilielmus.

//

Dei famulus Februeni ad eius domum se accessurum et coniugem curaturum est pollicitus. Quadam die mane in crepusculo vir de uxoris incolumitate sollicitus eam visitans de salute interrogat. Mulier uxor laeta respondet, nocte superiori Sanctus Dei vir cum accensa candela, quam muro (ut vides, non consumitur ardens) affixit hic veniens, me a gravi morbo curavit. Ad audiendum eum comes Robertus nomine, ac tota regio cucurrerunt. Erat tunc perniciosus et arrogans grammaticista, qui coram comite de Sancto viro non cessabat detrahere, quod Guilielmus ut idiota, quid facere nescire. Die quadam (volente Deo) inter litteratum et idiotam incidit sermo, quo attritus et convictus Rixosi

grammaticus illo, ut confessus discedens atro dolore felle commotus, cum sicariorum impia manu. Beatum virum manentem verberibus in cellula maximis petiit. At Deus scelerum ultor illum pessimo languore percussit. Tota namque eius crura ita computruerunt, ut foetido odore nec propinquiore accederent; et in ea prolixè per biennium cruciatus occubuit. In eodem Cuneato monte manens quendam habebat hortulum, die quadam aprum illum in dies devastans, aspiciens, clamare coepit. ubi sunt hortuli custodes? et defensores? Ad cuius vocem subito duo lupi arreptis auribus adfuerunt, qui eum dentibus per aures caputum foras trahentes, illesum abire permiserunt; nec aper amplius ad hortulum est regressus. Eodem tempore habebat quidam lunaticam filiam, quam dum frequenter tanto periculo fatigari conspiceret, paterna pietate commotus. At Deum toto corde conversus, oravit. Deus, qui Sanctorum tuorum meritis glorificari non desinis, praesta et meritis gloriosi Confessoris tui Guilielmi salutem filiae meae largiri digneris. Puella sanata numquam, dum vixit, tale periculum sensit. Pater vero eius ad Guilielmum adiit, ac illi gratias agens habitum suae religionis humili corde quaesivit; quem vir Dei veste religionis induens, socium sibi adiunxit. Tunc etiam quidam vir nobilis villae Monti Cuneato adiacentis dominus, venandi studio ad ipsum montem accessit; unus de suis venatoribus daemonis furore impulsus temerarium pilum in Dei famuli caput iniecit. Quo vulnere impacto, diabolus saevientem et ad libitum

later Marginalia:

Miraculi maximum de muliere Beneuentana.

Grammaticum convincit.

Poena grammaticisae.

Hic mons est in territorio tricariae Civitatis, qui vulgo dicitur la Serra cognata in Basilicata.

Miraculum de sue vastante hortulum.

Puella lunatica meritis Sancti Guilielmi sanatur.

A venatoribus incutitur.

//

torquens invasit, quem frementem spumantemque cruentus concussit. Quem incussum, emictentem, socii comprehenderunt, conicientes, ac a daemone liberatum. Causa furoris cognita, idem nobilis homo, ligatis manibus ad Sanctum Dei virum perducì, iussit: precibus meritisque cuius ab eo exit daemon. Postmodum dioecesani auctoritate Pontificis, prece illius domini villae, ad honorem Sanctissimae Virginis templum et monasterium construere meminit. In quo monasterio innumeris monachis locatis, regulari norma statuta, abbatem relinquens, ad Monticuli territorium iuxta fluentia Aufidi ad vallem Consanam recessit. Ubi arbore quadam per unius spacium anni est pro tigurio usus est, ibique iterum apparuit Dominus, et ibi monialium, et virorum maximum aedificare monasterium iussit.

Appendix B – The Transformation Pipeline

This appendix documents the technical framework of the digital edition, ensuring the reproducibility of the research. Far from a mere supplement, the transformation pipeline is an extension of the scholarly argument: by exposing the source code and logic, the project ensures that every editorial decision is traceable and verifiable. In alignment with the principles of Open Digital Humanities, all native files are provided to allow the full regeneration of the HTML interface. This record serves as the edition's infrastructural blueprint, enabling researchers to inspect, replicate, or extend the existing model.

B.1 – TEI-XML Source (*AnalisiComparativa.xml* ¹)

This file serves as the single source of truth for the comparative corpus. It contains:

- TEI Header (Project Metadata): It hosts the full bibliographic description of both witnesses (the 13th-century manuscript and Renda's 1581 edition), informations regarding editorial responsibility, usage licenses, and the revision history of the digital file.
- Dual-Witness Encoding: Both texts are preserved within separate `<text>` elements under a single `<group>`, uniquely identified by `@xml:id`.
- Analytical Markup: Semantic segments (`<seg type="...">`) model the narrative functions, while `@corresp` attributes maintain alignment across witnesses.
- Structured Metadata: Centralized authority lists (`<listPerson>`, `<listPlace>`) manage entity linking.

B.2 – XSLT Stylesheet (*analisiComparativa.xsl* ²)

The stylesheet implements the transformation logic from TEI to HTML. It governs:

- Alignment Logic: Groups units by shared `@n` values using XSLT keys.
- Segment Rendering Rules: Processes `<seg>` elements according to analytical categories. Paratext Visualization: Separates marginalia from narrative flow.
- Metadata Extraction: Dynamically generates authority indices and header panels.
- Interactive Behavior: Embeds CSS and JavaScript functions (highlighting, scroll synchronization, map centering).

¹ <https://github.com/DEPMICHELLE/thesis-s-code/blob/main/AnalisiComparativa.xml>

² <https://github.com/DEPMICHELLE/thesis-s-code/blob/main/analisiComparativa.xsl>